

FEMININITY, TIME AND FEMINIST ART

CLARE JOHNSON

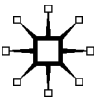
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For Mum and Dad

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Introduction

This book examines the tensions and connections between feminist politics and sexualized femininities through changing understandings of what constitutes 'critical' art practice. It emerged from a desire to reconcile my own fascination with artworks made by women for whom heterosexual femininity is something to be performed rather than refused, with my commitment to feminist politics. I am struck by my own identification with the visual pleasures of artworks that employ the rhetoric, if not, as I will argue, the values of woman-as-fetishized-image. It was also prompted by my experience of teaching practice-based art, media and design students, many of whom find no conflict between the performance of highly stylized femininities and an emerging interest in feminist politics, specifically the shaping of femininity through contemporary culture.

In recent years a significant interest in looking back at the women's movement of the 1970s has emerged in disciplines such as art history, cultural studies and women's studies. Forty years after the birth of the women's liberation movement there is renewed energy and urgency for rethinking the relationship between feminist art of the 1970s and contemporary artworks made by women. Major exhibitions such as WACK! Art and the Feminist Revolution (MOCA, Los Angeles, 2007), Global Feminisms (Brooklyn Museum, New York, 2007) and Elles (Centre Pompidou, Paris, 2009) have drawn attention to the connections and tensions between women artists of different generations, as has the recent writing of art historians such as Amelia Jones (2006), Laura Cottingham (2000) and Marsha Meskimmon (2007). Added to this is Lynn Hershman Leeson's critically acclaimed documentary film *!Women, Art, Revolution* (2010), which recounts the Feminist Art Movement of the 1970s through interviews with artists, historians and

curators as well as archival film footage from the time. There is, in short, a growing desire to remember this period of feminist art and examine its relevance for contemporary work.

Feminist artists and art historians are, after all, acutely aware of the dangers of forgetting, having worked so hard to write women back into the histories of art that routinely excluded them prior to this intervention. It is noteworthy that these forms of remembering have occurred at a point when cultural conservatism has taken hold as a reaction against hard-fought-for gains within the feminist movement of the 1970s and 1980s. Feminist critics have argued that since the 1990s neoliberal forms of femininity have become ingrained within Western cultures as the default norm. The cultural and political contexts of art production are markedly different, which impacts upon what kind of art is made and how it is received. Within the feminist art community this has fuelled a need to look back to a moment of activism sparked by the meeting of feminist politics and visual representation. *Femininity, Time and Feminist Art* contributes to this discussion by reading artworks made predominantly in the 1970s through contemporary practice rather than offering a chronology that leads up to the present day. This is not in order to smooth a historical path, nor primarily to argue that some artworks have been neglected in accounts of feminist art (although this is also the case), but to set up other connections between artworks made at different points in time. It addresses the possibility of a *feminist politics of femininity* that moves between art made in the UK and US during the 1970s and art made in Europe (predominantly in the UK) during the 1990s and beyond. This was a period marked by the inequalities of post-feminist media culture in which feminism was devalued, repudiated and characterized as an undesirable relic from the past. There is, therefore, a need to investigate what radical practice looks like in this context and what its relationship is to earlier precedents.

The politics of femininity

The concept of femininity is always contested and highly charged. It has also been instrumental in the construction of feminist art history. Substantive anthologies such as Norma Broude and Mary D. Garrard's *The Power of Feminist Art* (1994), which charts the history and legacy of American feminist art of the 1970s, consistently foreground works that aim to distance the viewer from femininity understood as a series of masculinized pleasures. Rozsika Parker and Griselda Pollock's earlier seminal collection *Framing Feminism: Art and the Women's Movement*

1970–1985 (1987) documents feminist art history in the UK and tells a particular story in which aesthetic pleasure is not accorded any positive potential for feminist politics. This approach was informed by the theories of avant-garde German theatre director, playwright and poet Bertolt Brecht, in particular the aspiration to raise the spectator's awareness of the illusions of the image through a strategy of distanciation. The artworks included in these anthologies are largely read as interrupting or transforming the seductive pleasures of femininity in its imaged form as a necessary move towards empowerment and raised consciousness of the production of woman as a commodity. This was indeed necessary during Western feminism's 'second wave' of the late 1960s to 1980s. The dialogue between art and feminism at this time enabled a critique of representation to take place with increased urgency and momentum. This critique has enabled contemporary women artists to explore the construction of femininity through the visual image in a way that would not have received attention, or at least critical acclaim within the artworld, had it not been for the necessary agitation of feminist artists working during the second wave. Far from belonging solely to the 1970s, feminism informs contemporary practice in a myriad of different ways some of which are explored in this book.

I have put artworks that positively engage with the pleasures of femininity at the heart of this book with the aim of questioning what counts as 'properly' feminist art. My intention is to examine the possibility that these artworks can produce something other than recuperation into a male imaginary, something unexpected that can only be articulated by moving beyond the limitations imposed by critical frameworks premised on resistance to aesthetic pleasure. Here I concur with Sue Tate who has argued in relation to female Pop artists that the emphasis on subversion in feminist art history comes at the expense of an exploration of women's complex relationship with mass culture and its production of woman as image (Tate, 2008, p. 182). My approach is to read femininity as an activity rather than a noun. It is not a 'thing' from which distance needs to be forged so much as a project that is taken up and performed by the artworks discussed throughout this book. This is not a position of compliance – there are indeed forms of femininity from which it is crucial to forge a distance necessary for survival – but an argument about the potential to re-orientate femininity from *within* its symbolic infrastructure. I ask whether feminist tactics can be imagined within what Pollock has called the 'space of femininity' opened up by the artworks, not in opposition to it (Pollock, 1996, p. 8). Rather than understanding the visual pleasure of femininity as critically devalued and in

need of transformation by a feminist politics assumed to be external to it, I consider the ways in which it is strategically reconfigured by the artworks discussed.

What these artworks share is the repetition of femininity, albeit for different purposes and in varying configurations. This includes the repetition of the trope of the female nude in Sam Taylor-Johnson's (formerly Taylor-Wood's) filmic portrait of David Beckham, which is the only artwork analysed in the book that does not have a woman as its subject (see Chapter 7). A space of potential critique is opened up by the repetition of femininity as an image that needs to be worked on and maintained, which resists a necessary division between pleasure and politics. The ongoing performative activity of femininity need not be over-determined by the idea of successfully repeating normative behaviours. As Angela Partington has argued, femininity can be productive of new meanings (Partington, 1987). By taking seriously feminine skills and knowledges of consumption, Partington opened up new avenues of discussion about visual pleasure in feminist art criticism. This was a challenge to the dominance of deconstructive strategies that pervaded British feminist art practice and criticism in the mid-1980s and is a springboard for my own interest in femininity as a form of productive work. Feminist deconstructions of femininity regard it as something imposed by a male imaginary, a concept sustained by oppressive structures of representation (Parker & Pollock, 1981; Mulvey, [1975] 1989). This form of critique remains a crucial component of the politics of representation. Folded into this, however, is the possibility that femininity may be productive both of and in itself. If performing femininity is a practice that works to reproduce its own effects (Butler, 1990), in the chapters that follow I ask if it is also a practice that can produce something else, an experience beyond the triangulation of meaning, language and sexuality that informed dominant feminist art critical discourses of the 1980s and which in turn framed the writing of feminist art's histories. I am interested in the porosity of femininity and feminism as practices and ask what is generated when one seeps into the other. Running through the chapters is the idea that femininity is fragile and marked by its failure and potential to collapse, which differentiates my approach from those who argue that the repetition of signs of femininity signals the necessary success of patriarchal forms of representation.

Throughout this book I use the notion of femininity-as-image to refer both to the commodification of women in representation, their exchange value in both an aesthetic and sexual economy, as well as

the stalling of time that turns the corporeal reality of a woman into a spectacle. Here the concepts of temporality and femininity connect in the stasis of the image. Femininity-as-image is both a description of the condition of stasis and a denaturalization of the myth that women are aligned with spectacle in the sense that Guy Debord used the term in 1967 to describe a society enmeshed with commodification and appearance (Debord, 1984). The term femininity-as-image implies that it can be otherwise. Femininity is formed in and through representation, which detaches it from the idea of essence or a natural mode of being. What is at stake is the extent to which femininity-as-image is achieved or failed in artworks that operate within its repertoire of forms and gestures.

Thinking with the artworks

It is a central concern of this project to argue for the potential of artworks to generate new ways to think about sexual politics. Each chapter, therefore, leads with a reading of one or more artworks and overall the book is led by the intensities and peculiarities of art practice. The process of developing my own visual archive has, from the early stages of this project, been inextricably linked to my desire to read the pleasures of particular artworks, usually coded as male and heterosexual, as something other than a sign of narcissism or uncritical compliance with a regime of representation that does not serve women's interests. To name an archive is a difficult task because it can suggest a natural grouping of a particular 'type' of art, the logic of which can be found in formal characteristics. My archive is a more provisional gathering of artworks some of which have, at various points in time, been contentious for feminism. Not always comfortable for feminist art history, and sometimes excluded from it altogether, these artworks test not only the boundaries of the feminist canon, but the relevance of this concept for a practice that aims to destabilize patriarchal structures of thought. I do not, therefore, aim to propose a better, more accurate or even more inclusive canon of feminist art, but to open up new and productive alliances. Neither do I offer the artworks as exemplars of feminist art. In many ways some of them remain problematic from this point of view. I do, however, suggest that they are actively engaged with the relationship between sexual politics and femininity-as-image in ways that agitate our understanding of feminist art, what is included or excluded and why.

The question of which types of work 'count' as feminist and which remain outside the parameters of gender politics was reignited by

WACK!, curated by Cornelia Butler in 2007. This exhibition aimed to internationalize the remit of feminist art beyond the usual Anglo-American examples to include a geographically and socio-politically diverse range of artists. It acknowledged the possibility of simultaneous feminisms and a desire to disassemble the received canon of feminist art. This involved the inclusion of artists who may not identify with feminism, but whose work can nevertheless engage our sense of politics. These developments have informed my own project, in particular a willingness to include artworks that often fall outside the parameters of acceptable feminism. I have not, however, included a global constellation of artists. Instead I revisit well-known Western practitioners to re-imagine their genealogical connections in the light of the loosening of the canon that WACK!, amongst other exhibitions and critical approaches, has instigated.

I have selected artworks that create friction between the pleasurable display of sexualized femininity and the production of feminist thought. In Chapter 3, for example, I discuss Tracey Emin's photographic piece *I've Got It All* (2000), which combines sexual and aesthetic commodification with a disturbing image of maternal loss. Chapter 7 includes a reading of Vanessa Beecroft's filmed performance *VB29* (1997). This film is overt in its extreme objectification of a woman who poses as pure spectacle, but strangely compelling in its slowing of the image, which refuses to rest as a still. What these works share is an ambiguity that disrupts any clear separation of femininity and feminism. Furthermore, this ambiguity is derived from the skills of performing femininity, which enable the repetition, but also the exaggeration or distortion of what is expected. Other recent works in my archive include Elizabeth Manchester's photographic piece *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002), Tracey Emin's short film *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995) and Sam Taylor-Johnson's photographic piece *Soliloquy III* (1998). My proposition is that each of these works provokes something irreducible to (and in addition to) fetishization by a male imaginary. This occurs not despite the overt display of femininity, which is differently configured in each of the artworks, but is enabled by it.

The engagement with femininity in these contemporary works resonates, sometimes unexpectedly, with earlier works that also treat sexualized femininity as something to be performed. Thus, my archive includes a number of artworks made during or prior to a second-wave feminist consciousness. The treatment of femininity takes a number of forms, such as the notion of an enduring project in Eleanor Antin's photographic series entitled *Carving: A Traditional*

Sculpture (1972) and a vocabulary of mimicked gestures in Hannah Wilke's *Starification Object Series* (1974–1975), both of which share the photographic grid formation but produce a different relationship of femininity to pleasure. Carolee Schneemann's *Interior Scroll* (1975) confronts its viewer with woman both as authorial subject and fetishized object: artist and model, maternal figure and desiring woman. The numerous positions activated by the work suggest a multi-faceted relationship with time and presence. Here the autonomous artist–subject clashes with the spectacular model-object in the temporality of the work, and the subjectivity of the artist unfolds in the embodied time of the performance. What connects the artworks that form my archive is, therefore, not a shared series of formal characteristics, but a sense of ambiguity that derives from the layering of differently performed femininities.

My approach raises a methodological question about the purpose of constructing readings of artworks when such works are considered not as objects with inherent properties, but relational forms of becoming, not as representations but as practices. In producing readings my intention is not to arrive back at an *a priori* object, despite being initiated by the textual specificity of the work. The notions of textuality and artwork as practice arise from different traditions of analysis, but there is no reason to assume that textuality is not contingent. It is possible to be interested in the textual possibilities of an artwork without being tied to the notion of representation. A reading of an artwork can lead to a series of ideas not rooted or anchored in the text but liberated by it; ideas that cannot be imagined without the artwork but that are not visible within it at the level of decoding. Thus, my readings are not attempts to think *about* artworks so much as attempts to think *with* them. The concentration on embodiment and inter-subjectivity in feminist art history of the 1990s bears witness to the idea that feminist readings do not always need to be understood as establishing an already recognizable form of critique, but can instead become opportunities to imagine the previously unthought in collaboration with the viewer (Betterton, 1996; Jones, 1998). This requires the artwork to be conceptualized as an inter-subjective process and not as the 'capitalized objects of phallocentric discourse (familiar in the present mainstream art world), a discourse which closes down intersubjectivity by reducing the other subject to object status' (Robinson, 2006, p. 200). Feminist readings are at their most powerful when they treat the artwork as a fellow subject and relinquish the critic from the tyranny of certainty, the need to 'explain' the work or secure its meaning.

Inter-generational affinities

The artworks around which the arguments in this book pivot are drawn from two historical moments, but my aim is not to present a chronology of feminist art from the nascent stages of second-wave feminism to the present day. Instead my concern is with inter-generational dialogues between women artists who have engaged and often struggled with the relationship between feminism and femininity. The idea of generation can be understood not in its traditional sense of chronology, one generation following another, but as what Julia Kristeva calls 'a signifying space, a both corporeal and desiring mental space' (1981, p. 33). When Kristeva speaks of a third generation of women forming in Europe she does not mean another overarching feminist movement. Instead she champions the idea of a third generation (and third attitude) existing in parallel to previous generations in the same historical time. In Kristeva's formulation, different generations can be understood as interwoven rather than running in succession, which is an aid to my thinking about what it means to operate in an inter-generational space.[1] This approach involves a dual conceptualization of time as both constitutive of the concept of femininity and as historical narrative.

I am arguing that femininity can be understood as a relationship to time. Hence the artworks share a sense of temporal play in the formation of femininity. Despite profound differences in political intent and art historical context, the key artworks that I focus on produce an understanding of time as gendered in the very practice of art making as well as in the performance of femininity. It is not just that the media used – primarily film, photography and performance – lend themselves to this, but that the artworks actively challenge temporal understandings of femininity as, for example, an aspiration to a future state of satisfaction that never arrives. It is by using culturally devalued skills associated with consumption, such as trying on clothes or dancing, that the artworks come into being, thus collapsing the distinction that Andreas Huyssen (1986) has articulated between masculinized production (making art) and feminized consumption.

Nowhere is this more striking than in Hannah Wilke's photographic series *Super-T-Art* (1974) in which the artist enacts a striptease through which she transforms herself from a robed woman into the crucified figure of Christ.[2] Originally performed live at an event called 'Soup and Tart' held at The Kitchen, New York in 1974, Wilke recreated *Hannah Wilke Super-T-Art* as a photographic series. This formed one of a range of works made during the mid-1970s that Wilke referred to as her

'performalist self-portraits' (Jones, 1998, p. 154). In Chapters 4 and 5 I explore another of these works, *Starification Object Series*, which shares with *Super-T-Art* the reference to image sequencing although not, as I will argue, the developmental rhythm of striptease. In *Super-T-Art* the developmental transformation takes place using a white tablecloth, which, in the process of rearrangement, takes the form of a robe secured over one shoulder, a wrap worn over the breasts as one might wear a towel, and a device for sexual teasing, before finally being used as a loincloth. It is her skill at reproducing the signs of an embodied sexualized object that, ironically, enables Wilke to transform herself into a representation of a transcendental subject. By wrapping, concealing, binding, tying, folding and knotting, Wilke works the material of domestic display into a symbol of autonomy. The poses and gestures of sexualized femininity generate the work necessary to perform a kind of euphoric crucifixion, the ecstasy of religious enlightenment cast in relation to the pleasures of heterosexual femininity. The patriarchal structure of religion is here articulated as a performance, amenable to change and thoroughly embodied.

The idea of femininity as a series of skills that can be worked to produce something else is a theme also explored by Vanessa Beecroft in a performance entitled *VB35*, which was staged at the Guggenheim Museum in New York in 1998. In this performance Beecroft dressed a series of models in designer bikinis and spike heels, leaving some naked except for shoes with straps that wrap around the lower leg. The semi-choreographed performance lasted for several hours during which time the models did not speak. Spectators who stayed the distance observed changes to the composition of the *tableau vivant* as the models tired and adjusted their position. Here the achievement of this particular version of femininity can only ever be temporary because it requires enduring work. I discuss Beecroft's work in more detail in Chapter 7. However, this preliminary consideration of *VB35* alongside *Hannah Wilke Super-T-Art* illuminates a shared understanding of the signs of sexualized femininity as materials used both in the construction of femininity and in the making of art. In both artworks shoes are used to invoke mobility between live performance and sculpture. In *VB35* spike-heeled, open-toed shoes act as pedestals, the spike of the heel supporting the body as if it is an object of museum display. As time passes, however, the sign value of the shoes changes as the models move between achieved and faltering femininity. Shoes both support the women as sculptural objects of display and have to be endured in the reality of a lengthy live performance. The movement between sculptural form and live

performance in *VB35*, enabled partly by the use of shoes, resists any easy identification with the models as reproducing only a predictable immanence to their own image.

Wilke presents herself as a sculpture by standing on a pedestal, an effect further enhanced by her heeled and open-toed shoes. The photographic images of *Super-T-Art* make me wonder how the artist negotiated the tablecloth whilst wearing high heels and whether the movements between these frames were awkward or smooth. Did the shoes get in the way as Wilke stepped through the gathered fabric? Were they obstacles to her representation of herself as Christ or was any sense of difficulty offset by the elevation such shoes offer and the bodily posture they create? Thinking about the relation of image to endurance in Beecroft's work enables me to read Wilke's wearing of shoes in *Super-T-Art* as a possibly precarious transformation. The certainty of her display of femininity as confident and practiced to the point of unthinking behaviour is fractured by the possibility of collapse. In reading against the grain of art historical chronology (through Beecroft to Wilke) different connections between femininity, gesture and temporality can be put into play. Wilke's performance photographs are, therefore, differently charged by reading the friction that Beecroft's work creates between wilting and achieved femininity. It is this inter-generational dimension that I hope to set in motion throughout this book. My premise is that working across and between generations can both historicize recent art and reinvigorate our understanding of earlier art practices in a way that aids, rather than obscures, an appreciation of the contexts in which they were made. Far from being ahistorical this approach suggests alternative historical affinities.

The connection I posit between Wilke and Beecroft cannot be arrived at by solely employing a linear, chronological model such as matrilineage, despite the many benefits of constructing a heritage of female artists. Matrilineage is important because it establishes links between women artists in response to the overwhelming tendency to situate the significance of female artists and theorists in relation to male forebears. Mira Schor offers a number of examples of this in an article on the prevalence of patrilineage (1991). One of the most pertinent and striking instances is a review of a Robert Morris exhibition written by Donald Kuspit for *Artforum* magazine in 1989. Kuspit discussed works such as *House of the Vetti* (1983), which is sculpted from folds of pink felt forming a central narrow opening. Despite clear references to the work of Hannah Wilke and other women artists who produced 'labial' sculptures in the 1970s, no mention is made of this precedent. In her discussion of the sculptural work of Rachel Whiteread, Lisa Tickner comments on

the artist's response to the search for founding, originary fathers within the artworld. Tickner describes Whiteread's 1995 sculpture *Untitled (One Hundred Spaces),* which explicitly borrows from the treatment of negative space in Bruce Nauman's *Space Under My Steel Chair* (1965–1968), as 'almost a parody of the assumption that women elaborate, colour, and interpret, rather than originate structure and form' (2006, p. 92–93). Whiteread's use of coloured resin, rather than Nauman's concrete, lends the work a playful knowingness. Furthermore, she positions her 100 resin units in a grid formation, which references the language of minimalism without the accompanying austerity. This tactic is discussed further in Chapter 2 in relation to Elizabeth Manchester's photographic work *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002).

At stake is a model of art history that emphasizes the back and forth of matrilineal resonance, not an unbroken line. In place of patriarchal notions of precedence and influence it is possible to imagine a rhizomatic approach in which the connections between women artists of different generations are heterogeneous, conflicting, overlapping, non-sequential and multi-dimensional. In *A Thousand Plateaus* Deleuze and Guattari write about the rhizome as a non-hierarchical network of connectivity spreading out in numerous directions as opposed to a tree-like structure formed by chronological lines of descent (1999, pp. 3–26). It is not goal orientated and does not involve the search for causal origins or final destinations. A rhizomatic approach is nomadic and involves multiple entry and exit points. As a model of culture this emphasis on the map as a series of multiplying connections without any origin chimes with what Marsha Meskimmon calls 'chronology through cartography'. In response to the geographically diverse array of artists exhibited at WACK! Meskimmon signals a spatialized rather than linear understanding of art history. Her interest is in 'networks of relation, processes of exchange, and affinities of meaning', rather than influences or origins (2007, p. 324).[3] This informs my own interest in the layered temporalities of the artworks discussed throughout this book. Attunement to this aspect of the artworks' production and consumption can animate a set of relations between feminist politics, female subjectivity and art practice that exceeds those enabled by the historical fixity of feminist canon formation. Furthermore, an emphasis on non-hierarchical connectivity enables different questions to be asked about women's art. A linear approach might lead me to ask whether or not the contemporary artists discussed in this book have fulfilled the legacy of second-wave feminist practice. However, a cartographic model enables me to examine a range of orientations towards it.

I am acutely aware that my approach has its own temporality, which can be read as a displacement of earlier models. Inter-generational ways of thinking with artworks does involve a challenge to matrilineal models, but it does not aim to replace them. The advances made by matrilineal approaches to women's art history enable others to work in the space that this opens up. My aim is, therefore, inter-generational but not post-generational. By thinking with the artworks and pausing over connections between artworks made at different historical moments it is possible to see how femininity has been cast (sometimes literally) in temporal terms. With this in mind each chapter analyses one or more concepts of time.

Chapter 1 pivots around my reading of Tracey Emin's short film *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995). I read Emin's film in the context of feminist responses to the idea of post-feminism, which is itself a temporal concept suggesting a time after feminism. I explore Emin's relationship to this context and argue that the sexual politics of her work are put into play by the affective character of the film itself, including her enjoyment of femininity. More specifically I question the displacement logic that is built in to the notion of post-feminism and challenge the attempted repudiation of sexual politics, in relation to which women artists of different generations are set apart from one another. In addition to the temporality of the post-feminist context in which Emin made her film the chapter argues for two approaches to time that arise from my reading of the work itself. The first is the way in which Emin renegotiates the meaning that disco music holds for her across different time periods. The second is her narrative of escape from the past.

Chapter 2 develops my critique of the generational polarization implicit in the notion of post-feminism through an analysis of femininity as an embodied relationship to time. Here I look at the inter-generational relationship between two photographic works: Eleanor Antin's *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* (1972) and Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002). My reading of the dialogue between these two artworks, which are distinct in terms of the political and cultural climate of their production, leads to a series of observations about the gendering of time. These include understanding femininity as a future-oriented project characterized by failure; dialogue between previous feminist strategies and present-day contexts for art production; femininity as a continual process of 'becoming'; and the fantasy of a perpetual present in post-feminist discourses. Towards the end of the chapter I introduce the work of Vanessa Beecroft, which is discussed further in Chapter 7, to explore the relation of femininity to forms of time that are seemingly,

but not actually, economically unproductive. What emerges is a complexity of tenses performed by the artworks, which offers an alternative to generational separation.

The primary concept of time explored in Chapter 3 draws on Mieke Bal's notion of 'preposterous history' in which quotations of past practices become the source material through which the chronologically precedent work can be read (Bal, 1999). Using this method, the chapter explores the issues of maternal desire, loss and control by reading Carolee Schneemann's performance *Interior Scroll* (1975) through Tracey Emin's photographic print *I've Got It All* (2000). I consider Schneemann's embodiment of female sexuality and maternal desire through Emin's recurrent visualizations of sexuality and maternal loss. Both artists refuse to disengage from the pleasures (and displeasures) of sexualized femininity and here I consider the different contexts within which this issue has been handled in each artwork. Understanding Schneemann's performance through Emin's photograph leads me to reflect on the relationship between mediation and 'liveness' in *Interior Scroll*. My proposition is that the inter-generational dialogue between the two artists generates thoughts and ideas that are irreducible to the individual works.

Chapters 4 and 5 both revolve around a work by Hannah Wilke called *Starification Object Series* (1974–1975). This work is an installation, which includes a photographic series and chewing gum sculptures, but also included a performance. I have devoted a significant amount of space to Wilke's practice partly because her relevance to contemporary artists working with femininity-as-image, pleasure and embodiment warrants more attention than it has so far received. I have deliberately placed these chapters in the middle of the book so that they can be read through the discussion of embodiment and time outlined in preceding chapters. Chapter 4 maps the diverse ways in which Wilke's photographic work of the mid-1970s has been critically positioned and argues for her importance to feminist art history. The key notion of time explored here is repetition, which is analysed through Wilke's unfaithful or partial repetition of the codes of femininity-as-image. The chapter includes some reflections on feminist history, specifically how Wilke's work of this period can impact upon the way feminism tells its own story. Chapter 5 develops the concept of unfaithful repetition further by pursuing a reading of Wilke's work that is informed by Luce Irigaray's idea of critical mimicry (1985a). This adds a spatial dimension to the discussion of repetition in which Wilke occupies multiple spaces in relation to her image. Towards the end of the chapter I consider

the implications for contemporary practice by reading a performance/installation by Angela Ellsworth and Tina Takemoto through the conceptual territory of artifice, masquerade and mimicry.

The emphasis on artifice and screen culture in Wilke's *Starification Object Series* leads in Chapter 6 to a discussion of Sam Taylor-Johnson's *Soliloquy III* (1998), which is a photographic work based on Velásquez's *Rokeby Venus* (1647–1651). Time is elongated in Taylor-Johnson's depiction of a reclining Venus and her inner thoughts, so my approach to time in this chapter is the prolonged present tense of the work. I ask whether this gives rise to new forms of criticality that emerge from within the smooth surfaces of contemporary culture.

The question of criticality is extended in Chapter 7. Here I focus on two films by contemporary artists, both of whom have consciously traversed the increasingly thin divide between art and pop culture: Vanessa Beecroft's *VB29* (1997) and another work by Sam Taylor-Johnson called *David* (2004). My interest in these films is their existence between the static photographic image and the movement of film. I want to occupy the near-stillness they generate and understand what their restlessness can offer a feminist sensibility.

My hope for the reader is that putting these particular artworks in dialogue with each other generates some electricity with which to think about femininity, time, criticality and feminist art history.

1

Fantasies of Adventure, Escape and Return: Tracey Emin's *Why I Never Became a Dancer*

In this chapter I analyse Tracey Emin's short film *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995) and argue for its importance to a feminist art history that takes time as its principal concept. My intention is to explore how Emin's feminism is articulated through the manipulation of time and to consider how her work has been critically positioned in relation to feminist art of the 1970s and 1980s. By starting this book with an analysis of a film by Emin I wish to signal that my approach is not chronological. It does not follow a developmental path of precedents and influences that lead up to Emin's work, but takes her provocative expressions of desire, trauma and memory as a starting point for feminist art history. It is to start where students of visual culture often begin their journey into sexual politics, with a visual practice that speaks to them about something that matters.

In *Why I Never Became a Dancer* Emin reflects on the experience of being humiliated at a dancing competition in the late 1970s from the position of her adult self in the 1990s. The film is a useful entry point to the central theme of this book because it explores and plays with the differences between the 1970s and 1990s including the different cultural, social and sexual contexts in which humiliations are experienced. There are in fact three different time periods at play in the analysis that follows: memories of the late 1970s in which the story is set, the context of the film's production in the mid-1990s, and the present day of my encounter with it. The triangulation of these time periods enables a fresh analysis of the connections and tensions between female sexuality, femininity and feminist politics. The visualization of memory and ability to imagine a better future free of humiliation connect temporality to sexual politics in the narrative of *Why I Never Became a Dancer.* Emin made this film at a time when post-feminist representations of women were becoming

increasingly widespread. The idea of post, meaning 'after', feminism has met with a fierce response from feminist critics and this provides the main critical framework for the chapter. Post-feminism is itself an aggressively temporal idea, which suggests the desire to move on from a rights movement erroneously consigned to the past. In the context of this rhetorical and contextual notion of a past tense of feminism, I focus on two specific temporal strategies within the film through which the relationship between Emin's femininity and feminism is articulated: the renegotiation of meanings across time and the narrative of escape from the past.

Fragile conservatism

To write about Emin over ten years into the new millennium presents both opportunities and challenges. There is now a plethora of material by and about the artist, which provides a rich resource to work with. Through a combination of major exhibitions, numerous appearances on television and radio, contributions to newspapers and celebrity connections Emin's position as a doyenne of the contemporary British art scene is secured. On the other hand, the artist's acceptance of this position is a far cry from her earlier days spent challenging the expectations and attitudes of the art establishment. One such venture was her collaboration with Sarah Lucas with whom she opened The Shop on Bethnal Green Road in London in 1993. The artists sold a variety of handmade items in The Shop, which existed outside the institutional limitations of the artworld and commented playfully on its system of reverence for celebrated artists. Examples included Damien Hirst ashtrays and Mark Rothko comfort blankets. Four years later Emin famously appeared drunk on television during a live Channel 4 discussion show after the awarding of the Turner Prize in 1997. It was an irreverent display of dis-identification from the artworld, which introduced Emin to the wider public as either a refreshing antidote to artworld pomposity or an embarrassing interloper without the required level of seriousness and self-control. She was, however, brought back into the fold when two years later she was shortlisted for the Turner Prize with her installation *My Bed* (1998). In 2007, a decade after her infamous appearance on TV, Emin was made a Royal Academician and awarded honorary doctorates from the University of Kent, London Metropolitan University and the Royal College of Art where she is now Professor of Drawing. By the time her 2011 survey exhibition 'Love Is What You Want' opened at the Hayward Gallery in London, she had publicly supported the British Conservative party in the 2010 general election and in an interview with John Humphries on BBC Radio 4's Today programme

acknowledged without regret that she is now part of the art establishment (16 May 2011). Talking to British TV and radio presenter Andrew Marr in May 2012 Emin claimed that the establishment is now based on meritocracy rather than class (Andrew Marr Show, BBC1).

This move from margin to centre presents a challenge to those, myself included, who want to argue for the feminist, progressive potential of Emin's practice. Feminist art has articulated the material, sexual and cultural inequities that women face with a view to developing radical, subversive and oppositional strategies. So, how can feminist art historians and critics endorse an artist who has embraced the establishment and whose own politics are at odds with the trajectory of left-wing thought that informs dominant narratives of feminist art? One answer lies in Emin's uneven and contradictory relationship to the art establishment. In 2008, for example, she took up the invitation of a retrospective at the Scottish Gallery of Modern Art yet retained a resistant and playful approach to this most conservative of cultural forms. The retrospective is an active form of remembering, which simultaneously produces and celebrates an artist's legacy. However, the tradition of the retrospective and the memory-work of Emin's oeuvre are differently gendered. Whereas the retrospective is an art historical form used to secure the dominance of patrilineal control and influence emanating from a celebrated individual, Emin's mediated memories of pain, pleasure, disappointment, humiliation and trauma construct a sense of fragility that beckons the experiences of the women who are drawn to the work. It is as though Emin relishes the opportunity to have the legitimation of a retrospective bestowed upon her so that she can play with the narration of gendered memory (sexual and artistic) that her work has always focused on. If Emin appears to occupy the centre ground she cannot resist the temptation to test its boundaries. It is one of this book's arguments that in an understandable rush to avoid appearing to drift to the right art critics and historians are in danger of missing the critical nuances of artworks produced by commercially successful artists, whose political affiliations may not chime with their own. In Emin's case the critical potential of her art is connected to her manipulation of time in the forms of memory, futurity and endurance. These concepts find some of their most powerful expressions in her short films.

The renegotiation of meanings over time

Shot on Super 8 and running at just under seven minutes, *Why I Never Became a Dancer* features Emin narrating the story of her own adolescent

experiences as a young teenager growing up in Margate in the late 1970s. It has been described as a video-poem, which captures something of its affective rhythm and intensity of feeling (Smith, 2011, p. 29). The imagery in the early part of the film is faded and amateur, which gives it a nostalgic tone. Emin's voice is heard over footage of a seaside town and describes her early experiences of under-age sex against the backdrop of a rundown landscape.

> Sex was something simple
> You'd go to a pub – walk home
> Have fish and chips – then sex
> On the beach
> Down alleys

Sex is initially described as an empowering adventure, something that made her feel free and alive. Emin then describes her love of dancing and how this replaced sex as a form of bodily pleasure:

> I stopped shagging
> But I was still flesh
> And I thought with my body
> But now it was different
> It was me and dancing
> (Emin, *Why I Never Became a Dancer*, 1995)

The story becomes increasingly disturbing as Emin explains her participation in a disco dancing competition. During her performance she is taunted by men with whom she has had casual sex, who chant 'slag' until she runs off the dance floor knowing that she has lost the competition, vowing to leave Margate for a better life. I read it as a story about the desire to access a different sexual and material economy, which is represented by the possibility of success at the disco dancing competition. The final part of the film shows Emin as an adult woman, smiling and dancing to Sylvester's disco hit *You Make Me Feel (Mighty Real)* (see figure 1.1). She recites the names of the offending men and tells them that 'this one's for you' in a gesture of defiance and embodied pleasure. In a triumphant riposte she demonstrates that as an adult she is still 'thinking with her body' and enjoying it. Here the camera is positioned as if it is held by someone dancing with her, circling in a way that visually connects this scene to the continual camera movement and visual restlessness that characterizes the earlier part of the film. We are invited to share in her



Figure 1.1 Tracey Emin, *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995), single-channel projection with sound, shot on Super 8, 6 minutes, 30 seconds
Source: © Tracey Emin. All rights reserved, DACS 2013.

sense of embodied empowerment as she articulates the political charge of her personal story.

It is significant that Emin does not offer us a visual image of the power relations inscribed on to her body in the original dancing competition. She reserves this for her moment of glory when, for the first time, we see her dance. Emin's level of control over her visual availability is in stark contrast to the story of her former sexual availability. Her adult self tightly controls the representation of the younger Emin as playing truant from school, having sex in public places and living a life outside institutional control. By withholding and then allowing our gaze Emin turns the sexual economy, through which the insults that she recounts have meaning, into an affective economy, which opens up a range of feelings and alignments with the film: guilt, shame, pleasure, empowerment, depending upon where you position yourself in relation to the narrative. This is enabled by Emin's renegotiation of the meaning that Sylvester's track represents for her over time.

You Make Me Feel (Mighty Real) was released in 1978, which is the same year as the dancing competition referred to in the film, thus enabling a recreation of the scene through Emin's adult eyes. The irony of the scenario in 1970s Margate is that *You Make Me Feel* was interpreted by some as a gay anthem, accompanied by a video in which Sylvester appeared in full drag. The emergence of a widespread gay culture in the intervening years offers the adult Emin an opportunity to make a subtle mockery of the aggressive masculinity that jeered her off stage as a teenager. The mainstreaming of disco opened up audiences within both the gay and straight communities who have appropriated its meanings. For Emin, dancing to Sylvester's track in the mid-1990s puts into effect a set of meanings quite different from those she experienced at the competition in the late 1970s. Part of her triumph is in successfully enacting the discrepancy between the classed and gendered meanings that disco music represents across this period of time, such that the dance floor becomes a site of initially failed and then achieved femininity. In 1978 she was positioned by those who taunted her as sexually available, undisciplined, vulgar and in excess of the restraint required of feminine conduct. Her lack of respectability can be understood through Beverly Skeggs' work on class and gender (Skeggs, 1997). In her influential ethnographic study of white working-class women in the North-West of England, Skeggs raised awareness of the significance of respectability as a signifier of class. Noting that it is primarily an issue for those deemed not to have it, Skeggs identifies the aspirational aspect of middle-class respectability on the part of those positioned as tainted, pathological and without boundaries or control. However, as an artist working in the mid-1990s Emin exerts a great deal of control over her image and enjoys the benefits of more recently acquired cultural capital. She appears at ease with herself and confident in her work. There is a long history of judgements about female respectability being articulated within the visual image, both within art history and popular culture. In *Why I Never Became a Dancer* Emin takes hold of this and reworks her earlier subjection to moral judgement.

By providing an authorial voiceover to images of a past that is both romanticized and troubling Emin interweaves her experience of late-1970s Margate with her political consciousness in the mid-1990s. The overlaying of imagery from one period of time with a voiceover from another suggests an overlapping approach to memory, working across and between two historical moments. However, sound and image are treated differently in relation to time. Emin's voiceover is certain and suggests no fading of memory or doubt in the story. She recalls the

names of the men and exactly how they made her feel. This contrasts with the fragility of the imagery, which is impressionistic rather than definite. In her choice of film stock Emin signals the subjective nature of memory as a series of stories that are always told from a point of view. The grainy character of super 8 footage calls attention to its existence as mediated image rather than transparent truth because it makes no attempt to hide its filmic quality.

Ambivalence and the post-feminist subject

In arguing for the feminist provocation of Emin's art my account differs from some other interpretations of her work. Like many other artworks discussed in this book, Emin's practice has not been universally accepted into feminist art history. Cultural theorist Angela McRobbie argues that Emin's work demonstrates an ambivalence and disavowal towards feminism as that which must not be named (2009, p. 121). For McRobbie, who is working in a UK context, this is symptomatic of a post-feminist media culture in which feminism is strategically dismantled. During the period in which Emin made *Why I Never Became a Dancer* post-feminist representations of femininity were becoming increasingly common. Post-feminism is a contested term and as others have pointed out has been used in a number of ways by different authors (Projansky, 2007; Jones, 2003). Most frequently, however, it gives name to a tendency that emerged in the 1990s and 2000s to represent feminism as homogeneous, unattractive and irrelevant to contemporary life. It suggests a time after feminism, which is left behind as if it is unnecessary. As a concept it is blind to the diverse range of experiences of gender-based oppression, assuming a universal feminism that has achieved its aims.

Post-feminist representations of women often include a playful dis-identification with a strict and humourless feminism. Judith Williamson has observed this tendency in adverts that use a parody of sexualized femininity to delineate contemporary attitudes towards female sexuality. Writing in 2003 Williamson noted that the concept of sexism had fallen out of use in public discussion. Through her analysis of contemporary editorial advertising, she argued that the notion of sexism is often employed as a nostalgic stylistic signifier rather than a form of political critique. Through a visual language of pastiche and retro styling there is a reference to a former moment of sexism, which is often visually located in the 1970s. Examples of this tendency include a 2002 Alfa Romeo advert featuring a leggy model that, as Williamson observes, is reminiscent of TV dance troupe Pan's People. Sexism is

placed in quotation marks and framed within a sense of nostalgia for a time when it was innocent, a time before feminism had imposed political correctness and ruined the fun (Williamson, 2003, pp. 44–53). Any sense of the politics of the women's movement is lost in the way in which these adverts invoke sexism as nostalgic innocence. The implication that Williamson objects to is that sexism belongs in the past, which makes it difficult to challenge. To do so would be out of step with the cool irony that was arguably favoured within the advertising industry at this time, as if to claim sexism in the present is to misunderstand the spirit of the times and reveal an absence of graphic design sensibility.

Many other feminist authors have challenged post-feminist formulations of womanhood often by critiquing conservative representations of femininity in advertising, journalism, popular film and TV. Diane Negra, for example, provides a brilliant analysis of the central position given to the American post-feminist subject as, amongst other female types, chick-flick heroine, stay-at-home mom, and self-care specialist (Negra, 2009). Much of this literature reflects on media representations of choice. In a distortion of hard fought for gains this focuses on the choice to reject feminism as if it is something to be liberated from. Amelia Jones has identified an anti-feminist voice in American sexual politics and illuminates this through an examination of the use of photography in news media and advertising (Jones, 2003). For Jones the increasing visibility of gay, feminist and non-white identities is a cause of anxiety to white, anglo hegemonic masculinity, which uses conservative post-feminist imagery to shore up its authority. There is now a wide body of literature in this field and a series of concerns that stretch across the interpretation of different media forms, from the narratives they tell to the (audio) visual languages used to naturalize their values. By working across a range of media forms Jones, McRobbie and Negra signal the pervasiveness of post-feminist ideology on both sides of the Atlantic. This ideology includes a reactionary approach to gender politics and the invocation of a fantasy feminist as a figure of hate. This anonymous, generic feminist is hostile to family life, overly serious and aggressively ambitious. She has burdened women with too many life choices and is to blame for the conflict between work and family life, which is understood as a personal problem for women who struggle to 'have it all' rather than a socio-political issue requiring structural changes such as flexible working hours and affordable childcare. In the place of the monstrous feminist enters an imagined post-feminist ideal who is white, hyper-feminine, Western, affluent, upper-middle-class, heterosexual and young (often referred to as a girl rather than woman).

The new feminine ideal is educated up to a point, but ultimately rejects professional and public life in favour of heterosexual matrimonial duties. She is a proficient consumer and prefers materialist forms of femininity to social critique, which she finds distasteful and unfeminine. Her sense of empowerment is derived from consumption, which necessarily excludes many women for whom access to commodity culture is hopelessly out of reach. What makes post-feminist rhetoric so malevolent is the extent to which it constructs its values as common sense, for example the desire to look forever young or to reign in ambition. The post-feminist subject is as much of a caricature as the feminist she replaces, but powerful nonetheless.

In the UK and US post-feminist representations emerged during a time of economic prosperity for the group it privileges, but in a climate of financial hardship, rising unemployment, unfavourable policies for women and disincentives to pursue higher education the inequalities of post-feminist rhetoric are thrown into sharp relief. No longer so young and with employment prospects increasingly fragile, the affirmative, youthful consumer of post-feminist representation is under threat. Fear for the future encourages a reconsideration of the sexual politics of the recent past. So there are multiple layers of time at play. First, the concept of post-feminism is itself entrenched in a never-ending aspiration to youthful femininity that lies out of reach in an imagined future, whilst simultaneously invoking nostalgia for an earlier moment of pre-feminist identification with femininity. Second, there is the vantage point of the present day from which these temporal contradictions can be viewed.

While much has been written about post-feminism from the point of view of feminist cultural studies, it is less frequently used as a critical vocabulary within art criticism, despite the permeable boundary between art and popular culture that characterizes the work of Emin and many of her contemporaries. McRobbie, however, works between art and popular culture, using a cultural studies approach to examine Emin's position within the wider culture. In a landmark book on the subject McRobbie argues that there has been an attempt to 'undo' feminist gains. This extends the notion of a 'backlash' against feminism, which was posited by American journalist and author Susan Faludi in her book of the same name published in 1991. Faludi argues that there has been a hostile reaction to the gains of the women's movement based on the false belief that feminism has made American women miserable. Her book contests a range of myths about the negative effects of too much feminism, arguing instead that if women are unhappy it is because there

is not enough feminist agitation to see them fairly represented in social and political structures. McRobbie's work is differently nuanced, arguing that the 'undoing' of feminism involves taking it into account only in order to repudiate it as outdated and irrelevant. Post-feminist rhetoric assumes the achievement of female independence, self-sufficiency, empowerment and employment as if these objectives are obvious and shared, therefore do not need to be argued for in the present. However, this occurs within socially sanctioned limits and without challenging patriarchal authority. Female independence is celebrated, but solidarity amongst women who wish to organize for structural change is not. The rhetoric of equality as a given, a desire so obvious it need not be stated despite enduring inequalities in the workplace and at home, is why McRobbie argues that the rage felt by women about their situation is illegible. It appears unintelligible in a society in which equality is often invoked far too simplistically to distinguish between Western young women who are 'free' and 'others' who are not.

One of McRobbie's key arguments is that a social contract exists in which young women are encouraged to relinquish their feminism in exchange for increased access to education and employment opportunities. This, she argues, was encouraged in the UK by the right-wing press and Tony Blair's New Labour government, which came to power in 1997, two years after Emin made *Why I Never Became a Dancer.* Feminism thus becomes less a social movement concerned with collective struggle and more to do with the individual pursuit of middle-class, affluent femininity. It remains, nevertheless, as an absent presence, never entirely out of mind. McRobbie transposes this situation on to the relationship between Emin's work and feminist art of the 1970s. She notes that there are many shared themes including autobiography, testimony, sexual abuse and rape. I would add that there are also genres and techniques in common such as diary entries, appliqué, self-portraiture, spoken voice and found objects. For McRobbie, Emin mimics feminist art while simultaneously distancing herself from it in the press. She argues that Emin's work forgoes the social critique of second-wave feminist art in favour of a politically ambivalent individualization (2009, p. 121). Emin is read as typical of the new feminine subject who substitutes self-narration for communal activism; the post-feminist woman who achieves independence at the expense of collective sexual politics. In relation to *Why I Never Became a Dancer* the argument is that Emin's film is about herself rather than about the collective position of working-class women struggling to survive with dignity. The film undoubtedly speaks of personal damage and success and it is fair to say that it does not allude to the broader

context of women's liberation from sexually demeaning behaviour that gained momentum in the 1970s. Furthermore, in relation to *Why I Never Became a Dancer,* McRobbie argues that Emin is more readily accepted as a successful artist when she expresses anger against herself rather than against socially legitimated violence (2009, p. 122). In short, the veneer of political engagement wears off easily.

My own view is that in her wider body of work Emin does not display anger with herself so much as sadness, fear, hope and strength. She does not explicitly point to a wider marginalized group and certainly her work is based on her own life. However, I am more optimistic about the potential of Emin's work, rather than her statements, to make a useful contribution to sexual politics. I agree that her relationship to feminism is ambivalent, but argue that this can be a fruitful position if it shakes up what we understand as properly feminist and why. This idea is explored throughout this book in relation to artists of different generations such as Hannah Wilke and Sam Taylor-Johnson. Although these stories are *about* Emin, there is a sense that they are not only *for* her. Emin's work is of great interest to students who often recognize their own struggles in hers and use this as a springboard for an emerging interest in the social, material and sexual injustices that feminist visual culture sets out to challenge. The positioning of Emin's work as individual as opposed to political has sometimes revealed deep-rooted prejudices about what counts as critical and what doesn't. In 2005 Emin published a collection of writings called *Strangeland* in which she recounted fragments of her past through a combination of memoirs, poems and extracts from her artworks. In its candid description of working-class lived experience *Strangeland* echoes Carolyn Steedman's *Landscape for a Good Woman* (1987). The two authors write about the experience of growing up at different points in time and in different parts of the UK – 1950s London for Steedman, 1970s Margate for Emin – but both explore their relationship with their mothers and the socio-economic hardships that characterized everyday life during adolescence. However, whereas Steedman's book is rightly considered auto-ethnography, some critics consigned Emin's to the academic wasteland of confession and victimhood (Adil, 2005). Where Steedman's draws on psychoanalysis, Emin's wider body of work is considered theoretically empty. It is, nevertheless, difficult to argue that Emin's account of teenage rape, complex familial arrangements in which her father was shared between two homes, and the material realities of squatting after the family hotel closed down are anything other than critical commentaries on the economic and sexual economy that formed the backdrop to her life.

Emin has also exercised control over the dissemination of some of her work in an attempt to politicize a specific audience. In 2004 she directed a feature-length film called *Top Spot*, which was originally intended for general cinema release. It features six teenage girls who each represent aspects of Emin's adolescent life. The emphasis on the artist's own experiences was put into a wider context when Emin pulled the film from general release. The British Board of Film Classification had given it an 18 certificate as a result of a reference to suicide, which meant that young teenage girls would not see it. In December 2004, the film was broadcast on BBC3 in the UK and a DVD of the film was released in 2004. At the level of the artist's intention there is an attempt to reach a group of people whose situation is often under-represented and to give voice to their experiences as well as her own.

In an earlier piece of writing McRobbie distinguished Emin's well-known tent in which she appliquéd the names of those she had slept alongside (including her twin brother in the womb), *Everyone I Have Ever Slept With 1963–1995*, from the work of earlier feminist artists arguing that the artwork, 'owes more to the bawdy "girls just wanna have fun" humour of *More!* magazine than it does to her feminist elders, Cindy Sherman and Mary Kelly' (1999, p. 6). Sherman has not, in fact, claimed to be a feminist although her work resonates with feminist identity politics and has been influential for artists interested in the performance of mediated identities. Where McRobbie argues that Emin's work is haunted by the history of feminist art, as if the artist would ideally like to shake this off, Rosemary Betterton suggests a more positive relationship that connects these two periods without denying key differences. Betterton argues that 'Emin is consciously engaged in sexual politics, albeit of an individualized kind, and that her use of genres and techniques historically gendered as feminine would be impossible without the histories of feminist debate and practice that preceded it' (Betterton in Merck & Townsend, 2002, p. 26). Betterton signals the complexity of Emin's femininity, which involves an ambivalent relationship to feminism rather than an outright rejection of it. Her argument resists the temptation to homogenize British art during the 1990s as post-theoretical or apolitical (see Chapter 4 for further discussion of this). Furthermore it reconnects Emin's work to feminist art history through artistic practice, in particular Emin's use of embroidery, stitch and autobiography, whilst acknowledging divergent tactics and intentions. It is in her techniques that a different critical repertoire can be found. Critiques of Emin's work have understandably focused largely on her disarmingly honest, confessional approach to narrating her own life

story, but have sometimes lacked attention to the details of her practice. Emin's facility with film, for example, has not received critical acclaim in the way that some of her contemporaries have, such as Jane and Louise Wilson or Sam Taylor-Johnson, and one of my aims is to redress this here. It is not only that Emin uses these techniques in the pursuit of different political strategies, but that her work comes from a different place. It may be driven by experience rather than theory, but the representation of this experience across film, sculpture, painting, monoprint, neon and other media forms is always necessarily positioned.

I am wary of identifying Emin as emblematic of post-feminism and want to suggest a less linear feminist art history than the narrative of lost consciousness that this entails. In the final scene of *Why I Never Became a Dancer* the artist codes herself as simultaneously sexual, feminine, pleasure-seeking and feminist, thus defying the generational separations of post-feminist rhetoric in which 'ideal' femininity is understood as both conversant in consumer culture and beyond feminism. I read this moment as a powerful intervention into post-feminist representation because of, rather than despite, its ambivalence. I am cautious of the narrative of individualization that surrounds Emin, even though she perpetuates this in interviews and writings. There are specific artworks, including *Why I Never Became a Dancer*, in which the narration of personal feelings becomes a means to a more strategic, affectual ends.

The recent turn towards affect in cultural theory offers a different critical repertoire with which to make sense of this aspect of Emin's art. The tendency to talk about women's autobiographical work as rooted in critically devalued concepts such as feeling and emotion belies a more structural sense of affect as public feeling, which is available to analysis and critique. Authors such as Lauren Berlant and Kathleen Stewart have renewed interest in the affective potency of ordinary life.[1] This means understanding emotions not as individual feelings, but as critical attachments to ideas of, for example, citizenship and intimacy. The emotive aspect of *Why I Never Became a Dancer* is also about the politics of intimacy, embodiment and abuse. There are details, such as the thumbs up that Emin gives to the camera towards the end of the final scene, which signal a shared rather than individual understanding of achievement at having overcome something.

In her contribution to the catalogue for Emin's 2012 show at the Turner Contemporary in Margate, UK, Jeanette Winterson writes that she used to worry that Emin's 'personal history might block a bigger history' (2012, p. 59). The location of this concern in the past might signal an appreciation of a shared sense of affect that extends beyond any

one person's experience. This is closer to Sara Ahmed's idea of affective stickiness, which necessarily involves more than one person or sign. Ahmed introduces an economic model of emotions in which they circulate as a kind of capital. Using the figure of the asylum seeker and the international terrorist, Ahmed argues that negative affects, such as fear or hate, stick to particular subjects creating the effect of a border, which enables others to distance themselves. Read through this approach, Emin's display of emotions cannot be entirely individualized because emotions do not reside positively in any one subject, but are an effect of their circulation between and amongst subjects, objects and signs. For Ahmed, emotions 'bind subjects together' but do not exist within any one figure (Ahmed, 2004, pp. 117–120). Emotions assumed to reside in Emin's work in fact circulate between subjects (curators, gallery visitors, critics, historians, fans), institutions (galleries, publishers, broadcasters), geographies (Margate's Golden Mile, the sea, the dance hall) and temporalities (memories of the past, hope for the future). For Ahmed, the greater the movement between such elements the more intense the affect becomes. These elements then appear to 'contain' affect (2004, p. 120), which in Emin's case gives rise to the accusation that the work is entirely individual. The idea of emotions as economic, circulatory and public challenges the propensity to equate the autobiographical nature of Emin's art with individualized post-feminist narcissism. Furthermore, Emin's version of the leaving home story involves a form of return that is inconsistent with the post-feminist narrative of withdrawal from public life, which often involves women giving up their careers for a life of domestic duty. With the circulation of emotion between subjects and signs in mind, in the next section I explore the interplay between Emin's film, the geography that it refers to and the desire to leave and then return home. By working between the artist's narrated experience of a seaside town and my own memories at a similar stage, I hope to capture something of the circulatory nature of affective resonance.

Leaving home

As I watch *Why I Never Became a Dancer* I identify with the story despite knowing that Emin's working-class upbringing in Margate is not reflected in my own adolescence, which was spent near (but not in) the seaside town of Bournemouth. Perhaps my desire to empathize with her story of traumatic sexual realization is a desire for the working-class femininity denied in my own adolescence, both geographically and culturally, by growing up in the middle-class suburbs. In a reversal of

Skeggs' argument about the aspiration to middle-class respectable femininity, I now understand my teenage frustration at the safe distance separating me from the bright lights (most often triggered by inadequate bus timetables) as an acute desire to lose middle-class respectability. What Emin narrates as the habitual struggles of her adolescence from within a seaside town were experienced from outside as a fantasy of adventure. The gap that prevents me from claiming Emin's experience as my own – a gap necessary for empathic identification – is a function of differences in class and geography. Where Emin repeatedly narrates her desire to escape the working-class realities of a rundown seaside town I have never lost the desire to get in.

Hers is a story that works against the grain of what Negra calls domestic retreatism or 'the post-feminist promise of coming back to oneself in a process of coming home' (2009, p. 7). Post-feminist representations have routinely romanticized the 'coming home' story as a return to conservative family values and a way to recover a lost sense of self. Examples of this include films such as *Sweet Home Alabama* (2002) in which Melanie Carmichael, played by Reese Witherspoon, leaves her city life as a fashion designer in New York to finalize a divorce. Eventually she rediscovers her true love of her hometown, its values and the childhood sweetheart from whom she had originally intended to break free in order to marry the mayor's son. Seeing the error of her urban ways Melanie repairs the rift with her past and rediscovers her Alabama roots. Emin's work, on the other hand, often deals with the fantasy of escape from her hometown. The process or idea of escape is often more important than any particular destination. In *Why I Never Became a Dancer*, for example, the room in which Emin dances at the end of the film does not appear local to anywhere; what matters is that it is not the Margate of ruined dreams.

The importance of escapism is alluded to in the sound as well as the image of migrating birds and a seascape that stands between the subject and an elusive elsewhere; an audio-visual symbolism that Emin has used in other film works such as *Homage to Edvard Munch and All My Dead Children* (1998) and *Riding for a Fall* (1998). As spectators we become what Michel Chion calls 'audio-viewers' of Emin's films in that the notion of spectatorship alone does not do justice to the sound/image texture of her work (Chion, 1994). Sound plays a crucial role at the start of the film as we hear the teenage Emin's fast breathing as she runs towards school. Overlaid on to this is the voice of a calm adult Emin explaining that she never liked school and was always late. The difference between the two Emins is secured through sound every bit as

much as through image. The sound of birds, the sea and disco music is used to generate a sense of escape from a series of experiences such as school, sex and Margate.

This is not the contained domestic home of my adolescence, set apart from the messy reality of public space. When describing her hometown Emin recounts communal spaces such as the beach, Golden Mile, Bali-Hi and lunchtime discos. These are the spaces through which her identity as an adolescent is articulated. Even her domestic home was public – a collection of six seafront guest houses comprising the Hotel International. *Why I Never Became a Dancer* also alludes to potentially dangerous spaces such as alleys, greens and parks. Read from the point of view of my own middle-class upbringing there is a sense that the spaces Emin calls home were not private and not always safe. In her story there is a blurring of public and private such that private acts, including sex, take place in public spaces ('on the beach, down alleys'). So while I felt I was escaping the perceived (if not actual) confinements of a private home, Emin narrates an escape from chaos, the licence to do what she liked when she liked. She calls into question the mapping of specific kinds of experience on to particular forms of space. One of the most refreshing aspects of *Why I Never Became a Dancer* is the adolescent Emin's transgression of the gendering of space. By occupying wide-open spaces such as the beach when she should have been in the enclosed schoolroom, she heightens the sense of freedom that is subsequently crushed at the dancing competition.

What is shared between my seaside fantasy and Emin's is the need for geographical and class mobility, albeit in different directions; not the desire to return home, but the need to move away and experience the future differently, which is both a spatial and temporal idea. It is also an idea written into literature on feminist realization. Joanne Hollows has noted that in some accounts of second-wave feminism there is an assumption that feminist identification must involve leaving home in order to enter into full public citizenship (2008, p. 66). This was evident in early second-wave literature such as Betty Friedan's landmark book on suburban American housewives *The Feminine Mystique* (1963). Friedan mounts a scathing attack on the primacy given to the role of the housewife in middle-class America during the 1950s and early 1960s. The association of home with unpaid chores, motherhood and the management of domestic femininity, allied to the consumption of goods for the home, led many second-wave feminists to argue that home represented a loss of public identity for women.[2] A necessary precondition for achieving emancipation was to leave home. However,

as Hollows observes there is a broader context for this assumption. She argues that second-wave feminism tapped into the suppositions of modernity 'that privileged the public sphere as the site of politics, identity and history and found little of value in either private life or the housewives whose lives were defined by domesticity' (Hollows, 2008, p. 66). Feminist identification involved leaving home because the domestic sphere carried negative associations with economic reliance on others and dutiful maintenance of the patriarchal family unit.

In second-wave feminist art there are many examples of the critique of domestic femininity. Some artists took domestic chores into public spaces, thus challenging the divisions between public and private that are both critiqued and perpetuated by the denigration of the role of the housewife. Mierle Laderman Ukeles, for example, undertook 'maintenance' art activities such as cleaning streets and waxing floors during a series of 17 performances between 1973 and 1976. Ukeles wrote a Manifesto for Maintenance Art in 1969 in response to the celebration of progress and heroic achievement encapsulated by minimalist sculptors such as Richard Serra and Donald Judd. Her point was to challenge the separation of art and the everyday routine labour involved in childcare and maintenance work of various kinds, including housework and public service jobs. In *Touch Sanitation* (1977–1980), for example, Ukeles travelled around New York City shaking the hands of over 8,500 sanitation employees and thanking them for keeping the city alive. Other artists took the viewer into the home thereby rendering it a public space. Examples of this approach include the Womanhouse project organized by Judy Chicago and Miriam Schapiro in 1972.[3] This featured site-specific installations and performances by students from the Cal Arts Feminist Art Program. It was one of the first public exhibitions of feminist art and was housed in an empty mansion in Hollywood that had fallen into disrepair. The students learnt the skills necessary to reconstruct the house before displaying their work within it, along with work by professional artists such as Chicago and Carol Edison Mitchell. The students worked collaboratively to critique the construction of femininity focusing on issues such as menstruation, relationships and housework. Sandy Orgel's installation *Linen Closet*, for example, featured a naked female mannequin emerging from a built-in cupboard filled with neatly arranged sheets. The body of the mannequin is fragmented by the drawers, which sever the figure at the hips, beneath the breast and below the chin. It is an eerie, if somewhat literal, representation of woman as home reminiscent of Ira Levin's novel of the same year *The Stepford Wives* (made into a film in 1975 and remade

in 2004). The home as domestic space was not left behind in these works so much as reinvented as a site of political tension.

Returning home

Emin's relationship to home is not restricted to a particular building. Hers is not the 'successful' domestic femininity of inter-war modernity that Ukeles and Orgel critiqued. Neither is it uni-directional. She does not simply leave Margate behind, despite vowing that she will 'leave this place' in the voiceover to *Why I Never Became a Dancer*. In narrating this promise to herself she enacts a return to a version of her home that she can construct and over which she can maintain aesthetic control. Time and again in her wider body of work Emin invokes memories of home at the same time as asserting the importance of having left it for a better life. From the vantage point of her adult self home can be reimaged as nostalgia, which enables her to hold it at a distance necessary for representation. As it is imagined within Emin's film, Margate is not the hometown fantasy of domestic retreatism nor the object of entirely negative affect, but a more paradoxical place: beautiful and abusive, painful and enlightening, the site of adolescent pleasures (visually located in the past) and adult reflection (recalled vocally by the artist in the present). In *Strangeland*, Emin reveals a knowing attitude to her construction of home:

> It's a strange thing when you come from a place – or, rather, when you have somehow created the place that you came from. The Margate of my mind has the most beautiful sunsets that stretch across the entire horizon. Sharp white cliffs divide a charcoal blue sea from the hard reality of the land. (Emin, 2005, p. 28)

This romantic vision contrasts vividly with the Margate of *Why I Never Became a Dancer.* However, even in her descriptions of humiliation and abuse there is a hankering for the version of Margate that Emin would like to reconstruct. Hers is a relationship to leaving home that involves continual return via the safety net of nostalgia. Throughout the film there is a sense that the future, and perhaps also the past, is hers to make. This is a particular view of futurity, which Emin holds dear as she turns shame into aspiration. For her the future is not a matter of God-given fate or destiny, something out of our hands that pre-exists our experience of it. The future is something she can shape through her filmic dexterity and manipulation of time. Despite being entirely

naturalized this concept of the future is historically specific and rooted in the idea that humans can intervene in the continuum of life. It is a product of modernity, the rationalization of clock time and the instantiation of a global present taken for granted in capitalist cultures (Adam, 2010, p. 365). We are used to the idea that the same moment can be shared by people living in different time zones; it might be daytime in one part of the world and night time in another, but we can share in a unified present tense. Any disruption of this idea is disconcerting, as when New Year is celebrated in Australia several hours before it occurs in Europe. It is as if others are somehow already living the future in the present. This experience of the future (as representation) in the present is reflected on a small scale in Emin's film. The past, present and future tenses are not chronological, so much as simultaneously embodied by the artist. They become enmeshed, multi-directional and amenable to her creative influence. In the film the imagined past stretches into an anticipated future of potential and progress. As Emin describes it, the future will irrupt out of the present moment of torment, which we understand is already in the past.

The leaving home story of *Why I Never Became a Dancer* came full circle in 2012 when Emin returned to her hometown as a successful and established artist to exhibit at Margate's Turner Contemporary gallery. The impressive building is located on Margate's seafront and a stone's throw from the scenes described in Emin's film. Her return 17 years later was both celebratory and strangely distanced from the gritty, embodied characterization of the film. The Turner Contemporary reminds visitors of Margate's connection to J. M. W. Turner who was schooled in the town and visited throughout his life. The project, completed in 2011, was supported by Emin and is the beginning of an anticipated regeneration of Margate. The three-storey building, designed by David Chipperfield, has divided opinion. It has been described as 'alien, brutal and bleak' (Sewell, 2011, online), but also as 'probably the most elegant gallery interior in Britain right now' (Januszczak, 2011, online). It is a stunning sight. A series of six white blocks face the sea affording beautiful views from within its walls. On arrival at the railway station the gallery is approached via a short walk along the seafront. This puts into stark relief the difference between the still rundown buildings familiar from Emin's film – the dilapidated Dreamland complex and faded Golden Mile – and the pristine sight of a gallery that stands proud and tall in comparison. The cool, white, sparse and air-conditioned environment of the Turner Contemporary is entirely at odds with its surroundings. The perfectly controlled environment contrasts with the smells, sounds

and colours of the seafront. It is a middle-class sanctuary from the smell of the sea and of fish and chips. It shields the visitor from the beating sun on a hot day and offers a visual infrastructure quite different from the serif typefaces and funfair graphics of a seaside resort.

Emin's exhibition for the Turner Contemporary was entitled 'She Lay Down Deep Beneath the Sea'. For her first solo show in her hometown the artist chose not to focus on Margate. Her return contained a deliberate departure from her earlier proximity to personal history. The regionalism of *Why I Never Became a Dancer* was banished in favour of a series of mainly new works including many female nudes, which reflect the sensibilities of a woman in a new phase of her life. Amongst them were tapestries that look like paintings and embroidered works that can initially be mistaken for ink drawings. These works have the visual effect of a quickly rendered drawing, but are in fact made using the much slower process of stitching. This work suits the calmness of the gallery interior and is a long way from the seaside culture that lies outside, aesthetically if not geographically. It is as if Emin returned to Margate as an artist in order to remind us that she left. In a sense she has realized the promise she made to herself and to the viewer in *Why I Never Became a Dancer*. The door is firmly (and literally) shut on the Margate of broken dreams and messy escapades. There is a new pastness at work here as the artist positions earlier works as something she has moved on from. The new work in its new surroundings is still about female sexuality, but not about promiscuity. In the quiet, sheltered cleanliness of the gallery spectators are invited to contemplate the themes of love, sex and eroticism shared with a small number of carefully selected works by Turner and Rodin.

In contrast to domestic retreatism, which habitually involves relinquishing professional ambition and public visibility, Emin comes home as a successful artist. She separates herself, artistically and physically, from the scenes of her former life. The calmness of the work shown in 'She Lay Down Deep Beneath the Sea' only increases my desire to go back to the urgency of *Why I Never Became a Dancer*, as if for a fix of something visceral. Emin's film offers a vital antidote to insidious postfeminist strategies in the form of a triumphant story of escape from the humiliations of adolescent sexuality. It explores the tensions and desires involved in identifying as both feminine *and* feminist, of achieving feminine agency through feminist realization. This takes place through Emin's treatment of time as overlapping, inter-weaving and malleable. The affective possibilities of remembering, narrating and renegotiating power relationships are enabled by the temporal play of the artwork and

extended by its meeting with the spectator. This is in tension with the stultifying linear chronology of post-feminist rhetoric, which purports to represent 'progress' by emphasizing differences between young and old, second-wave and new, as if this will allay the misguided fear that inter-generational feminist practice will disrupt these binaries and reinstate the contemporary relevance of feminist politics. With this in mind Emin's film offers a provocation to rethink feminist politics in terms of time, affect and a love of disco music.

2

Traces of Feminist Art: Temporal Complexity in the Work of Eleanor Antin and Elizabeth Manchester

In this chapter I explore the inter-generational relationship between two photographic works: Eleanor Antin's *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* (1972) and Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002). These two artworks are distinct in terms of the political and cultural climate of their production, but share some formal characteristics. Here I put them in dialogue with each other to generate a series of observations about the gendering of time. These include an analysis of femininity as an embodied relationship to time, multi-layered temporalities within each artwork and femininity as loss. My intention is to read the relationship between these particular artworks through difference but not opposition. I consider differences in photographic style, political resonance and attitude towards consumer culture, while arguing for a shared understanding of the parameters of acceptable femininity articulated through a playful approach to the language of minimalism in each artwork. These connections are important because they suggest an alternative to generational divide and the associated political separations of women artists working at different historical moments.

The polarization identified in Chapter 1 between feminist, 'critical' or deconstructive artworks of the 1970s and 1980s and 'post'-feminist, apolitical and individualized contemporary works is deeply problematic in its de-historicizing of particular contemporary practices, which are discursively constructed as inconsistent with, or antithetical to, earlier feminist paradigms. The tendency to polarize art made by women of different generations has occurred in critical writing about art as well as in decisions made by curators. The 'Bad Girls' exhibitions held in London, New York and Los Angeles in 1993 and 1994 are notable examples. These exhibitions featured work by Nan Goldin, Sue Williams, Dorothy Cross and Helen Chadwick amongst others. It was an opportunity to

articulate the many and varied relationships between contemporary women's art practice and second-wave feminist work. However, the construction of the artworks through curatorial rationale and catalogue essays perpetuated a discourse of generational divide, even contributing to what Laura Cottingham described as an anti-feminist backlash (Cottingham, 2000, p. 94). Cottingham chastised the American shows for trivializing the work included, denying a continuum of feminist art history and invoking the spectre of a humourless feminist. She described the attitude through which the shows were framed as a 'girlie giggle', which betrayed the significance of the work exhibited (Cottingham, 1994, online). Katy Deepwell was also highly critical of the positioning of the artists included in the London show. Deepwell questioned why the exhibition distanced the women artists from the history of feminist art and argued that 'reducing all past feminist practice to a version of essentialist feminism neatly enabled the presentation of these six women as post-feminist, as something new' (Deepwell, 1997, p. 155). These were important critiques, which exposed the need to challenge such formulations. The counter-argument involves proactively constructing different histories of art based on the many and varied connections between women working at different points in time.

Inscriptions in the feminine

Rosemary Betterton relates generational divide to the positioning of young British artists as 'post-feminist' in her essay on Tracey Emin entitled 'Why Is My Art Not As Good As Me?' Here she contests an article by John Roberts in which he describes Emin's work as 'a proletarian-philistine reflex against '80s feminist propriety about the body' (Roberts in Betterton, 2002, p. 26). Betterton suggests that a more interesting reading of Emin's work would attend to debates about earlier women's art practices through which Emin can be contextualized and without which her use of genres historically coded as feminine would not resonate. A more complex reading would acknowledge that the issue of inter-generational traces is part of the landscape of both feminist art practice and feminist critical discourse, for example in Griselda Pollock's important work on generation and geographies (1996).[1] The divisions between feminist 'mothers' and post-feminist 'daughters' are characterized as both generational and geographical. A problematic spatio-temporal trajectory is drawn from American feminist essentialism to European critiques of representation, followed by the notion of backlash, which enables British work of the 1990s to be discursively

constructed as 'post-feminist'. As a discursive structure this narrative is dependent upon a Western, first-world frame of reference, which is beginning to be questioned by exhibitions such as Global Feminisms (2007).

Exploring the traces of past practices in the present requires a non-linear approach to generation in art practice. The mobility of an artwork's provocation across time and space is at the heart of Pollock's notion of 'inscriptions in the feminine' (Pollock, 1996). The concept of inscription moves us away from what Pollock calls 'the fallacies of expressionism and intentionalism associated with notions of self-conscious authorship' (Pollock, 1996, p. xvi), as does the idea of an inscription *in* (not of) the feminine. Here the feminine is not something already known that can then be expressed as if from a position outside its domain. 'Inscriptions in the feminine' suggests a temporal relation quite different from that of expressionism. Femininity can be understood through Foucault's genealogical analytics as historically and culturally contingent, something that emerges in the present through specific conditions of existence in which subjects of discourse are constituted. The notion of inscriptions of the past articulated in the present allows earlier art practice to re-emerge in contemporary work without flattening out the specific contexts within which the artworks were produced and received. As an inscription in the feminine, Emin's work can be read as a *site* of historically constituted and contested understandings of feminism and femininity, rather than the *product* of a reductive linear chronology of women's art.

In this chapter I use the relationship between Eleanor Antin's *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* and Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* to think about the coexistence (rather than opposition) of femininity and feminism in contemporary work, specifically in relation to the temporality of the work and of its viewing. Towards the end of the chapter I develop the gendering of time in these works with reference to a performance piece by Vanessa Beecroft called *VB35* (1998). Here I want to move away from the conceptualization of femininity as a series of codes over-determined by oppressive structures of representation, towards the idea of multiple and, at times, overlapping femininities produced as what Foucault termed 'objects of knowledge', continually in process and formed in their very articulation in and through specific temporal expectations (Foucault, 1972). In this approach femininity is not understood as an *a priori* truth, to which our approximation can be straightforwardly measured, but the uncertain product of a contested and uneven discursive terrain that constitutes the object(s) of which it

speaks. Femininity is a heterogeneous object of knowledge, produced in relation to multiple sites of cultural praxis. By way of example, Adele Patrick has noted that the widespread rejection of femininity as constitutive of second-wave feminist identity formation lacked specificity and involved 'a trashing of caricatures, of an unnamed Other, a Stereotype of the Eternal Feminine or homogenized Beauty Queens' (Patrick, 2004). Furthermore, the characterization of second-wave feminism as partly predicated on a relinquishment of femininity is itself part of a dominant feminist critical discourse that risks excluding the arguments of non-white women, for whom femininity had never attained visibility in the first place. The invisibility of some kinds of femininity to both hegemonic culture and feminist discourses was an important part of the lack of specificity that Patrick refers to. A comparison between Antin's *Carving* and Manchester's *All My Dresses* does illuminate Patrick's point. If Manchester's piece, which shares a number of formal characteristics with Antin's, shows the imagined other of Antin's critique, this turns out to be specific. It is cognisant of a particular popular cultural repertoire through which femininity is produced as an unstable and historically specific concept, necessarily contingent on the conditions of existence that give rise to its emergence in any particular form. Manchester appears as anything but a 'homogenized beauty queen'.

In suggesting difference without opposition I want to discuss the two artworks in terms that do not presuppose a 'proper' form of feminist art practice, or suggest that the contemporary work *supersedes* the 'critical' strategies of the earlier piece, despite its refusal to present its viewer with a 'resistant' practice or to assume a position outside the phallocentric landscape of representation.[2] My intention is not to claim Manchester as a feminist artist, but to concentrate on a reading of her work that articulates the inscriptions of feminist practice that her work bears witness to. Indeed, the notion of inscription enables me to think differently about the inclusion and exclusion of particular artworks or artists as feminist. I want to suggest that Manchester's piece adds a layer of complexity to the idea of femininity as enduring compliance and continually deferred gratification – an ultimately futile linearity – that emerges in Antin's critique of normative subject positioning.

The relationship that I posit between Antin's *Carving* and Manchester's *All My Dresses* is not a linear, teleological trajectory of influence in which the contemporary work displaces the earlier piece. As many have argued, including Pollock (1996) and Meskimmon (2003), this would only serve to uphold the structural logic of the very system of canon formation that has persistently excluded a cross-generational understanding of female

subjectivity in art. Instead, I am interested in the relational web of mutually constitutive meanings such as that initiated by Catherine de Zegher in her curatorship of 'Inside the Visible' (Institute of Contemporary Arts, Boston, 1996), an exhibition arranged around art made by women at different historical moments (1930s–1940s, 1960s–1970s and 1990s) and in different geographical locations. Here the convergence of spatial and temporal zones is considered productive of new meanings, which are contingent on the dialogue between past and present practices. De Zegher moves away from oppositional thought in favour of 'the cyclic development or reinvention of artistic procedures shifting meanings, not the auratic original "as a moment of irretrievable plenitude and truth"' (de Zegher, 1996, p. 23). This approach unfixes meanings and destabilizes positions in order to provoke a dialogue, in which the viewer is also implicated, between works produced in different spatio-temporal and political circumstances. The reason why this matters is explained by Meskimmon who, drawing on the work of Ian Buchanan, argues that 'a shift from object to process, from an ontology of being to one of becoming, is the crucial component of thinking beyond an economy of the same, of the already-known' (Meskimmon, 2003, p. 3). It is in this spirit of a 'dialogue without canon' (de Zegher, 1996, p. 36) that I now move on to consider the idea of femininity as a relation to time in each of the artworks.

A number of questions arise that signal different types of time. How can the connections and tensions between Manchester and Antin be characterized if not through the generational split implied by post-feminism or the directional impetus of matrilineage? How does the discursive production of this generational relationship, through which some types of artwork are either marginalized by, or excluded from, both feminist and mainstream art history, intersect with the micro-temporalities of the works' making and viewing? How do chronological understandings of post-feminism relate to the minutiae of the works' material presence?

Femininity as a relation to time

In 2001 Bristol's Arnolfini gallery in the UK exhibited a retrospective of Eleanor Antin's work in which her photographic grid-formation piece *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* was shown (see figure 2.1). This was one year prior to a group show curated by Roger Malbert entitled 'Apparition: the Action of Appearing', also at the Arnolfini, at which Manchester's piece was exhibited. *Carving* charts Antin's dieting regime

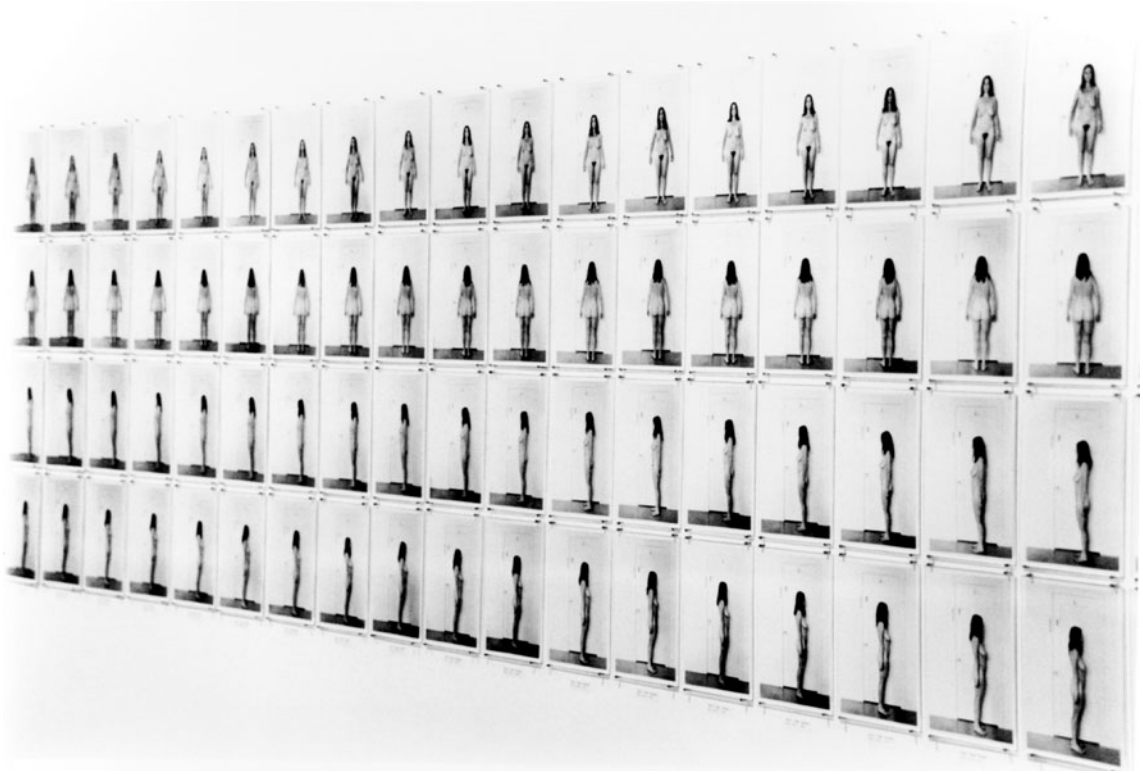


Figure 2.1 Eleanor Antin, *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* (1972), 28 gelatin silver prints with labels and wall text, each: 7 × 5 inches. Courtesy Ronald Feldman Fine Arts, New York

during the period between 15 July and 21 August 1972 through a series of 148 photographs. Each day her body was photographed from four different angles (front, back, facing left and facing right) to record the developmental transformation of Antin's physique. The photographs record the artist's process as she carves her own body in a parody and inversion of the tradition of Greek sculpture in which thin layers were carved from all sides of the form. However, in Antin's piece the 'material' is her own body and rather than carving the exterior she depletes her body from the inside out.

Carving highlights the propensity for Western audiences to 'read' Antin's 'progress', left to right, towards an indefinable goal of cultural legitimacy, as if the process may well extend outside the available image data supplied in *Carving*. Antin's piece suggests what Norman Bryson calls the 'mobility of duration' that characterizes the 'glance': 'Painting of the glance addresses vision in the durational temporality of the viewing subject; it does not seek to bracket out the process of viewing, nor in its own techniques does it exclude the traces of the body of labour' (Bryson, 1983, p. 94).

This differs from Bryson's notion of the gaze in which the viewer adopts the founding perception of the artist in 'an eternal moment of disclosed presence' (Bryson, 1983, p. 94). The gaze is arresting, disembodied and operates outside duration. The bodies of the artist and the viewer are denied other than as organs of sight and even this is instant and disconnected to the rest of the body or of other senses. In choreographing its viewer according to its developmental logic, *Carving* suggests a durational experience of spectatorship and implicates the bodily presence of its viewer as he or she works their way along the grid. The work cannot be grasped in its totality in an instant and cannot be divorced from either the body of the artist or the viewer. The labour involved in producing the work is not veiled, as with Bryson's gaze, but recorded, and the photographic series does not paint out 'the traces that have brought the strokes into being' (Bryson, 1983, p. 95).

The work brings into being a number of temporalities. The time of dieting is a slow, measured, future-oriented duration, punctuated by the time of its photographic recording, which, although in one sense arresting is also anticipatory. I cannot help but study the photos in an attempt to determine whether the movement of calendar time represents any progress in the differently structured time of dieting. This coexists with the temporal aspects of aging, a sense of time embodied in the fabric of Antin's sculptural 'material'. Elizabeth Manchester's work can be contextualized in relation to a cultural appetite for

technologically-enhanced imagery in which the visibility of time on the body is denied, for example through the culture of transformation exemplified by the possibilities of digital imaging, or the desire to stall the visible effects of aging using plastic surgery. However, Antin's work pre-dates the widespread realization of such overt forms of temporal manipulation. This, in turn, is related to the multiple pastness of my viewing, which is over thirty years after the event. It is haunted by recollections of the power relationship between observer and observed inscribed in both legal and medical photographs of the 19th century, which are held up for critique in Antin's work. I have in mind panoptic, masculinist and institutionalized uses of viewing technologies to entrap the body through a triangulation of observation, knowledge and power in which to see is to know.[3]

In *Carving*, the future-orientation of the project is accompanied by a sense of incompetence. Femininity is articulated as false consciousness and as a type of labour in the form of dieting. It records the ritual of self-observation involved in the process and brings to mind the sense of failure that accompanies this. Here femininity consists of a developmental, teleological aspiration to an identity that is, ultimately, never achieved. Antin shows us the already-failed character of femininity as an effect of a naturalizing gaze and an experience marked by displeasure, monotony and inadequacy. When the grid of photographs is read left to right very little difference in body shape is discernable and what emerges is the inevitability of the failure of the exercise. The work describes a never-ending, but nevertheless measured, movement towards an unobtainable goal, which is, in turn, always shifting its terrain. *Carving* functions as a denaturalizing critique where femininity is understood as a future-oriented *project* in which the goal is not, in fact, to lose weight, but to consent to a perpetual state of 'becoming feminine'. Antin emerges as what Meskimmon, drawing on Julia Kristeva, calls a subject-in-process (Meskimmon, 2003, p. 108). Her subjectivity is partly an effect of the viewer's embodied and historically situated relation to an imaging technology that can no longer be understood as an innocent eye. Here Antin's relation to femininity is not something inscribed on an already existent subjectivity. Instead, her subjectivity emerges as a product contingent on the conditions of existence through which *Carving* is received. *Carving* calls forth a complexity of times and tenses, which renders inadequate any simplistic division between a feminist past and a post-feminist present.

The developmental production time of *Carving* differs from the speed of the photographic moment in Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses*

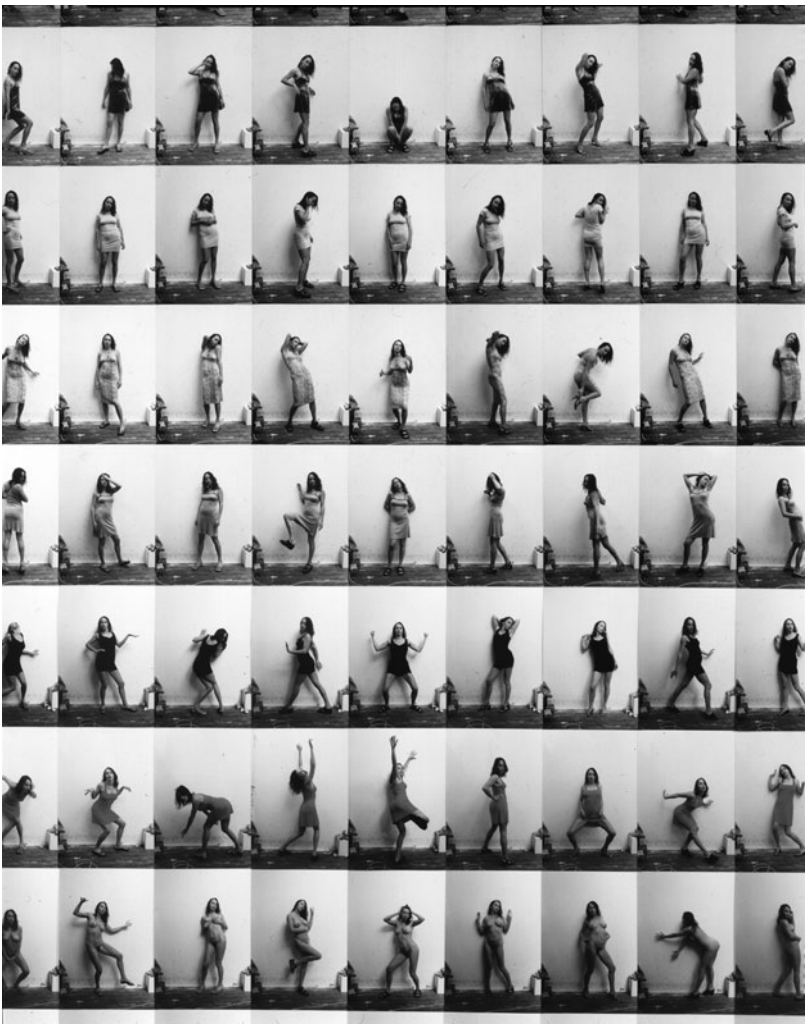


Figure 2.2 Elizabeth Manchester, *All My Dresses with All My Shoes (A/I–XXIII/ i–xxiv)* detail (2002), wall installation: 552 colour photographs. Image courtesy the artist, copyright Elizabeth Manchester

with All My Shoes on two levels (see figure 2.2). Not only is the longevity of dieting quite different from the condensed time of trying on clothes, but the photographic ritual of self-regulation is not carried out with the same kind of prescribed spontaneity that *All My Dresses* invokes. In this

work we see the combinations of the title in grid formation. The overall semaphoric pattern draws you in to examine the details of the title, as if zooming in and out with a camera. At any one point the viewer can either stand back to see the patterned effect or move in to study the content, but cannot do both simultaneously. Our eyes function as cameras that pan or zoom. In this sense the camera/eye is not a tool of rationalized vision, but an embodied subject moving around and into the artwork. The scale and composition of the grid structure tampers with the viewer's coherence, despite the expectation that such seductive imagery will capitulate to the desire for total vision.

There is a formal logic to the arrangement (and an overt reference to Sol Le Witt) in that Manchester wears the same pair of shoes in each vertical column and the same dress in each horizontal row. The methodical rigour of the grid is in sharp contrast to the conventionally gendered and devalued status of the content. The overt nature of this divide demonstrates Andreas Huyssen's argument that mass culture is feminized in its positioning as 'modernism's other' (Huyssen, 1986). *All My Dresses* clearly alludes to the identity play of trying on clothes, but is at its most playful in relation to the conventionally gendered distinctions between masculinized production and feminized consumption. Mass culture is clearly if not unproblematically embraced, but this takes place within the structure of the grid, which has an avant-garde trajectory in the work of, amongst others, Piet Mondrian, Sol Le Witt, Ad Reinhardt, Jasper Johns, Carl Andre, Eva Hesse and Agnes Martin. Rosalind Krauss has discussed the use of the grid motif as a function of the modernist discourse of originality, where this is interpreted either in relation to disinterestedness and autonomy or the 'empirically grounded unity' of the pictorial surface: 'The absolute stasis of the grid, its lack of hierarchy, of centre, of inflection, emphasizes not only its anti-referential character, but – more importantly – its hostility to narrative. This structure, impervious both to time and to incident, will not permit the projection of language into the domain of the visual, and the result is silence' (Krauss, 1996, p. 158).

The modernist/masculinist aspirations that the grid represents are perverted by Manchester in her use of a language derived from mass culture. The severity of the distinction between a feminized low cultural 'private obsession', to use Malbert's phrase (2002), and the masculinized rigour of conceptualism is mocked in one row of the grid. Here Manchester appears naked with the exception of footwear, humorously invoking a clichéd response to the inability to decide that is built into the work's logic. I can almost hear Manchester say 'I don't have a thing to wear', apart, of course, from a good pair of shoes.

In *All My Dresses* femininity is constructed in a perpetual present, outside narrative developmental movement, in the sense that the various permutations of trying on dresses with shoes do not resolve themselves into a decision or a hierarchy of preferred looks. There is evenness, but despite giving the appearance of repetition no image is, in fact, repeated. The design of the work's logic marks the parameters of 'choice', which occurs only within a pre-determined repertoire of possibilities. Within the organizing principle of the work Manchester cannot step outside the grid to encounter other choices. In 'Variations on Sex and Gender' Judith Butler discusses choice in relation to Simone de Beauvoir's claim that 'One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman' (Beauvoir in Butler, 2004, p. 23), arguing that '"choice" comes to signify a corporeal process of interpretation within a network of deeply entrenched cultural norms' (Butler, 2004, p. 23). The 'choices' available to Manchester are necessarily constrained by the parameters of acceptable femininity that have already been legitimated within specific historical and geographical conditions.

Manchester's piece is in tension with the strategic currency of Antin's critique in that she appears to be indulging in the very cultural norms that Antin's work aims to dismantle. It could be argued that *All My Dresses* can more easily be contextualized through media strategies that encourage dis-identification with second-wave feminism and insist on the present-ness of the experience of femininity; as if feminism is the new tyranny from which women need to be freed, a relic from the past that ruins their enjoyment of populist pleasures. I argue, however, that the layered temporalities of the work's making and viewing works against the denial of feminist histories that emerges through the concept of post-feminism. Equally, a defiant insistence on the present-ness of the experience of femininity, the sense of the 'here and now' in which identities such as the ladette, girl power, or even 'Blair's babes' (Whelehan, 2000) are framed, is rendered untenable by Manchester's artwork. *All My Dresses* promises instantaneity, femininity as a pure present, in the knowledge that this can never be delivered.

If Manchester presents the 'here and now' of youthful femininity, in an arguably post-feminist age, this is encroached upon in a number of ways. Her attitude is playful and pleasurable and, in the endless, yet logical, deliberations over dresses and shoes, she mocks the masculine representational structure to which the work makes reference and, in this sense, is connected to Antin's earlier feminist appropriation of the language of minimalism. Manchester rearticulates the motif of the grid in relation to contemporary contexts of consumption. If the relationship

of this artwork to commercial culture is significantly different from that explored by Antin twenty-nine years earlier, it is in the sense of a reconfigured repetition, rather than opposition. The idea of re-invoking and re-contextualizing artistic paradigms across generations and geographies is developed by Catherine de Zegher, who employs Edward Said's idea of 'beginning-again': 'Beginning is basically an activity which ultimately implies return and repetition rather than simple linear accomplishment; beginning and beginning-again are historical whereas origins are divine' (Said in de Zegher, 1996, p. 23).

Femininity and feminism come together in *All My Dresses* through the knowing traces of an earlier moment of women's art practice. In this sense *All My Dresses* is necessarily dependent on the past, despite its reference to the instantaneity of the photographic snapshot.

A dialogue between the past and the present

The photos allude not so much to the developmental movement of film strips as to the ephemeral stills of a passport photo machine; the desire not for continuity but for moments of stasis never intended to become movement. There is a kind of 'stilling' that is divorced from any sense of telos or determination to achieve. However, I would argue that what Malbert describes as 'work that belongs resolutely to the moment' (Malbert, 2002, p. 17) is simultaneously inflected by what Roland Barthes called the 'having-been-there' of photography (1977), the sense in which photographs necessarily connect us to the past. In bearing the stylistic hallmarks of the time in which the work was produced, the visual repertoire of *All My Dresses* will inevitably date, but this coexists with what Mary Anne Doane has termed the cultural desire for instantaneity and contingency, the 'free and undetermined moment' (Doane, 2003, p. 208), which, she argues, is a consequence of the rationalization of time that characterizes industrialization.

All My Dresses is reminiscent of the cultural appropriation of photo-booth imagery, the way in which these machines were in the past used for trying out multiple identities in opposition to their intended institutional use in verifying a singular identity. In this sense photo-booth images are all about 'having been there' in a particular moment and have an immediate pastness about them. This sense of pastness is also an effect of the relationship between forms of temporality and the historically specific cultural use of particular technologies. Where teenagers once used the photo-booth as a means to establish a record of their 'having-been-there', this has been replaced by the far more

instantaneous use of the photographic and image-sharing capacity of mobile phones. This comes closer to the 'being-there' that Barthes ascribed to film, but, as Doane argues, this is still marked by the stylistic vocabulary in circulation at the moment of production and can, therefore, never achieve the instantaneity that it promises. The now-ness of the photographs ultimately fails, which opens the imagery up to inter-generational dialogue. *All My Dresses* hovers on the cusp between its potential to be discursively produced as a post-feminist present and its indexical trace of both phallocentric and feminist understandings of femininity. Here, femininity is what is imagined in the gaps between the desire for the instant and the preservation of the trace.

In these various ways the appeal to the present tense of femininity is unsustainable and with it the categorization of feminist / post-feminist works along both generational and political lines. What is needed is a way of articulating the relationship between Antin and Manchester that does not prescribe a linear, chronological model; one that avoids the strategic distancing of *All My Dresses* from its feminist contextualization while simultaneously embracing the differences in approach between artworks that have been made in different historical circumstances. My reading of Manchester's work is intended to highlight the relational web of temporalities between artworks, and between the artwork and viewer. Understandings of the present are only possible with recourse to conceptualizations of the past. The spaces of femininity that emerge in her work do not move *beyond* the many and varied languages of feminism, but extend them in ways that call into question the premises upon which certain kinds of practice are excluded as not 'properly' feminist. Her work is not strategic nor resistant, but neither is it contained within a post-feminist present, unencumbered by the legacy of earlier feminist practice. In this sense it is provocative of different ways of understanding the relationship between mediated pleasures in contemporary women's art practice and sexual politics, a relationship that is both complex and temporally dispersed.

This temporal dispersion requires not only a reconfiguration of the prefix that positions some types of practice as 'post', which in the case of post-feminism suggests an empty political indifference, but also demands reconsideration of the stability of 'past' practices. The 'here and now' rhetoric through which femininity is discursively constructed depends upon an equally dubious positioning of the 'then and there' against which it can become meaningful. The positivist notion of historical certainty determined by observable facts has been discredited using intellectual frameworks that privilege the discursive production

of the 'then and there' (Foucault, 1972), such that there is no access to a 'real' and objective past that can be counterposed to the idea of a pure present. As delineating temporal groupings these are only imagined certainties. The notion of post-feminism implies an already given feminism from which we have moved on. However, as Barbara Adam has argued in her work on the complexities of social time, tenses interrelate in ways that do not allow for such clear divisions: 'The past has no status apart from its relation to the present. The past "in itself" is not a past at all; only its relation to the present is the ground for its pastness' (Adam, 1995, p. 79).

It is in this sense that E. H. Carr argued that all history is 'an unending dialogue between the present and the past' because the past is always necessarily conceptualized through contemporary frames of reference, continually reinvented in relation to competing discourses in the present (Carr, 1983, p. 30). In my own analysis it is through an engagement with Manchester's *All My Dresses*, including contemporary discourses concerning the continued relevance (or not) of identity politics, that the significance of political critique in Antin's *Carving* is recreated. In so doing I want to resist the temptation to fix the provocation of either work, which remain contingent rather than inherent. The perpetuation of a generational and strategic divide between feminism and post-feminism depends upon positivist notions of the past that are incompatible with the traces of feminist strategy in, for example, Manchester's reference to former feminist appropriations of masculinist imagery. When used to suggest 'moving beyond' feminist politics the notion of post-feminism does not hint at the inter-relatedness of tenses that the artwork makes available and, consequently, is problematic as a critical apparatus.

Unfixing a sense of opposition between artworks produced in different historical and political contexts is to treat artworks as *practices*. Antin and Manchester become participants in a continually mutating network of connections and tensions between what counts as 'feminine' and 'feminist'. Understood as practices artworks have the potential to animate meanings across and between time and space, rather than only to defer to a given framework within which the artwork has been positioned and legitimated. This is to understand the subjectivities called forth by the artworks as emergent and (re)articulated in relation to different conditions of existence, for example by Manchester's engagement with the motif of the grid within a context of commodity culture. A connection is set up between artworks produced at different historical moments that does not presuppose the stability of either past or present

practices and has the potential to agitate what Moira Gatens has called a 'tremor in the web', which destabilizes how past–present relations can be used to imagine the future (Gatens in Meskimmon, 2003, p. 168). Read through Meskimmon's use of Gatens, the historical notion of 'the feminist seventies' can be detached from its moorings in order to suggest different cross-generational relations through which contemporary artworks can be seen as something other than 'after' feminism: 'This open-ended futurity is neither a function of abstractions nor of utopian dreams, but the emergent potential arising from working through the past and present as practices and not as fixed histories or static objects – as "blueprints", already provided' (Meskimmon, 2003, p. 168). The past is re-imagined in the present in order to set up a different possibility for the future, for example a non-oppositional discussion about gender and generation in art practice.

Simultaneity of commodified time and 'shadow time'

Barbara Adam's project interrogates the dualisms that, she argues, continue to dominate social science approaches to time, such as work time / 'free' time or male time / female time. Through a consideration of experiences of time that are not structured by the clock (such as environmental time or medical time), Adam seeks not to re-inscribe a different set of binary understandings, but to signal the *simultaneity* of differently valued experiences of time. Her attention is focussed on devalued times that fall outside the exchange system of paid employment in which time is commodified as an abstract exchange value. Times that are 'constituted in the shadow of the market economy' are culturally devalued because the productiveness of this time cannot easily be measured according to economic principles or divided into identifiable units (Adam, 1995, p. 8).

Feminist art practice has included performances that made visible the 'shadow times' of housework, caring, menstruation and childbirth, albeit alongside criticisms of essentialism or biological determinism. The Womanhouse project, 1972 (introduced in Chapter 1), featured site-specific installations and performances by students and staff from the Cal Arts Feminist Art Program. Exhibited work included Judy Chicago's *Menstruation Bathroom* and Sandy Orgel's *Linen Closet*. Antin's *Carving* made visible the futility of the 'shadow time' of dieting and in the UK Catherine Elwes was working with related temporal themes in performances such as *With Child* (1983), a video piece which deals with an expectant mother's experience of waiting for her child to be born

and the range of emotions that accompany this anticipation. Without wishing to homogenize these works, which were produced in different political contexts and adopt a range of approaches, what they share is a concern with the experience of femininity as a relation to time that is not legitimated by the temporal structures of paid employment.

Here I want to suggest that the 'shadow times' of these works are not lost in Manchester's piece so much as recast as historically sedimented knowledge. The activities of 'free time', such as trying on dresses and shoes, are, as Adam notes, a product of work time because 'free' time does not exist outside employment relations, but is derived from it. In Manchester's piece, times that make sense in relation to the market economy, such as the 'free' time of trying on dresses with shoes, coexist with references to artworks in which 'shadow times' are explored, the latter accessed via the reference to Antin's *Carving* and the politic this invokes. Manchester's piece embodies this rhetoric without necessarily adopting the same political stance. Trying on clothes can be understood both as part of the 'shadow time' in relation to which femininity is constituted as a project and as commodified leisure time in the form of shopping, which is, of course, an important component of the market economy. Furthermore, while Manchester's activities do not articulate femininity as a type of labour in the same way as Antin's dieting, the limitations imposed on her choices make clear the restrictions of acceptability within which she has to operate.

The complexity of differently gendered forms of time is a theme shared with Vanessa Beecroft's highly provocative performance works in which semi-clothed or naked models typically stand (or sometimes slouch or sit) in choreographed arrangements, sometimes for several hours, while an audience is invited to watch. At an event held at the Guggenheim, New York in 1998 entitled *VB35*, for example, most of the girls were dressed in designer bikinis and spike heels, while others were naked. All were instructed not to speak. In works such as *VB35* there is a simultaneity of economically productive/commodifed time and 'shadow times'; time measured in terms of its economic productivity and time passed not in the production of anything; goal-orientated time and time that endures with no consequent action. Beecroft's performances have been known to last several hours, during which the passing of time is evident in the slowly fidgeting spectacle. However, time is not spent on a causal activity or in the pursuit of a goal and in this sense the temporality of the work does not articulate femininity as a teleological drive or perpetual state of becoming, as I argued in relation to Antin's *Carving*. Beecroft's models are not involved in an *activity*,

which would imply a sense of purpose or predetermination. On the one hand, time is passed not in the production of anything tangible and appears, therefore, to operate outside the time of market economies. On the other hand, this temporal passivity occurs within an exclusive event that has elevated Vanessa Beecroft's status within both the art market and style industry and is, therefore, highly commodified. The 'shadow time' of practicing the gestures that constitute femininity proves to be extremely productive within an aesthetic economy that courts Vanessa Beecroft as one of its stars.[4] The time of the performance event, including the anticipation that precedes it, is transformed into currency, but ironically this is achieved at least partly as a result of prolonged periods of unproductive time. Beecroft's performances enact temporal ambiguity whilst refusing to disconnect from commercial culture. The differently scaled temporalities of generational split and temporal play, at the level of the work, collide in Beecroft's practice because the discursive construction of her work as 'after' feminism is not straightforwardly consistent with her exploration of the gendering of time.

Nicolas Bourriaud has also noted the relationship between space and time in Beecroft's performances, although not in terms of the gendering of the work. In his influential book *Relational Aesthetics*, Bourriaud foregrounds art of the 1990s in which interactive social exchange takes precedence over utopian or revolutionary forms of critique. He argues that the work of Felix Gonzales-Torres, Rirkrit Tiravanija and others facilitate new forms of open-ended communication, 'places where alternative forms of sociability, critical models and moments of constructed conviviality are worked out' (Bourriaud, 2002, p. 44). Noting that the relational encounter is to 1990s art what mass production was to Pop Art, he argues that this generation of artists ground their practice in proximity and contact thus turning its audience into 'a neighbour, a direct interlocutor' (Bourriaud, 2002, p. 43). This notion of the political in art as relational rather than conflictual is refreshing and offers a new orientation towards the micro-utopias of everyday life. However, in homogenizing a diverse range of art practices, which he describes as 'art of the 1990s', Bourriaud misses the details of Beecroft's work. He does acknowledge that there are different ways to be relational, but the 'social interstice' Beecroft orchestrates between time (endurance) and space (gallery), which is variously awkward, voyeuristic and curious, cannot be grasped without taking into account the gendered aspect of her work.

VB35 has a nuanced relationship to the commodification of time that is not irretrievably separated from the critique of femininity as a

process/project that takes place in 'shadow times'. Beecroft's models are not involved in any kind of future-oriented action, they are not *narrating* femininity as process and unattainable goal, although their cool attitude may appear perpetually out of reach for the female viewer. However, the models *endure* their femininity in real time and it is precisely this endurance, stretched out over several hours, that draws attention to the idea of femininity-as-image without ever fulfilling this state. As John Stezaka has noted about Andy Warhol's 1964 film *Kiss*, it is the 'unbearable duration' of the simulation, extended beyond its capacity to remain plausible, that unravels the ability of the spectacle to seduce its viewer. Where Warhol's film becomes, for Stezaka, 'the serial experience of watching the collapse of the simulation' (Stezaka, 2006, p. 121), *VB35* works in a similar way, simultaneously exaggerating femininity as spectacle and letting the façade it creates slip.

Femininity as loss

In *All My Dresses* Manchester appears adept at operating within a stylistic vocabulary that constitutes a particular kind of white and youthful femininity. The studio setting enhances the sense in which she is practicing the static poses that construct femininity-as-image because there is no evidence of any other reason for her to occupy this space. There is no sense of her dresses and shoes being used to express a prior identity. Instead she deliberately stages the various combinations in a rehearsal of already-legitimated female types which, although dealt with differently, is reminiscent of Cindy Sherman's exploration of filmic stereotypes in the *Untitled Film Stills* series produced in the mid- to late 1970s. In both cases the viewer is presented with highly mediated understandings of gender, developed within representation rather than with recourse to an objective reality.[5]

The sense of aspiration, which, in Antin's piece, is marked by failure and incompetence, is abandoned by Manchester, who inhabits the territory of femininity-as-image for the mediated construct that it is. Jackie Stacey has argued, in relation to female spectators' memories of Hollywood cinema of the 1940s and 1950s, that femininity can be understood as 'the ultimate utopian identity: an impossible ideal, predicated upon loss through its very embodiment in the *visual* image' (Stacey, 1994, p. 333, original emphasis). This idea of femininity as something that is unattainable and already lost is highlighted in Antin's *Carving*, whereas *All My Dresses* documents fleeting moments of success in aligning the artist-model's own knowingly mediated self-image

with an already-coded version of acceptable femininity. However, once achieved this alignment is almost immediately and inevitably lost, because the pastness of the photographic image (its 'having-been-there') cannot keep pace with the never-ending reconstructions of desirable femininity that are produced within the rhetoric of the 'here and now'. The relationship between the two artworks is, in my reading, entwined, interrelated and mutually constitutive in their invocations of femininity as an image marked by inevitable loss. There is no straightforward dichotomy between failed and achieved femininity, but there are differences in approach in that Manchester stages a fleeting alignment with femininity-as-image that Antin critiques as necessarily marked by failure. Certainly, Manchester's work could not be read as cognisant of the production of femininity as a relation to the static image, had this not first been critiqued by Antin and others.

The context in which Beecroft and Manchester's work has been produced is one in which many young artists embrace the consumption of popular culture as part of their visual rhetoric. What is at stake is the changing definition and manifestation of feminist politics in relation to the changing attitude of the contemporary art scene towards consumer culture. If femininity-as-image is understood through the lens of consumer culture both Antin and Manchester's grid-formation photographic works comment on the limitations of choice of acceptable femininity, albeit in different historical contexts. Antin's critique of femininity is more overt, situated as it is within an emerging context of feminist consciousness of visuality. Manchester's operates within the codes that Antin illuminates, gently mocking the entitlement myth perpetuated by post-feminist forms of consumer culture. Her work suggests a parody and mimicry of femininity-as-image, which is explored further in relation to Hannah Wilke's work in Chapters 4 and 5. While this does not constitute a relinquishment of femininity, understood as a series of oppressive codes, it does set up fascinating questions about the production of femininity through temporalities of vision enabled by imaging technologies. The gendered subject is produced in and through technologies of vision, rather than being penetrated by them.

Femininity emerges from this as a transient concept marked by a simultaneity of temporal experiences; on the one hand a process of 'becoming', the goal of which remaining perpetually out of reach, on the other hand a concept mediated through the problematic notion of present-ness delivered through the stasis of the image. The temporal dynamic is a product of the artworks, the experience of the viewer and the relationship of this dynamic to a broader landscape of feminist

thought, rather than something that can be applied to them, as if from a position outside the particularities of making and viewing. By establishing an inter-generational dialogue between Antin's *Carving* and Manchester's *All My Dresses* a connection between temporality and feminist politics can be identified. The durational aspects of *Carving* (for both artist and viewer) led to an understanding of femininity as a failed project. This is picked up by Manchester at a time when feminist scholars and journalists have renewed their critique of the alliance of consumer culture with femininity. Manchester performs moments of successful femininity whilst simultaneously demonstrating the extent to which the available choices are limited to a logic of the same. There is a knowingness to the design of *All My Dresses*, which enables Manchester to appropriate the masculinism of the grid for the purpose of rehearsing femininity as an ultimately lost aspiration.

3

Sexuality, Loss and Maternal Desire in the Work of Carolee Schneemann and Tracey Emin

This chapter explores the practice of reading an historically precedent artwork, Carolee Schneemann's *Interior Scroll* (1975), through the provocations of one produced twenty-five years later, Tracey Emin's *I've Got It All* (2000). The use to which female artists have put their own bodies, as both subjects and objects of desire, continues to be a source of contention within feminist art discourse (Jones 2006, p. 149), but Schneemann's identity as a feminist artist continues to be cited by looking back at the work she made during the 1970s.[1] The published images of *Interior Scroll* serve as pivotal touchstones of second-wave feminist body art and, in the process of image reproduction, contribute to a canon of works that can be securely identified as properly, if not unproblematically, 'feminist'.

Here I explore Schneemann's work on the energy of female sexuality and maternal desire through Tracey Emin's recurrent visualizations of sexuality and maternal loss. I ask how Emin performs her position as a woman artist, not only in relation to contemporary culture, but also in terms of her performative relation to a history of feminist art practice. I invoke Judith Butler's genealogical notion of performance as the bringing into being of ideas, rather than the search for origins (Butler, 1990). Read through Butler's challenge to identity as substance, the bodies of both artists can be understood as contingent and constituted in the temporality of 'becoming' rather than 'being'. With this in mind I consider the production of Schneemann's body through present-day understandings of sexuality, femininity and feminism.

The desire of some women artists to represent active female sexuality continues to present a challenge to established understandings of the role of women in the artworld. In particular, Schneemann's dual identity as model and artist contests the idea of women as muse or model

for male artists.[2] This raises theoretical questions about what a specifically female form of sexuality might look or feel like (Irigaray, 1985a). Within this context it is striking that Emin's multiple evocations of maternal desire and loss are still met by some commentators with derision on the basis that her art is too personal, or consequently not even art at all (McGrath, 2002, online). The idea of maternal desire within the artworld remains as problematic now as it was when Schneemann performed *Interior Scroll* in 1975.

The artistic identities of some contemporary British artists such as Emin is shaped, as Rosemary Betterton argues, 'in terms of a shared consumption of mass culture' (Betterton, 2002, p. 24) and hence dismissed as unable to question the visual structures to which it refers, whereas Schneemann belongs in feminist art historical memory to an anti-capitalist critique of commodified pleasures. However, Schneemann's relation to this was always ambiguous, particularly in early works developed prior to, or in the nascent stages of, second-wave feminist art. Films such as *Fuses* (1967) and *More Than Meat Joy* (1964) were heavily criticized by women for whom Schneemann's active sexualized artistic identity was too close to the visualization of women as sexual commodities, which feminism targeted in its critique of representational codes. Laura Cottingham has described the hostility with which these works were received, citing a screening of Schneemann's *Meat Joy* at a women's film festival in Chicago in the early 1970s as a prime example (2000, p. 128). On this occasion the audience displayed outrage at what they read as a conventional porn film, which suggests that there was no context at this point for active female sexuality to be understood by an audience of fellow artists as in any way resistant to hegemonic femininity.

My interest in the cross-generational production of feminisms contrasts with readings of Emin's practice as antithetical to the feminist politics associated with Schneemann (see Chapter 1 for a discussion of this). This differentiation has at times been perpetuated by Emin herself, but in recent works she has directly referenced feminist art history through her invocation of the work of Frida Kahlo, for example in *Tracey x Tracey* (2005), which calls to Kahlo's double self-portrait *The Two Fridas* (1939). In addition, Emin has worked in collaboration with Louise Bourgeois modifying a series of gouache torsos sent to her by the artist and exhibiting them at Hauser and Wirth in London in 2011. Despite the different contexts of production, *I've Got It All* shares with Schneemann's work a refusal to disengage with commodified (dis) pleasures in what I will read respectively as Emin's ambiguous display of conspicuous consumption and Schneemann's mediation of the female

body. The matrix of artist, desiring woman and maternal figure that Emin both constructs and calls into question in *I've Got It All* is generationally connected to Schneemann's *Interior Scroll*, but the historical linearity of this logic is here considered as a starting point for a temporally different model of analysis. My model resists what Foucault has called 'a history whose function is to compose the finally reduced diversity of time into a totality fully closed upon itself … a history whose perspective on all that precedes it implies the end of time, a completed development' (Foucault, 2000, p. 379). Recognizing the limits of matrilineage outlined in the introduction to this book, in particular the perpetuation of a model that has historically obscured the interests of women artists, my approach is indebted to the arguments of Pollock (1996), de Zegher (1996) and Meskimmon (2007), which, while diverse in aims and scope, share an understanding of generations and geographies as freed from the restrictions of linear chronology. Also of note is Lisa Tickner's (2006) use of Deleuze and Guattari's concept of the rhizome, in which non-hierarchical alliance is presented as an alternative to an arboreal model premised on lines of descent (trees and roots).

The complexity of tenses that enables cross-generational dialogue between artists and artworks is, I argue, art historically productive. My mode of analysis moves away from a developmental trajectory, in which Schneeman can only be understood as feminist mother and Emin as unruly daughter, and moves towards a situation in which the temporal complexion of the concepts of mother and daughter, as well as the limitations they impose such as the preclusion of positions other than those defined through a maternal relation, can be unfixed. What excites me about looking at Schneemann's performance through Emin's inkjet print is precisely the possibility of producing ideas that derive in some sense from the inter-generational relationship between the two artworks, but cannot be reduced to either. It is in this spirit that I want to explore the possibilities that emerge through analysis of artworks that are each evocative of different understandings of both the maternal and the mediated in women's art practice. Consequently, new questions arise about what exactly this mode of analysis enables us to see. Here I explore how Schneemann's work is activated, or 're-born', through Emin's. What can this tell us about historically different, although not necessarily opposing, understandings of the relationship between feminist politics, visuality and our own mediated encounter with the body? This leads me to consider how the maternal can be understood, both within the visual and experiential fabric of each artwork, and within a broader discussion of genealogical approaches to art history. To read earlier works through

contemporary ones is to bring an historically precedent artwork to life in a different context – not as a touchstone of accepted ideas to be looked *back* upon, but as the lifeblood of new configurations of mother-artist-desiring woman, to be *produced* in the present.

Maternal desire, loss and control

Discussions about Emin's work often revolve around her engagement with commodity culture. This is dismissed by some critics as signalling a depthlessness, which was taken to be symptomatic of the broader young British artists scene (Stallabrass, 1999). However, I want to think about the details of this claim with specific reference to *I've Got It All*. Here I concur with Peter Osborne when he questions Stallabrass's argument that Emin's art is simply an intellectually desolate amalgamation of commodified cultural forms: 'Is Emin's art really no more than a symptom of a commodified fusion of cultural forms … Or does it address this condition within which it is located, artistically, and, in the process, tell us something about it, and with that, something about the conditions of contemporaneity in art?' (Osborne, 2002, p. 41).

Emin's piece addresses the tension between woman-as-commodity and woman as maternal figure in ways that warrant close attention to the details of the work. *I've Got It All* is an inkjet colour photographic print of Emin sitting on a red floor, legs apart, clasping bank notes at her crotch with one hand and holding the money over her stomach with the other, as if feeling the kick of a baby (see figure 3.1). Coins spill out over the floor emphasizing the severity of the single point perspective that leads to Emin's crotch, which is positioned at the centre point of the print and is the object of Emin's downcast look. The artist wears a top that is recognizable as a Vivienne Westwood garment. Her legs are bare and the image is cropped before the ankles so that Emin's feet are outside the parameters of the image. In the background we can identify a Ryman's carrier bag, which seems incongruous with the cultural capital of the signature Westwood bustier top. The image is contradictory inasmuch as the cultural kudos afforded by the Westwood garment and the signs of commercial success cannot be reconciled with the pose, which evokes a sexuality more akin to Emin's depiction of adolescent sexual encounters and abuse in her feature-length film *Top Spot* (2004). In this film Emin cast six girls who narrate various facets of their teenage experience such as rape, promiscuity and the desire to escape. As Christine Fanthome explores in her reading of *Top Spot* the girls represent aspects of Emin's adolescent life, but also raise questions about the extent to which they



Figure 3.1 Tracey Emin, *I've Got It All* (2000), inkjet print, 124 × 109 cm. © Tracey Emin. All rights reserved, DACS 2013

own the confessions they make on screen (Fanthome, 2006, pp. 30–42). Indeed, when *I've Got It All* is viewed through this later work a clear dialogue emerges about sexuality, femininity and respectability. *Top Spot* appears, within my own viewing history, as a precedent for *I've Got It All*, which, in turn, cannot be encountered outside the issues of sexual identity and vulnerability with which the film engages. Emin attends to herself as if left in a dark alley in the backstreets of Margate as I imagine it from other works such as *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995), discussed in Chapter 1. Her body is divided at the waist between the boned control of Westwood's structured garment and the loss of control depicted in the overflowing excess of bank notes and coins. This composition is further marked by the line dividing the red floor from the white wall.

The character of the image signals the precariousness of converting economic capital into what Pierre Bourdieu called cultural or symbolic capital because her success as an artist does not guarantee the respect of cultural critics who continue to cast aspersions on Emin's creative abilities (Bourdieu, 1984). As if in response to the insecurity this kind of commentary can provoke Emin's conspicuous consumption appears out of control, spilling out of her body as if she is bleeding money.

I've Got It All captures Emin as if she is unprepared for the flash of the camera or caught in the glare of headlights. It alludes to paparazzi photos in which celebrities are caught unaware and in so doing reminds us of Emin's multiple performances as artist and celebrity. The lighting is focused sharply on Emin's lower abdomen and thighs, which has the effect of blurring the coins in the foreground and throwing the background into dim light, particularly the part of the room behind Emin in the top left-hand side of our view. While the poor light in this part of the scene virtually obscures it from vision, the bank notes at Emin's crotch are over-exposed and therefore appear not only as banknotes, but as a mass of paper used as if to stop her bleeding. This connects *I've Got It All* to the recurrent themes of abortion and fertility explored in Emin's wider body of drawings, monoprints and video work. The argument I wish to propose about the materiality of the image is that the tension between the maternal and the commodified in this work cannot be thought outside the photographic rhetoric of the piece. The lighting is aggressively and specifically connected to a particular kind of flash light photography in its use of under and over-exposure. What I read as the coexistence of conspicuous consumption (both the financial means and objects of consumption) and maternal loss, understood as miscarriage as opposed to the choice not to have children (signified by the blood-red floor, which spills out around Emin), is produced in and through this form of mediation, rather than being described by it. The specific photographic vocabulary produces the effects of which it speaks (Foucault, 1972). In this sense the maternal is an effect of photographic mediation, not a purely experiential phenomenon. It is formed in the flashlight directed at Emin's crotch, which draws our attention to the symbol of miscarriage that is further exacerbated by the blood-red floor. This resonates with historical precedents such as Kahlo's *Henry Ford Hospital* (1932), in which Kahlo paints herself lying on a hospital bed in the aftermath of a miscarriage. In *I've Got It All* Emin brings together the idea of her body as potentially reproductive, primarily through the spectre of failed procreativity, and the assertion of sexual availability that can be read through her open-legged pose.[3]

The concentration of light on Emin's flesh and, in particular, her crotch, is emblematic of the connection between light and patriarchy, which is crystallized in the objectifying photographic form. As a representation read through feminist responses to Lacanian psychoanalysis, Emin's role is to function as a mirror that secures male subjectivity. As what Hilary Robinson calls 'other of the same' she must affirm male coherence by virtue of her otherness and have no ontology of her own (Robinson, 2006, p. 66). This function is dependent upon the visibility of woman's 'nothing to see'.

'If woman is "seen" as "castrated", as not having something … then her relation to origin and her representation of and to self will be seen as negative. How can she love the fact that she is like something that has nothing, that is nothing but the gap where something should be?' (Robinson, 2006, pp. 58–59).

However, Emin fills this gap with the rewards of her success as an artist such that she cannot simply be regarded as not having something, or as deficient in the signifiers of material wealth. On the contrary, Emin does, as she herself exclaims in the title of the piece, 'have it all'. Read through the refusal to accept feminine lack, Emin's title, *I've Got It All*, is defiant rather than possessive. The material/financial and the maternal/sexual collide in her posture, which denies any sense of lack (even if it allows loss) and articulates her relation to the sexual division of labour within the activities of originating and generating – as successful artist, if not as mother. Indeed Emin's history is one in which her creativity and procreativity have intersected. This emphasis on the differently gendered forms of labour involved in the work was also highlighted by the inclusion of *I've Got It All* in a group exhibition called ECONOMY held at Stills in Edinburgh and the Centre for Contemporary Arts in Glasgow during the early part of 2013. The show focused on the various ways in which contemporary art engages with the economy as a material and experiential phenomenon. The curators of the show, Angela Dimitrakaki and Kirsten Lloyd, similarly read Emin's print as a challenge to the division between maternal and artistic work in the context of contemporary economic conditions: '"Good mother" and "successful artist" remain mutually exclusive roles. They occupy the two poles of the unskilled/trivial/natural/anyone-can-do-it (maternal) work and the highly skilled/unique/cultural/exceptional (artistic) work in the axis of the immaterial labour regime of 21st-century capitalism' (Dimitrakaki & Lloyd, 2013, online).

Dimitrakaki and Lloyd's argument chimes with my own engagement with the identity of the woman artist in the context of neoliberalism. This marks a change in attitude towards Emin's practice and connects

to a wider debate about the gendering of labour in feminist art history. At stake is the recognition of Emin as an authorial subject in her own right rather than as 'other of the same', which throws the construction of male subjectivity into turmoil.

Irigaray has suggested that patriarchal understandings of light assume a flat mirror in which woman's reflection secures male subjectivity: 'a faithful, polished mirror, empty of altering reflections' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 239). In place of the symmetry implied by the flat mirror, Irigaray posits the notion of concavity. Feminine desire curves the mirror so that the reflection functions differently and produces what Irigaray calls the 'cultural reserve yet to come' (Irigaray, 1985b, p. 138), the possibility of a space of representation for female sexuality. In *I've Got It All* the mirror is curved by the inconsistency between the expectation of Emin's multi-dimensional lack, as a half-Turkish Cypriot formerly working-class woman, and the authorial control with which she brings this lack into being as an image.

I've Got It All pivots on an axis of accumulation and loss. Is she, as Osborne suggests, 'symbolically filling the vagina with money, a blatantly profane, onanistic act of consummation' (Osborne, 2002, p. 45) or trying unsuccessfully to stem the flow of an outpouring, hopelessly trying to keep something inside. The latter possibility resonates with Emin's decision to have two abortions, which has been well documented by the artist in other works including two series of drawings from 1995, *Abortion, How It Feels* and *A Week From Hell*, and her short film *Homage to Edvard Munch and All My Dead Children* (1998). When contextualized within ongoing debates about the economic disadvantages of motherhood, *I've Got It All* functions as a visual reminder of the (im)possibility of inhabiting the dual identities of artist and mother. It asks whether financial gain is still at the expense of maternal loss. Furthermore, by combining the flashlight's propensity to reveal with the illumination of maternal loss the work articulates a tension between mother and sexual/desiring woman, which situates the work within a trajectory of feminist art practice. There is, I suggest, a cultural anxiety over both Schneemann and Emin occupying a maternal position as a result of their respective refusals to distance themselves from sexual and visual pleasures, as if they cannot be both sexually desiring and maternal. This friction is not resolved in Emin's piece, but it is positioned in relation to the contemporary artworld's interest in entrepreneurial success.

(Pro)creativity and control

I read Emin's pose as an attempt to prevent loss. Her stance is intriguing because the notion of 'outpouring' is highly gendered. It is formed in

both art historical and corporeal terms. The connection between pain and creativity, characteristic of Romantic myths of the masculinized artist, is cleverly bifurcated by Emin, who comments in this image on both artistic creativity and maternal procreativity. In both works under discussion the gendering of 'procreation', as opposed to 'creation', is developed in relation to the initial contexts of the works' consumption. Robinson has drawn on Irigaray's work to discuss the gendering of this distinction in which 'creation' is proscribed as a male activity and defined in its difference from 'procreation', which is the only type of creation that women can practise without threatening the social order (Robinson in Deepwell, 1995, p. 162). In differing ways the procreative is fused with the creative in both artworks and hence there is a confusion of gendering at the level of the works' production. The gendered attachments of the terms 'creation' and 'procreation', as well as the implied hierarchy, is called into question. While Schneemann draws her words from her body as if giving birth to an artwork, Emin makes her art out of the fear and guilt attached to lost procreativity.

The issues of control (bodily/artistic) and loss come together in the very ambiguity cited by Osborne. The materiality of Emin's body, which supposedly obscures it from rational thought, is coexistent with the materiality of commodity culture that has infused the artworld. However, the irony is in the extent of Emin's artistic control over the depiction of her bodily lack of control. This is a dynamic that is carefully constructed by the artist herself. Chris Townsend has explored the construction of the ideas of immediacy, intimacy and spontaneous disclosure in Emin's work, noting, in particular, the use of monoprint to create the illusion of raw and unmediated outpourings (Townsend, 2002, pp. 80–84). The process necessary for producing a monoprint involves coating a surface such as glass with ink, placing a sheet of paper on top of it and then 'drawing' on this paper before peeling it back to reveal the image. The resulting one-off 'print' (the image cannot be serialized) is, therefore, an inversion of the marks inscribed on the paper and at one remove from the perceived immediacy of drawing. Townsend explains this process in order to explore Emin's use of lettering in monoprints, in particular her deliberate construction of the notion of literary 'failure' that we read through apparent mistakes such as inverted lettering. While this can be read as a hurried, emotionally charged outpouring, in which the care needed to correct mistakes is deemed unimportant, Townsend reminds us that lettering on monoprints is rare because it requires the artist to write backwards on the paper and to do so quickly, before the ink dries. His point is not to unmask Emin as fraudulent, but to argue

that she uses a technique that removes the immediacy of drawing with clear purpose in order to create a feeling of raw, uncontrolled disclosure. The sense of loss that pervades much of Emin's work is carefully constructed. In controlling the appearance of loss of control, Emin's working practices are not only inconsistent with the identification of her artistic sensibility as out of control, but are also testament to her awareness of the cultural and historical feminization of this idea.

The title of *I've Got It All* is, at face value, an exclamation of possession derived from a sense of individualized self-entitlement. However, Emin's title also comments on these values (what does 'it' consist of?) by relating the accumulation of financial wealth and commercial success to contradictory ideas about consumer culture, female sexuality and its relation to the maternal. Osborne observes the connection between the claim of the title, which refers both to consumer culture and female sexuality, and the visual rhetoric of the image, arguing that, '*I've Got It All* is thus simultaneously an economic and a sexual claim, an identification of economic and sexual freedoms' (Osborne, 2002, p. 50). The nature of these freedoms, however, remains ambiguous given the tawdry depiction of the space, both literal and cultural, in which they occur.

When read through Betterton's argument about the feminist art historical context of Emin's work (2002, pp. 23–39), in particular the critique of accounts that assume Emin's alliance with apolitical libertarian agendas, the irony of the title becomes strikingly apposite. The personal pronoun can be read as a post-feminist statement of individualistic entitlement, but this is in tension with the complexities of the image and the discursive territories from which the possessive statement is made. Despite being dismissed for her lack of critical distance from commercial culture, including the accumulation of cultural as well as financial capital, Emin's work is permeated by a sense of loss, which manifests itself in a number of ways. Monoprints such as *Terrebly Wrong* (1997) refer to maternal loss. Emin's film *Why I Never Became a Dancer* (1995) is initially about loss of respectable femininity, and her *memento mori* assemblage *Uncle Colin* (1963–1993) refers to familial loss. *I've Got It All* does evoke a feeling of excessive consumption, but equally it articulates the vulnerability of gains that are easily lost. Emin is not throwing money around, but trying to hold it in. *I've Got It All* speaks of the impossibility of keeping hold of it all; not only the desire to be a mother while also remaining financially independent, but a cultural anxiety over the desire to be at once a sexual woman and a mother. The piece reflects on its own conditions of existence, both in terms of art history and sexual politics.



Figure 3.2 Carolee Schneemann, *Interior Scroll* (1975), performance photograph (photo – Anthony McCall). Image courtesy the artist

Here the accumulation/loss dynamic is articulated within a reflexive relation to particular aspects of feminist art practice. Whereas Emin's piece is ambiguous in this regard (is she pushing the bank notes in or trying to prevent them from leaking out?), Schneemann's action in her *Interior Scroll* performance (1975) was clearly an extraction of a coiled piece of paper from her vagina (see figure 3.2). Emin's work is cognisant of the relationship between artistic/bodily control and creativity as a gendered concept, which was explored by Schneemann in *Interior Scroll*. Schneemann's performance includes a highly controlled unravelling as the artist uncoils a legitimated cultural form as a kind of umbilical poem. In their different ways, both artists respond to the cultural anxiety over transgressed bodily boundaries using a high level of control, discipline and cultural competence, which is in sharp contrast to the notion of femininity as lack of control.

The description of *Interior Scroll* offered by Helena Reckitt and Peggy Phelan (2001) explains the sequence of events that took place. In the performance Schneemann appeared wearing a sheet and told the audience that she was going to read from her book, *Cézanne, She Was a Great Painter*. Unwrapping the sheet she then painted her body and face with mud to define its contours. Climbing on to a table she read while assuming a series of action poses familiar from life modelling. Having dropped the book Schneemann continued to read from a paper scroll that she gradually extracted from her vagina. Schneemann's controlled unravelling of the paper enacts movement from inside to outside, invisibility to visibility, as she performs the idea of women as makers of meaning, rather than bearers of meanings legitimated by men.[4] Furthermore, the visibility of the poem is embodied. Knowledge is understood as an embodied phenomenon, both culturally and literally. What emerges from Schneemann's body is a poem about a structuralist filmmaker, which reads as a critique of disembodied forms of analysis. It was originally thought that the poem referred to the filmmaker Anthony McCall, who was Schneemann's lover in the early to mid-1970s and photographed the performance. However, in 1988 Schneemann disclosed that the scroll was, in fact, a secret letter to critic and art historian Annette Michelson. Contrary to most people's assumption Schneemann was addressing a woman who the artist claimed could not look at her films rather than a male filmmaker (Schneemann, 2002, p. 319).

Both *Interior Scroll* and *I've Got It All* explore an embodied relation to art practice, despite the different contexts within which this becomes meaningful. Schneemann's work can be contextualized within a feminist desire to use performance as a way of disrupting the aesthetic

economy of the artworld (despite feminist criticisms of biological determinism) by making objectless art that cannot enter into a system of exchange. *Interior Scroll* positions Schneemann as both artist/poet and model/object, physically connecting these roles in the extraction of critical thought from her body and refusing, in the process, the Cartesian mind/body split that has been used to secure women to the category of nature rather than culture. The natural (birth, menstruation) and the cultural (poetry and the authorial voice) are indistinguishable from one another within the experience of the performance.

Emin's piece reflects on its historical conditions of existence in different ways. The work comments on the commercialization of the artworld, including what Roberts has called its 'loss of guilt in front of popular culture' (Roberts, 1996, p. 30), while simultaneously reflecting on the position of women who supposedly 'have it all'. Furthermore, the work questions the relationship between the maternal body, artistic identity and woman as commodity form, provoking questions about the 'value' of Emin's 'outpourings', understood as both emotional and physical. Her procreative value is represented as synonymous with her commercial value, described in the image using banknotes and coins. In this sense, Emin connects her own situation to feminist debates about the market economy in which both art and women are treated as commodities to be exchanged. Emin stages the aesthetic economy of the artworld (her body as a commodity and repository) and consequently retains a reflective relation to the circumstances of its production.

Contextual travels

In addition to arguing for the traces of feminist work in Emin's practice, which I think are palpable and important, the reality of my own experience of *Interior Scroll* is that, along with other feminist works of the 1970s, I read it through an entangled nexus of contemporary practice and discursive constructions of the 'feminist seventies'. Within the history of my own viewing, it is as if some aspects of contemporary women's art practice appear to be 'quoted' in the photographs of Schneemann's performance. Clearly this kind of reverse quotation is factually impossible (how can Schneemann have been quoting Emin?), but it is not experientially impossible in terms of how I read and make sense of the artworks and their relevance to contemporary culture. This is more than simply seeing one image through another because it suggests a meeting point of discursive terrains. To deliberately embrace the lack of chronology this involves may be to enable

a multi-directional dialogue that engages the earlier work in a dynamic that is only possible once the notions of cause and effect have been unseated. As Bal (1999) has argued in relation to contemporary artworks through which Caravaggio can be read, the quotation of past practices is not only important for a new artwork, but also for the work quoted from, because the new work itself becomes a source through which the chronologically precedent work can be read: 'this reversal, which puts what came chronologically first ("pre") as an aftereffect behind ("post") its later recycling, is what I would like to call a *preposterous history*' (Bal, 1999, p. 7, original emphasis). The 'preposterous history' of reversing 'pre' and 'post' can lead to the dissolution of matrilineal logic. In common with Foucault's concept of genealogy, it challenges the tendency to smooth the edges of history in the service of a coherent continuum. For Foucault, genealogy involves the discovery that 'truth or being lies not at the root of what we know and what we are but the exteriority of accidents' (Foucault, 2000, p. 374). It has to do with the dissipation of events outside of any search for origins.

There are elements of *I've Got It All*, such as the conflict between the seductive visual pleasures of the surface (the smoothness of the inkjet print) and the ambiguous, even potentially disturbing, nature of the scene, or the tension between the implication of tawdry sexual encounters and the evidence of financial and artistic success, that raise questions of *Interior Scroll* that are predominantly of the present. How has Schneemann's work interacted with the economy of repetition and her accumulation of cultural capital? How has this impacted upon her politics of representation? How adept is Schneemann at simultaneously inhabiting a range of environments that span what might once have been considered incompatible spaces in terms of the political consciousness of her work, for example her web presence alongside her presence in memory, or in art anthologies? Emin's occupation of multiple identities (for example, woman artist, fashion icon and celebrity) also provokes a debate about Schneemann's dual identity as both radical artist and established figure within feminist art. Perhaps most provocatively, what would it mean to read Schneemann's display of overt female sexuality through current understandings of post-feminism with which Emin has, I suggest problematically, been identified?

This multi-directional production of meaning is more than a quotation of motifs and closer to what Bal terms 'interdiscursive': 'the precise quotation of utterances [turns] into the borrowing of discursive habits' (Bal, 1999, p. 10). This mode of analysis highlights the way in which Schneemann's work appears to find its natural context in times other than those in which

it was produced. No doubt this feeling of temporal mis-match contributed to the experience of *Interior Scroll* as a transgressive work in the mid-1970s, but the depiction of active feminine (and sometimes maternal) desire in work that is as widely disseminated and discussed as Emin's, offers a more sympathetic context for Schneemann's ideas. The notion of 'preposterous history' highlights not only the empathetic intricacies of Emin's relationship with her feminist predecessors (including her way of doing feminism differently), but the temporal fluidity of Schneemann's work, which, as Barry Schwabsky puts it, 'reaches backward and forward through time' (Schwabsky, 1997, p. 80). Schwabsky notes the geographical as well as temporal dislocation of Schneemann's work, arguing that her 'sensibility seems much closer to that of the West Coast scene of the fifties and sixties … than to hard-nosed, formally terse New York-style empiricism' adding that her work is 'somehow out of place as well as time' (Schwabsky, 1997, p. 81). 'Preposterous history' travels through and in between re-materializations such as films and photographs, not in chronological order, but in the less structured experience of memories.

Clearly Emin's *I've Got It All* is not intended as a revisiting of Schneemann's *Interior Scroll*, but it does engage with the political and artistic terrain in which Schneemann's piece was performed. Emin may not identify as a 'feminist artist', but she nevertheless uses a language made available to her by the work of feminist artists, theorists and activists to explore sexuality and the female body in a way that can be read as an interdiscursive conversation, even if each discursive terrain remains elusive to the other and can never be grasped with any certainty. As such, I suggest that *I've Got It All* stands in a performative relation to both the historically precedent work and its traces, in the sense that the conversation between the two works is productive of new possibilities. As a text it also becomes a historical other to the earlier work, which has the analytical advantage of disallowing the present to become taken for granted as the natural outcome of previous historical moments. The present moment is understood as historical *in itself* and the act of interpretation self-reflexive.

The materialization of performance

In the last section I want to explore how the dynamic between femininity and feminism in *Interior Scroll* can be produced through Emin's contextually different encounter with the themes of mother-artist-desiring woman as mediatized entities.[5] What is the relation of the performance to the performative in Schneemann's work, when read through Emin's

highly specific appropriation of the medium of photography? What can a 'preposterous history' of these two artworks offer?

If the detail of Schneemann's performance of *Interior Scroll* is emphasized, rather than only the fact of its original existence *as* a performance, the artist's adoption of life model poses warrants careful consideration. Schneemann combined the mediated with the live scenario. She was explicitly engaged with woman-as-image and the effects of the screen as a mediating device. Schneemann's fascination with the sensate experience of an embodied subject is well documented (Enright, 1998), but with the exception of Jones' (2006) reading of Schneemann's films *Plumb Line* (1968–1971) and *Fuses* (1967) less emphasis has been placed on her competence in critically mimicking femininity-as-image. This is likely a result of her own appearance, which was too close to white normative femininity to be comfortable for a feminist reading, hence other aspects of her work emerged as meaningful within a feminist context. What has disappeared from view in the photographs of *Interior Scroll* is the fading in and out of movement or what I imagine to be the poignancy with which Schneemann's performance of mediation (life model poses) must have melted into live action. The tension that *Interior Scroll* sets up between the mediated and the live is labyrinthine. These elements are not simply combined, but start to question each other. The penetrating camera is positioned by Schneemann's anticipation of it, even if its 'real' purpose is to document a performance that takes this penetration as its object of critique. It is almost as if Schneemann poses for two different types of camera, one complicit with the visual apparatuses she was challenging, the other recording the live act of her artistic agency in doing so. There is nothing in the descriptions or reproductions of Schneemann's performance of *Interior Scroll* to suggest that live acts are independent of mediated images.

Philip Auslander has argued that performance studies persists in distinguishing the live/real from the recorded/artificial despite the increasing cultural appetite for events that combine the two, for example the use of video footage at rock concerts or screened imagery at large sporting events (Auslander, 1999). The transgressive potential of feminist performance art has been characterized by Catherine Elwes as the unmediated encounter with the 'real-life' presence of the woman artist (Elwes, 2000, p. 71). The implication of Elwes' position is that as a cultural form performance contains within its very experience an immediate loss. This argument contends that the merit of feminist performance art lies primarily within the moment of its enunciation, a temporary encounter that cannot be traded upon, owned, accumulated or

exchanged. Similarly, Peggy Phelan has argued that, 'performance's only life is in the present' (Phelan, 1993, p. 146). Phelan is concerned with resistance to commodity culture through the notion of the *immateriality* of performance art, an understanding of performance 'as that which disappears' (Phelan, 2003, p. 293).

Powerful though this argument is, it has the effect of encasing performance in a kind of temporal purity of the present. It renders the cultural form of performance art temporally autonomous, despite its simultaneous call to contingency and reciprocity, because these factors are privileged in the here and now of the event. The desire to privilege the origin, the specificity of the initial event, can even begin to counteract feminist critiques by resonating with the search for beginnings in mainstream art history. In this understanding the 'live-ness' of performance art, which, given its feminist use as a critique of modernism is somewhat ironically treated almost as a formal property of the work, is prioritized over what I read as the temporally dispersed reciprocity of the gaze, a dialogic encounter that takes place between and across generations and geographies.

Here the notion of a direct and intimate form of address is understood as contingent upon historically specific cultural and technological possibilities, rather than something that can be attributed to a particular media form. In fact, when Schneemann re-created a performance of *Meat Joy* in London, as part of the Whitechapel gallery's series of events in 2002 entitled *A Short History of Performance*, Anna Dezeuze wrote a review for *Art Monthly* in which she related the experience of watching the performance in 2002 to her knowledge of the photographs and film footage that exist as a record of the 1964 version. While these traces had clearly enhanced her desire to see the 'real thing', it is with a sense of disappointment that Dezeuze laments the loss of the intimate effect of the close-up photographs taken in 1964, which were shot from a position above the reclining performers (Dezeuze, 2002). Intimacy is enacted here as an effect of photographic practice. Such debates have intensified as artists have re-enacted either their own earlier performances or those of other artists. One notable project was an event called 'Once More With Feeling', which was organized by Oriana Fox and held at Tate Modern in June 2009. A number of artists including Oreet Ashery, Nadine Jarvis and Fox herself re-staged feminist performance art from the late 1960s to 1990s. Often taking a playful approach their performances included renditions of Eleanor Antin's *The King* (1972), Martha Rosler's *Vital Statistics* (1977) and Bobby Baker's *Drawing on a Mother's Experience* (1988). In 2010 the Museum of Modern Art, New York, held

a performance retrospective of the work of Marina Abramović, which included live re-performances of her works by other people. In each case the live-ness of the re-performance cannot be distinguished from the photographs and films that exist as traces of the initial event. Some of these photographs have become iconic, including the black-and-white photo of Schneemann pulling the scroll from her body, constructing a history of images that exceeds documentation and frames the re-staging of 'live' art.

Performance art does not have the monopoly on intimacy and there is no guarantee that intimacy depends upon physical proximity to a performance in real time. Schneemann performed *Interior Scroll* standing on a table, a form of pedestal, which itself creates a distance despite the live nature of the event. Her maternal desire was constituted within the visual structures of painting (life model poses) and the structural conventions of the gallery. Possibly the most significant aspect that is irretrievably lost through reproduction is less an idea of proximity to the artist and more the power of Schneemann's authorial voice. Few have written about this, with the exception of Peggy Phelan who argues that 'the photograph cannot amplify the dramatic sound of Schneemann reading: instead, it renders the scroll as a kind of mirror' (Phelan in Reckitt & Phelan, 2001, p. 30). The relative lack of attention to the aural, rather than visual, detail of the performance seems strange given that reading, in public, from the text is such a key component of the work and its political import. This absence of debate is a measure of the extent to which the vocal dimension of the performance has turned into a purely visual artefact, which leaves me wondering how loud Schneemann spoke, how fast, and which parts of the text she lingered on.

Rather than positing an understanding of live-ness in terms of its intrinsic *difference* from the recorded or reproduced image, Auslander understands live-ness as both historical and contingent. This contingency is refracted through Bal's notion of 'preposterous history' because the source of our present-day understanding of *Interior Scroll* as a 'live' event consists of a filigree of image fragments, partial memories and knowledge of both feminist and non-feminist discourses on female sexuality and the body. Auslander's debate with what he reads as the persistent methodological assumptions of performance studies opens up our understanding of what constitutes the 'live'. As a concept this becomes less an ontological fact or form of cultural practice, defined within the temporal singularity of the inaugural moment of consumption/collaboration, and more a relation to changing conditions of existence, which suggests a mutability that cannot be fixed

either temporally or politically in any straightforward way. What is at stake is the difference between 'performance', as a cultural form that suggests a particular temporality of the present, and the notion of the 'performative' (Butler, 1990), as a relation to an event that invokes a different kind of temporality involving repetition, duration and travel through different contexts of consumption. Butler's notion of the performative is not a search for precedence and, with this in mind, I have no interest in explaining Emin's work in terms of Schneemann's, as if the former is subservient to the latter. Instead, performativity opens up a space in which both artworks are instantiated anew in what Butler describes as 'a dramatic and contingent construction of meaning' (Butler, 1990, p. 139). Exploring mediation and the photographic production of the maternal in Emin's *I've Got It All* opens up a space in which Schneeman can be read as an artist adept at combining the live and the mediated, via the intimacy of a screen-based visual repertoire.

Read through Auslander's move away from privileging the 'live' event over and above the reproductions that ensue, the enduring significance of *Interior Scroll* can be preposterously reconfigured. While such performances are clearly not now experienced as live in an ontological sense, they remain live in an ideological or political sense, but only through the very reproductions that their existence has been interpreted in opposition to. Rather than positioning photographic documentation as the antithesis to the feminist critique of both patriarchy and capitalism, photographic traces of performance events are not only testament to that which has disappeared, but are themselves *differently live*, reactivated by their performative relation to contemporary works. Emin's *I've Got It All* is consciously formed within a photographic imaginary (the photographic as a cultural context rather than only a medium) whilst simultaneously retaining something of the agitation and urgency of being present in a specific moment, which is more commonly attached to the immediacy of performance art. Auslander is right to identify that the notion of disappearance (Phelan, 1993) is not particular to live performance. More specifically, I would cite the immediate past-ness of the photograph, its 'having-been-there' (Barthes, 1977), discussed in Chapter 2, as grounds for this observation. Emin's *I've Got It All* also provokes strong emotions around the failure to be there in the moment that matters. Why is she alone and not being helped? Could the loss have been prevented? Could I have done anything to help?

Bal's notion also illuminates the contingent character of live-ness in the work of both artists; a sense of the live, intimate and embodied

relation to woman as both artist and maternal figure that is re-imagined through cultural consumption in the present. However, what I read as the live-ness of Emin's address in *I've Got It All* is an effect of mediatization. The desire to experience the live event (or the wish that you had) in both its temporal immediacy and geographical singularity, even to understand the live as a differentiated concept, is a product of mediatization. In this sense the experiential is not opposed to the material. Making sense of Emin's *I've Got It All* enables me to see the materiality of Schneemann's performance in *Interior Scroll*, including the extent to which she *'performs* the inscription of mediatization within the immediate' (Auslander, 1999, p. 54, original emphasis). This form of 'preposterous history' enables a different reading of Schneemann, as an artist adept at exploring the mediation of the body, rather than only its 'live-ness' as a direct encounter. Schneemann becomes, for me, differently live. *Interior Scroll* is mediatized in a way that preposterously echoes Emin's *I've Got It All* in its consciousness of the life model pose and the idea of a repertoire of poses from which it is acceptable to choose. This theme is explored further in Chapter 2, where I discuss a photographic piece by Elizabeth Manchester, and informs my reading of an earlier photographic work by Hannah Wilke in Chapters 4 and 5. Both artists use the grid formation to comment on the bounded nature of choice. It is in relation to the conventionality of this repertoire, its cultural sedimentation of the woman as image, that Schneemann's 'live' act of pulling a scroll from her body becomes transgressive. In effect, the live-ness of this is only meaningful in the context of the historically changing mediation of the female body, its continual production through representation. Emin's inability to keep hold of it all becomes source material for my reading of Schneemann as an artist highly adept at questioning the gendered relationship between the live/real and the recorded/reproduced. Both works are involved in a dialogue between the material and the experiential, in particular the materiality of that which is considered non-material and sometimes immaterial – not only the 'lost' performance, but the lost experience of maternal desire.

What is produced through the genealogical implication of 'preposterous history' is a series of different intensities. These can only be reached if the relation between maternal desire, sexualized femininity and woman-as-artist is understood as a historically specific *effect* of the continual reorganization of discourse, power and the body. And what of the artistic agency of Emin and Schneemann within this framework of contingency and inter-generational dialogue? Where Butler argues that 'there need not be a "doer behind the deed", but that the

"doer" is variably constructed in and through the deed' (Butler, 1990, p. 142), this does not amount to the exclusion of agency so much as a re-conceptualization of what it means. Artistic agency may give way to a dispersed series of connections, continually in formation and irreducible to authorial intent, but the artist is, nevertheless, still there in her propensity to elicit new forms of kinship.

4

Feminist Narratives and Unfaithful Repetition: Hannah Wilke's *Starification Object Series*

In Chapter 2 I discussed the knowingness with which Elizabeth Manchester performs femininity as a series of poses within a limited repertoire of choices. To develop my argument further I want to explore the impact of imagery that consciously approximates a highly commodified version of femininity-as-image, but only up to a point. I am interested in artworks that deliver a practised range of gestures, only inasmuch as this heightens the effect of the deliberate failure that ensues. In this chapter I consider Hannah Wilke's *S.O.S. Starification Object Series* (1974–1975) as an artwork that makes visible the inadequacy of its own repetition of fetishized femininity. Thus, the key concept of time explored in this chapter is repetition. My premise is that repetition is not always repetitive in the sense of tiresome, unchanging monotony. Repetition can be understood in many ways including as a mechanized reproduction of the same (the assembly line), a reaffirming desire for familiarity (a child's request for the same story told every night), or the continual need to have a desire sated (addiction). Here I focus on repetition as a kind of subversive work undertaken by a practitioner who wished to affirm her status as a post-Minimalist artist and a sexual woman, which were differently gendered identities in the New York-based artworld that Wilke inhabited. She performed her femininity as a series of images akin to what Butler calls a stylized repetition of acts through time (Butler, 1988, pp. 519–520). Of interest here is Butler's argument for 'a different sort of repeating, in the breaking or subversive repetition of [a] style' (Butler, 1988, p. 520) and the implications this has for the critical reception of Wilke's work. Butler's argument in her important book *Gender Trouble* focuses on gender performativity and continues to be a highly influential contribution to feminism and queer studies. Although Butler does not focus on fine art her argument chimes with the identity play at work in Wilke's practice.

Wilke produced many works during the mid-1970s in which the repetition of gestures and poses familiar from advertising and pin-up imagery was a key feature. These included photographic and performance-based works such as *Super-t-Art* (1974), *Through the Large Glass* (1976), and *Marxism and Art: Beware of Fascist Feminism* (1977). Both before and during this period Wilke made many sculptures that involved a single fold of a material, often repeated in a series, which are known as her one-fold sculptures. These were often ceramic, but other materials used included metal, terracotta, latex, erasers, chewing gum and lint retrieved from a laundry dryer. Wilke was a manipulator of materials, including her own body, and wanted to be understood in this tradition. There are clear differences between the hardness of the ceramic fold sculptures, such as *Sweet Sixteen* (1979), which features sixteen individual pink labial forms on a white wooden base, the pliability of erasers in *Needed-Erase-Her* (1976) and the fragility of the latex pieces, such as *Of Radishes and Flowers* (1972), not all of which survived. The one-fold sculptures recurred many times and took different forms throughout Wilke's career. They featured in many works during the 1970s and 1980s in different sizes, arrangements and materials. The sculptures became her signature motif, but their meaning changed depending on the concerns of the work. Nancy Princenthal has observed these variations, noting that Wilke identified her one-fold sculptures of the period between 1978 and 1987 with the division of cells in cancer (Princenthal, 2010, p. 28). During these years her mother suffered an ultimately fatal recurrence of breast cancer and Wilke was herself diagnosed with lymphoma, two experiences that informed later works such as *Portrait of the Artist with her Mother, Selma Butter* (1978–1981) and *Intra-Venus Project* (1991–1993). In other works the folds reference labial shapes and in many cases appear ambiguous. There is a connection to the contemporaneous work of Eva Hesse, who in the late 1960s was also using the language of Minimalism to explore a more sensual and embodied artistic sensibility. There is also a link to more recent work including Cathy de Monchaux's sculptures of the mid-1990s, such as *Dangerous Fragility* (1994), which shares with some of Wilke's work an unsettling combination of soft and sensuous materials held together (and held open) with hard fasteners and clasps. What is striking about all of these works is the link between materiality and seriality. This is the site of Wilke's repetition, which she took into her photographic grid-formation works of the mid-1970s.

Feminist traces

S.O.S. is a project that takes a number of forms, the most well known of which is a series of black-and-white photographs (see figure 4.1). The photos were taken by Les Wollam and feature the artist striking a range of poses, many (but not all) of which are familiar from particular forms of editorial fashion and advertising photography. Wilke appears in various states of undress and with props that range from sunglasses and a cowboy hat to hair rollers and a Mickey Mouse toy. Peppered across some of the images are carefully moulded pieces of chewed gum, which are precisely positioned on Wilke's face and body and punctuate what are otherwise smooth repetitions of specific image types.

The photographs differ in terms of the direction of Wilke's gaze and her preparedness to be imaged. In some of the images the artist looks over her shoulder, or at the camera/viewer, but in others she looks up and to the side, as if caught in a moment of contemplation or rapture. In one particular image Wilke looks directly at the camera/viewer and presents herself with calm resignation. This differs markedly from another photograph in which Wilke's hair is in rollers. Here the image functions as a sign of the labour intensive practice necessary to achieve the static, complete and entirely present image that constitutes the centrefold. In allowing herself to be seen in rollers Wilke also signals the cultural competence involved in achieving femininity. There are visual references to femininity as a *project* that requires a repetitive experience of duration, for example in the ritual of 'dressing up' for a night out or the routines of applying and removing makeup. The finished product of centrefold femininity is ruptured by the sense of a process, femininity as a never-ending activity, which suggests the passing of time spent leaving hair in rollers and letting nails dry.[1] Furthermore, this is a particular kind of time, which is often unproductive in any kind of work other than that necessary to achieve femininity-as-image. It is time that needs to be allocated to the task in hand, time that is anticipated and planned for. It is time spent waiting, time that is colloquially devalued (wasted time) yet crucial to the mechanism by which women exist as exchange value.

The majority of the poses have the feeling of a familiar, stylized vocabulary that Wilke repeats with the accuracy of someone who has learnt how to achieve the look she requires. It is as if Wilke repeats the image that she imagines the photographer wants to see, the success of which depends upon the reciprocal relation of the gaze between artist-model and photographer. In her discussion of portrait photography,



Figure 4.1 Hannah Wilke, *S.O.S. Starification Object Series: An Adult Game of Mastication*, detail (1974–1975), mixed media installation, grid of 28 black-and-white gelatin silver prints, 5 × 7 inches each. Musée d'Art Modern, Centre Pompidou, Paris. Donation by Centre Pompidou Foundation and partial gift of Marsie, Emanuelle, Damon, and Andrew Scharlatt, Hannah Wilke Collection and Archive, Los Angeles. Copyright Marsie, Emanuelle, Damon, and Andrew Scharlatt/Licensed by VAGA, New York, DACS, London

Peggy Phelan argues that 'the imitative reproduction of the self-image always involves a detour through the eye of the other' (Phelan, 1993, p. 36). We recognize ourselves in a portrait by imitating what we imagine the other sees. The other can be understood as the photographer, but also as the wider relations of viewing in the context of New York-based gallery art in the 1970s. In *S.O.S.* Wilke appears conscious of this process, as if she is demonstrating the detour that Phelan describes.

S.O.S. has existed in various combinations as a performance event, a series of chewing-gum sculptures, an installation, a grid of photographs, a vitrine display and a boxed game. The *S.O.S.* event is less a complete artefact than it is a series of encounters that play with different levels of viewer participation. The form of the mastication game invites participation, but is not played. *S.O.S. Starification Object Series: An Adult Game of Mastication* was produced for an exhibition in 1975 called 'Artists Make Toys', which was held at an alternative art space in New York called Clocktower. At an *S.O.S.* performance during an exhibition opening at the Gerald Piltzer Gallery in Paris in 1975 Wilke asked guests to chew gum, which she then sculpted and attached either to the wall or to her half-nude body. However, in subsequent incarnations of *S.O.S.* these same pieces of gum appear as sculptures beneath the photographs, and hence remain untouchable in their glass display cases. The dialogue between the various formats used to create the work enables Wilke to play with the degree of audience participation as well as with different forms of display; for example, the vitrine as both a mechanism of commercial display (as in a department store) and preservation (as in a museum). Wilke produced multiple repetitions of the *S.O.S.* project, but no two are the same.

Wilke's use of her own body in works such as *S.O.S.* warrants renewed attention through the work of women artists practising in the 1990s and beyond, not least because as Laura Cottingham has noted, artists such as Tracey Emin and Vanessa Beecroft, and also Mariko Mori, Pipilotti Rist, Kara Walker and others, are working with strategies that were developed by Wilke in the 1970s: 'The strengths and weaknesses of Wilke's self-objectifying practice are worthy of closer examination than they have yet received, not only to better and more fully comprehend Wilke's artistic contributions, but to enable us to decipher just what it is that younger women working with their bodies as material are doing – and why they think they are doing it' (Cottingham, 1998, p. 57).

Since Cottingham wrote these words some aspects of Wilke's practice, such as her use of narcissism, have been connected to later generations of women artists. One notable example is Whitney Chadwick's highly

informative essay in a catalogue for 'And the One Doesn't Stir without the Other', an exhibition held at Ormeau Baths Gallery, Belfast, in 2003. Consistent with the aims of the exhibition, Chadwick weaves together a geneaology of feminine desire through the work of Wilke, Ana Mendieta, Helen Chadwick, Claude Cahun, Sandra Johnston and others (Chadwick, 2003, pp. 8–21). Chadwick traces inter-generational affinities and resists the polarization of women artists working at different historical moments. This approach suggests that a developmental narrative of displaced ideas is not the most productive way to think about the connections and tensions between women artists of different generations. The idea of 'traces' that permeate a range of historical and cultural circumstances enables a multi-directional dialogue. The boundaries of artworks produced in different political and cultural climates can be understood as porous, thus allowing ideas to travel and re-emerge in new contexts.

In my view Wilke's practice is crucial to understanding the relationship between femininity and time in contemporary artworks that engage with femininity-as-image. The connection between the female body as material and its repetitious visibility in consumer culture is present, for example, in Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002), which is discussed in Chapter 2. The slowed-down spectacle of Sam Taylor-Johnson's work (see Chapters 6 and 7) and the persistence of the pose in Vanessa Beecroft's performances (see Chapters 2 and 7) also owe something to the audacious sustained eroticism of Wilke's earlier practice. This is partly an argument for Wilke as a precedent for these artists, an important element of a matrilineage that extends further back in time; for example to Claude Cahun's subversions of femininity-as-image. However, this is not the precedence of apprenticeship or deference to old masters. Here we find a less patriarchal form of precedence, in which the contemporary works are not over-determined by or reduced to the overbearing presence of an 'original' founding father or mother. After all, Wilke's work already plays with the idea of origin, both bodily (in the multiplication of her sexual and self-affirming motifs) and artistically (through her mischievous responses to Minimalist and Pop aesthetics).

Beecroft and Taylor-Wood are informed by the kind of sexual politics practised by Wilke, which differed to some of her contemporaries. Some of the most politically powerful feminist art of the 1970s performed the failure to achieve femininity, thus rendering the feminine visible as something that has to be worked at despite the inevitability of the failure of the exercise, for example in Eleanor Antin's *Carving: A Traditional*

Sculpture (1972), discussed in Chapter 2. The interpellation and internalization of normative gendered ideals had to be made visible before it could be challenged, for example in Martha Rosler's *Vital Statistics of a Citizen, Simply Obtained* (1977). In this video piece Rosler is subjected to a systematic measuring of every part of her body. Two men in white coats measure her, recording every detail in order to compare the results with 'normative' measurements. The video presents a deadpan language of medical instruction, which is sustained as Rosler is told to undress in what is, at times, an extremely uncomfortable visualization of an institutionally gendered power relation. This contrasts sharply with Rosler's directorial voice-over in which she articulates the scenario from the point of view of the woman we see, who is Rosler. This has the effect of transposing the imaged woman from object-specimen to an active subject who is aware of the cultural desire to continually measure her against normative standards in an attempt to submit her to the process of becoming feminine. In *Vital Statistics* the sexual politics lies in making visible the mechanisms by which gender expectations are naturalized and then manufacturing a critical distance that can be shared with the viewer.

What is made visible in Wilke's piece, made two years prior to Rosler's, is repetition itself, the partial replaying of specific versions of femininity, which reframes that which is repeated. I read the connection between feminism and visibility in Wilke's work of the mid-1970s not as the forging of critical distance, as in Rosler's *Vital Statistics*, but as repetition understood as mimetic work. The two approaches signal different attitudes towards the pleasures and pains of looking; the unbearable scrutiny of Rosler's body contrasts with the invitation to look at Wilke's. In both cases the artist appears as both subject (artist) and object (model), but *S.O.S.* does not distance the viewer from the visual pleasures of femininity-as-image in the way that Rosler's piece does. In 1976 Lucy Lippard spoke of the 'confusion' inherent in work by Wilke and Carolee Schneemann, arguing that in Wilke's case: 'Her own confusion of her roles as beautiful woman and artist, as flirt and feminist, has resulted at times in politically ambiguous manifestations, which have exposed her to criticism on a personal as well as on an artistic level' (Lippard in Reckitt & Phelan, 2001, p. 214).

This position raises a number of questions that pertain to cross-generational connections between female artists. If Wilke's work of the early to mid-1970s is politically ambiguous, what does the ambiguity consist of and why can it not be seen as a political strength? Why is Wilke's simultaneous performance of the constructs of beautiful woman

and artist, flirt *and* feminist, explained as a source of confusion rather than as a strategic manoeuvre? By inhabiting both positions she refused to accept a polarizing framework that posits her as one thing or the other, for example normative or non-normative, even when her body changed as a result of the lymphoma that eventually took her life. There are contemporary artists working with their bodies as sensuous material who do not seem to feel Lippard's confusion. The video art of Pipilotti Rist, for example, is overflowing with delicious bodily pleasures that immerse the viewer in colourful, dream-like fantasies. In works such as *Lungenflügel Lobe of the Lung* (2009) the spectator lies on cushions on the floor whilst being treated to an other-worldly series of constantly flowing images on the screens and ceiling. The glistening array of interwoven images and sounds includes naked bodies, vivid tulips and lapping water. However, nothing is quite what it seems as images mutate into other scenarios and the angle of vision fluctuates. Like Wilke, Rist's work is informed by feminism without necessarily identifying with it. Their practices involve rearranging elements within the field of vision rather than orchestrating distance from it. At times they revel in political ambiguity rather than deliver a message, eliciting the pleasures of femininity rather than relinquishing them. These works are reminders that pleasures are not always experienced as pleasurable in any straightforward way. They coexist with, or give rise to, a range of other states including pain, guilt, conviviality, hope and shame. These artworks encourage the critic to avoid the polarization of pleasure and feminist politics that has had traction within particular strands of feminist art history. They are more likely to prompt questions about what pleasure consists of and suggest the need to distinguish between pleasure as a structural framework and the conflicted emotions that may be derived from it.

Wilke's work of the mid-1970s contests the notion that there has been a generational displacement of 'feminist/critical' to 'post-feminist/commodified' attitudes towards femininity in art. Instead, the different approaches adopted by Wilke and Rosler signal the diversity of relations to the matrix of feminism, femininity, pleasure and visibility in the mid-1970s. The sense of struggle over what counts as feminist art at a specific historical moment provokes questions about which feminist traces emerge from this rich and contested field in contemporary women's practice. This both subverts a homogenized understanding of second-wave feminist responses to representational norms and calls into question the narratives that feminism tells about its own history. In the next section I consider some of the existing responses to Wilke's

work and what they tell us about changing attitudes towards criticality and the representation of women's bodies. Here I want to develop a reading of Wilke's *S.O.S.* not as a corrective interpretation to previous feminist criticisms, but to investigate how the dominance of certain stories and their subsequent critique can reveal something about the relationship between criticality (what this means, how it is manifested) and the notion of visibility.

Contested readings

Wilke's work of the mid-1970s has been positioned in a number of ways that demonstrate the contested nature of the stories that feminist art tells about its own history. The work of critical historiographers of feminist art from the 1970s to 1990s has been collected in editions such as Parker and Pollock's *Framing Feminism: Art and the Women's Movement 1970–1985* (1987) and Broude and Garrard's later collection of writing on US-based 1970s feminist art *The Power of Feminist Art: the American Movement of the 1970s, History and Impact* (1994). In addition to the editors of these collections other feminist critics and historians of feminist art, such as Lippard (1995) and Linda Nochlin (1991) have contributed a great deal to the historicizing of feminist art.[2]

In some of this writing, works such as Wilke's *S.O.S.* have been positioned as the naïve and essentialist beginning of a narrative of progress. In 1980 Judith Barry and Sandy Flitterman published a topology of feminist strategies in which Wilke's *S.O.S.* project is firmly attached to the category of essentialist art, primarily (if somewhat literally) due to the labial shapes of the chewing-gum sculptures that cover Wilke's body. In the early 1970s, writers and artists such as Judy Chicago and Miriam Schapiro expounded and celebrated the idea of a specifically female experience of embodiment. In an article entitled 'Female Imagery', originally published in a journal called *Womanspace* in 1973, Chicago and Schapiro used the paintings of Georgia O'Keeffe and others to argue for the importance of 'central core' imagery. This was art that explored female subjectivity through the invocation of a central orifice, an essence that unites women in their difference from men. The authors asked: 'What does it feel like to be a woman? To be formed around a central core and have a secret place which can be entered and which is also a passageway from which life emerges?' (Chicago and Schapiro in Jones, 2003, p. 40). This form of argument polarized sexual differences and rooted women's artistic sensibility in their biology. By the time Barry and Flitterman wrote their article in 1980, other artists and

writers, such as Mary Kelly and Griselda Pollock, had challenged the biological determinism of Chicago and Schapiro's argument. Drawing on psychoanalytic, semiotic and Marxist theories they focussed on the social, cultural and ideological construction of woman, which provided an alternative to the idea of a biological female 'truth'.

The argument that Barry and Flitterman propose is itself contradictory in its positioning of Wilke as both expounding 'a belief in a female essence residing somewhere in the body of women' and 'assuming the conventions associated with a stripper' (1987, pp. 314–315). The latter argument suggests a self-conscious knowledge of how to perform in this role, which is inconsistent with the former argument about interiority. Wilke is positioned as too close to the mechanics of image production and, therefore, unable to develop a theory of representation, but at the same time she is able to 'assume conventions', which suggests a capacity to simulate a gap between her own body and a specific image of pin-up femininity. In fact, the now widespread rejection of biological essentialism in feminist art criticism obscures a degree of inconsistency in Chicago and Schapiro's position. Where accounts such as Barry and Flitterman's create an opposition between the essentialism of central core imagery and the awareness of social critiques of femininity in other kinds of art, 'Female Imagery' does include references to societal expectations based on sex. Chicago and Schapiro do, for example, speak of the 'conditioning of men', but remain reliant on sexual difference rather than an understanding of gender as culturally formed.

What Barry and Flitterman object to is not so much the perceived essentialism of *S.O.S.*, but a lack of clarity about the extent of Wilke's challenge to conventional notions of female sexuality. The primary concern for the authors is the transformative relation of feminism to femininity, including the lack of fit between Wilke's *S.O.S.* and the preferred strategies that constitute a political response to the construction of woman-as-commodity by the 1980s. Barry and Flitterman's comments belie an anxiety about Wilke's engagement with a particular kind of centrefold femininity and their characterization of her attitude as 'teasing' locates Wilke within the language of the striptease, which she cannot, consequently, be seen to critique; she cannot be both flirt and feminist. For Barry and Flitterman, Wilke does not create sufficient critical distance to enable her art to function as radically feminist, which they define as the creation of an aesthetics 'designed to subvert the production of "woman" as commodity' (1987, p. 313). Wilke does not render visible a politics of distanciation of the kind championed by Griselda Pollock (1988) nor does she feel the need to anchor her critical

credentials. Barry and Flitterman's reading of Wilke's art of this period, which positions it as other to the developing notion of critical representation, belies a reading of her work as ongoing process more than definitive statement, a practice rather than a representation.

More recent readings have understood the relationship between feminism and femininity in Wilke's work differently, embracing the ambiguous, fragmented and provocative character of the work. Amelia Jones identifies Wilke's innumerable images of her own body – her self-named 'performalist self-portraits' – as pre-emptive of postmodern understandings of the body as decentred and contingent. In Jones' reading of Wilke the contradiction in Barry and Flitterman's argument between essence/interiority and the performance of a prescribed image repertoire, becomes a merging of body and mind, which subverts the 'masculinist myth of male transcendence': 'Through her naked posing, Wilke not only solicits the male gaze, she also circumvents its trajectory in advance by performatively merging her exterior (body image) and interior (cognitive, emotive) selves – selves that are strategically dichotomized in Western patriarchy (dominated by Cartesianism) as a means of situating women always already on the side of immanence' (Jones, 1998, p. 157).

Jones retrieves Wilke from a simplistic association with essentialism and complicates Barry and Flitterman's attempt to privilege deconstructive strategies premised on critical distance from the image. For Barry and Flitterman this enables a developmental narrative to emerge in which artists such as Mary Kelly can be seen as politically more sophisticated because they have moved on from essentialism and in the process displaced its apparent naivety in favour of a more conceptual approach. However, some artworks of this period challenge the idea of progress as movement towards the conceptual critique of representation. Rosler's *Vital Statistics*, for example, engages with femininity, identity and embodiment but is also conceptual – the 'conceptual' has not superseded the 'visual' and, therefore, complicates a narrative of progress that favours deconstructive conceptual work.

The pleasures of the gaze that Wilke's work solicits are, according to Jones, 'condemned in the rush to embrace a feminist practice informed by the avant-gardist theories of Bertolt Brecht (one that distances rather than seduces the viewer)' (Jones, 1998, p. 173). Feminist criticisms of Wilke's work of this period are premised on her self-exposure, or what some critics have called her narcissism (Hess in Jones 1998; Liu, 1989). These criticisms are confronted by Jones who is unperturbed by Wilke's use of pleasure and seduction. Joanna Frueh goes further arguing that

'Wilke's self-display, which is erotic play, has always been an affront to proper femininity, which is patriarchy's containment of female possibility' (Frueh, 1996, p. 152). For Frueh, Wilke's work embodies a kind of critical erotics, which offers a refreshing alternative to some forms of austere, joyless intellectual rigour.

Jones' reading of Wilke does not adhere to the reductive linear narrative that underlies Barry and Flitterman's critique, instead claiming Wilke for a phenomenologically inflected feminism of contingency and performative reiteration. This increases her relevance and currency for contemporary artists who operate on the slippery boundary between feminism and femininity. Barry and Flitterman's desire for a model of critical distance is transformed in the writing of Jones into desire for a disorientating, synaesthetic model of immersion, in which the tension between feminism and femininity takes the form of a dynamic and uncertain seduction rather than problematic compliance.

'Precisely because of its very seductiveness (its refusal to "distance" the viewer into a state of critical awareness), Wilke's work operates *within* the frame of aesthetic judgement to highlight its internal contradictions' (Jones, 1998, p. 174).

Using Butler's model of the reiteration of codes, Jones argues that Wilke displaces the objectification of women through a strategic reiteration of narcissism. For Jones, as for Frueh, narcissism is tactical rather than problematic.

Feminist narratives

The consideration of different critical approaches to Wilke's work leads me to position *S.O.S.* outside what Clare Hemmings describes as narratives of progress or loss. Hemmings has argued that the dominant story feminist theory tells about its own history is a highly problematic developmental narrative of either progress or loss, despite the focus on feminisms as multiple and contradictory in recent literature. She describes the *progress* story as 'a shift from the naïve, essentialist seventies, through the black feminist critiques and "sex wars" of the eighties, and into the "difference" nineties and beyond' (Hemmings, 2005, p. 116). As Jackie Stacey has argued, this diachronic developmental narrative is incompatible with the feminist critique of the grand narratives of modernity, adding that 'for feminist theorists influenced by post-structuralism and post-modernism, to be positioned as the Enlightened subjects at the end of a history of Feminist Theory is a contradiction in terms' (Stacey, 1997, p. 76). Alongside the narrative of progress Hemmings charts a

narrative of *loss*, in which the 1970s is associated with a unified sense of political critique that is diminished through the fragmentation and multiplicity of feminisms that have emerged in more recent decades. Both narratives categorize tendencies within feminist theory as specific to particular decades, despite the historiographic approach of some of the feminisms contained within these narratives. For Hemmings this doubled narrative of progress and loss 'oversimplifies different areas of feminist thought and the contests over meaning that characterize feminist debate at all points of its history' (Hemmings, 2005, p. 116). This contestation is exemplified by the different approaches to criticality in the work of Rosler and Wilke.

When mapped on to art historical debate, these observations are a helpful framework through which to interrogate the idea that second-wave feminism necessarily involved a rejection of femininity, a claim challenged by Jones's reading of Wilke's practice. This rejection only remains meaningful inasmuch as it secures the discursive construction of a narrative of loss from second-wave feminist art that renders visible its opposition to dominant representational structures towards work of the 1990s and beyond, understood as recuperated into a capitalist and phallocentric logic in the form of an apolitical individualism. In this narrative of loss it is precisely the *rejection* of femininity-as-image as the dominant form of feminist critique that is lost. This story about the demise of feminist consciousness is premised on an evidential notion of visibility as a property of the artwork; for example, the confrontation with femininity that Barry and Flitterman favour in scripto-visual work that can *be seen to be lost*.

Running parallel to this narrative of loss is a discussion about the relationship of feminist theory to feminist practice. During the 1970s, issues such as the visibility of the body, expectations of sexuality and the performance of femininity were addressed by both artists and theorists. Some of the most well-known figures, such as Catherine Elwes, Joanna Frueh and Mary Kelly, were (and still are) recognized as both feminist practitioners and academics. Indeed their work reminds us that practitioners *are* academics, not only because they often write, but also because they use visual means to interrogate and generate new ideas. Issues connected with visibility, such as how to deal with the representation of a woman's body without reproducing oppressive subject–object relations, were not only theoretical problems, but became a site of struggle for practitioners. The intensely political question of visibility connected feminist theory with representation in works such as Kelly's *Post-Partum Document* (1973–1979), which charts the artist's

relationship with her son through framed documents including feeding charts and stained nappies. The work is a six-part series that focuses on early development phases such as the child's mastery of language and the mother's sense of loss as her son becomes increasingly autonomous. *Post-Partum Document* is informed by feminism and psychoanalysis and contributed significantly to the theoretically informed critique of representation that gained currency in the artworld during the 1980s. It is precisely the *visibility* of the connection between feminist theory and art practice that becomes the object of loss in the characterization of some contemporary women's art practice as non-theoretical.

Narratives of loss of political consciousness are aligned with (women's) art practice in the context of a perceived generational division between artists whose work is informed by theories of representation and artists for whom this is a given part of the cultural landscape and, therefore, not an issue requiring urgent attention. This is not, however, the same as being 'untheoretical'. John Roberts has argued that during the 1990s, contributors to exhibitions such as 'Minky Manky' (South London Gallery, 1995) were discursively constructed as somehow disengaged with theory through the use of exhibition titles that 'mock the assiduousness of theory-led curatorship' (Roberts, 1996, p. 29). Roberts himself employs a developmental understanding of 'new' British artists who have 'moved on' from theoretical positions taught in British universities and art schools during the 1980s and beyond, such as the critique of representation that informs the work of Victor Burgin or Mary Kelly. Roberts argues that the 'institutionalisation of critical theory' in British art schools during the 1980s has produced a generation of artists for whom contemporary art theory has been an enduring pedagogical presence (1996, p. 29). In his characterization of 'new British art' Roberts invokes a generation of artists who have displaced the professionally sanctioned critique of representation in favour of an acknowledgement of the 'enculturalisation of art', which is both produced and consumed in relation to a common set of Western cultural experiences and pleasures (1996, p. 72). However, his exaggeration of generational displacement – out with the 'old' theoretically driven art and in with the 'new' – is an interesting formulation. Roberts' position is aligned with a broader understanding of the critique of representation as a 1980s phenomenon, which he uses in the service of a teleological narrative. Critical interventions in representation have, however, continued in the work of artists associated with the post-structuralist theory-led practice of the 1980s such as Barbara Kruger, Jenny Holzer and the Guerrilla Girls. Furthermore, other forms of critical practice have opened our eyes to

other kinds of theory such as the affective qualities of Emin's work (see Chapter 1) or the immersive character of Pipilotti Rist's projections (see Jones, 2006, pp. 207–242). The influences of queer theory, phenomenology, affect, and developments in post-colonialist thought have all enabled different relations to emerge between critical practice and theory. In other words, the narrative of loss of critical engagement with representation is premised on a limited repertoire of theoretical possibilities.

It is, however, within the context Roberts describes that the increasingly explicit engagement of artists such as Emin and Taylor-Johnson with a range of cultural industries that commodify women in the form of femininity-as-image has been read as loss of critical distance from commodity culture (Ellis, 1998). This is, however, not synonymous with the loss of sexual politics. A discussion of the critical tactics shared by Wilke and the contemporary artists analysed in this book, such as the partial repetition of femininity-as-image discussed below, contests such teleological narratives. By tracing the inter-generational use of mimetic strategies and dialogue between failed and achieved femininity in specific artworks my intention is to suggest that multiplicity and fragmentation have always been at the heart of feminism and its relation to art practice. The revaluation of sidelined narratives of the relationship between femininity and feminism in art produced during the second wave may help to envisage a different kind of politics of the present. I have in mind a less evidential understanding of feminist visuality in art. This enables the consideration of artworks that are not made with any feminist intent and may even be highly problematic from this point of view, yet do not repeat faithfully the gendered norms that they initially project. This matters because the linear form of feminist narrative that Hemmings calls into question is in danger of rendering *invisible* inter-generational feminist traces that do not fit the pattern. Here I concur with Hemmings' desire to suggest 'a way of imagining the feminist past somewhat differently – as a series of ongoing contests and relationships rather than a process of imagined linear displacement' (Hemmings, 2005, p. 131). The feminist trace that I focus on in the next section is unfaithful, or partial, repetition of femininity-as-image. For this we must return to the details of Wilke's *S.O.S.* project.

Unfaithful repetitions

Here, with reference to the visual language of *S.O.S.*, I want to explore the idea that Wilke is both within phallocentric understandings of feminine behaviour, but simultaneously 'elsewhere'. I align this aspect of my

argument with Jones', who carefully situates Wilke as an artist operating *within* normative codes of femininity without entirely capitulating to them. This is an argument that warrants close reading of the details of the artwork. Wilke's engagement with the sexualized femininity she performs in the *S.O.S.* project is variously attentive, disruptive, anticipatory, compliant, fluent, practised and unexpected. It is as if the artist is a participant in an extended conversation with the commodification of her own image. *S.O.S.* can be read as a preoccupation with proximity to an image-ideal that replicates both the gestures of the centrefold and the condition of stasis that I have argued is a necessary aspiration for femininity (see Chapter 2). However, to position *S.O.S.* within a narrative of loss of feminist consciousness, premised on the need to reject femininity-as-image, is to overlook the range of images that comprise the work. The apparent visibility of a particular Western image-ideal is also marked by the loss of other images, the invisibility of what happens in between frames, such that femininity is staccato in form and never fully grasped. There is something about the posed snapshot that focuses attention on what we cannot see, the moments not recorded or the sense of a continuum from which these incidences derive. In a sense, to repeat femininity is to repeat a connection to the invisible. The work leaves out, for example, an explanation of how or why Wilke moves from the pin-up display of her overtly sexualized body, with mouth open and head thrown back, to the use of the headdress to cover her hair and mouth. Other photographs in the series depict Wilke not only dressed, but using her arms and hands to cover her breasts or mouth in a reversal of the developmental rhythm of striptease. Interspersed throughout the images of sexual availability and provocation are images of partial concealment of the body. Concealing takes a number of forms; the covering of the breasts in some of the images has a melancholic feel quite different from the playful part concealment of the breasts in others. Both can be understood as part of the visual repertoire of femininity, but it is precisely the idea that femininity is a diverse vocabulary of poses that Wilke emphasizes.

The photographic images included in *S.O.S.* are arranged in grid formation, although without the logic of rows and columns adhered to in Eleanor Antin's *Carving: A Traditional Sculpture* (1972) and alluded to in Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002) – see Chapter 2. The wall-mounted version of *S.O.S.* has the look of a contact sheet, which again calls forth the preparation involved in creating femininity as an expectation of the gaze. Contact sheets do not prioritize between those images that are preferred and those that are not; they

represent a pre-selective stage that nevertheless reveals the limits of the eventual choice. However, usually contact sheets present a sequence or developmental process of searching for the 'right' shot, for example the one that most accurately approximates a particular gendered ideal or acts out specific codes. Here Wilke has intervened within this developmental logic by changing the order of shots taken, which can be verified using the numbers in the bottom left-hand corner of each photograph – read left to right these are out of order. Wilke submits to the progressively revealing nature of the striptease in some of the individual images, but as a non-sequence they have the potential to function differently. The process is interrupted by an image that covers up the body or, as Goldman notes, by an image in which the facial expression does not appear to correspond to the bodily pose (Goldman, 1998, p. 28). Working between and across different attitudes towards femininity, including movement between failure and achievement in femininity as a project, *S.O.S.* exaggerates the bounded 'choices' from which Wilke selects her poses.

One of the most striking photographs features the combination of veiled mouth and bare breasts with eyes cast down and to the side. In amongst the overall effect of display and flirtation with the camera, Wilke presents us with a powerful reminder of the eroticization of the Other in Orientalist photography. This begs a number of questions. What is the effect of her adoption of these roles? Are they unconscious or deliberate? Does Wilke's engagement with them constitute impersonation or identification? Furthermore, as Diana Fuss has asked, 'is it possible for the mimicking subject to inhabit fully a performative role while still remaining largely outside it? Where, in other words, in a politics of imitation can one locate the politics?' (Fuss, 1995, p. 151).[3]

Drawing on Frantz Fanon, Fuss discusses the 'colonization of subjectivity' by the white power, which employs the notion of the Other to secure imperialist notions of self. Hence the white power appropriates subjectivity exclusively for itself, such that the Other becomes part of the same. In this argument the colonized has no subjectivity (not even as Other), but is reduced to what Fanon calls 'crushing objecthood' (Fanon, 1952). Wilke diverts from the kind of imagery that typified Orientalist photography of the late 19th and early 20th century. She presents the viewer with a white Western Jewish woman/artist who masquerades as a sexualized Orientalist fantasy, but replaces the hijab with a male Arab headdress. In her cross dressing Wilke's position becomes ambiguous. Her subjectivity as an artist prevents her from being reduced to crushing objecthood, but her mimicry of Orientalist

photography is problematic. In some of the photographs Wilke emphasizes the covering of the mouth, sometimes using her hands to further exaggerate this pose. However, the connection drawn between veiling and silencing says more about the artist's own Western gaze than the imitation of the codes of Orientalist photography. Reina Lewis has argued that Middle Eastern women have often used veiling and seclusion as a form of resistance to colonial intervention (Lewis, 2004, p. 98). Hence, veiling is sometimes a response to the presence of the colonizer. The combination of a covered mouth and male headdress turns a potentially critical gender ambiguity into a realization of the Occidental assumptions of Wilke's own viewing. Wilke signals a dichotomy between masculinized authority (signified by the male headdress) and feminized passivity (signified by the veil). However, this relies on a Western assumption that veiling can only be understood as having a silencing effect.[4]

The sexualization of racial difference, which characterizes Orientalist fantasies of femininity, is constructed primarily in relation to male visual pleasure. Wilke's relation to this hinges on the extent to which she identifies with such pleasures or impersonates them. In many of the other images that comprise *S.O.S.* Wilke strategizes what Homi K. Bhabha has described as the colonizer's desire for an Other who is 'a subject of a difference that is almost the same, but not quite' (Bhabha, 1994, p. 122). Bhabha argues that the excess or slippage involved in colonial mimicry (he cites the difference between being Anglicized and being English) produces a difference that is necessary for colonial power. However, Bhabha goes on to argue that the part-repetition involved in mimicry (nearly, but not quite) 'articulates those disturbances of cultural, racial and historical difference that menace the narcissistic demand of colonial authority' (Bhabha, 1994, p. 126). Wilke's part-repetition of Orientalist sexualized femininity is in danger of entrenching the Occidental assumptions of her own viewing (and perhaps also mine), ironically because her performance is too different from the imagery she references. It is the subtlety with which Wilke enacts a near-repetition of Western sexualized femininity in the other photographs in the series that enables her to comment on femininity as a masquerade developed in relation to practised gestures. Wilke's attempt to part-repeat a form of Otherness that is, in fact, other to her own experience is less successful because it loses the subtle slippage of the 'nearly but not quite'.

If, as British psychoanalyst Joan Rivière argued, womanliness is a form of masquerade, the range of femininities on offer in *S.O.S.* suggests a subjectivity that is lacking in Rivière's original argument. Rivière

published an influential article in 1929 in which she argued that the masquerade functions as an anxious and unconscious defence mechanism designed to avert reprisals from men. In her studies of professional women, Rivière noted their compulsive need to compensate for the 'theft' of the phallus/authority (it is not rightfully theirs) by exaggerating or flaunting their femininity (Rivière, 1986, p. 38). In her reworking of Rivière, Mary Ann Doane explains that, 'after assuming the position of the subject of discourse rather than its object, the intellectual woman whom Rivière analyses felt compelled to compensate for this theft of masculinity by overdoing the gestures of feminine flirtation' (Doane, 1992, pp. 234–235). For Rivière, femininity is a mask designed to hide the woman's transvestism, her temporary adoption of masculinity. Here, masquerade is compensatory rather than strategic, unconscious rather than deliberate. Masquerade suggests an exaggeration of visibility, an excess of gestures that are visibly familiar. However, the extent to which this operates unconsciously, as a source of reassurance that power has not been 'stolen' from those to whom it belongs, is highly contested. In *S.O.S.* the unfaithful repetitions of different forms of femininity point to Wilke as an artist, tactical and deliberate rather than defensive and compensatory. From the sexualized femininity of the centrefold to that formed in relation to, but not consistent with, an Orientalist photographic imagination, Wilke's multiple guises suggest a subject behind these masquerades with the requisite skill to enact different femininities. She takes on the masculinized identity of an artist, but any reassurance that her power is a charade is complicated, if not thwarted, by the knowingness of her attitude. By turning herself into a flirtatious object Wilke appears to be heightening the perception of her lack of power in an attempt to protect herself from the revenge she expects. However, she then punctures the illusion by drawing attention to the very imaging process that should allay the threat that she poses. This is the ambiguity of the work. She cannot both fulfil the compensatory aspect of the masquerade, as it is described in Rivière's account as an unconscious defence mechanism, while simultaneously pointing to the details of this process, which is a conscious operation. The latter cancels out the effect of the former.

Rather than disguising her adoption of masculinity (as an artist) the unfaithful repetitions of *S.O.S.* point directly to it. It takes knowledge of the repetition of normative behaviour, the ability to see it for what it is, to manufacture an 'almost copy'. In *S.O.S.* this takes place at the level of both gendered and racialized objectification. Wilke approximates the image that colonialism offers to the colonized of themselves in a kind of

double mime, up to the point where she transgresses gendered codes of dress. The post-colonialist argument that the colonized are expected to submit to an imposed vision of themselves, what Fuss calls 'an injunction to *mime* alterity', is itself enacted in *S.O.S.*, despite my reservations about the position from which Wilke views this process (Fuss, 1995, p. 146, original emphasis). She enacts the way in which the construction of the Other is used to secure a sense of subjectivity in the self, not by imitating cultural difference, but by imitating the *effects of its imaging* in Orientalist photography. This double mime, or doubled dissimulation, ultimately installs Wilke's subjectivity both as an artist and as a woman, practised in the labour necessary to produce the image expected of her.

Malleable signifiers

S.O.S. demonstrates a desire to reinstate subjectivity as a sexualized woman/artist through the very mechanisms that are supposed to ensure its renunciation. The artful slippage from pleasure in the commodification of her image to unfaithful repetitions of the same resists the binary logic of either/or. Instead, Wilke drives a wedge between impersonation and identification so that, despite the possibility of the former collapsing into the latter, the conscious act of unfaithful repetition comes into focus. The gap between impersonation and identification is precisely where the politics of *S.O.S.* is located, uncertain and precarious though it may be. Nowhere is this more effectively demonstrated than in Wilke's use of chewing gum, her politics of femininity ironically enabled by a sign of working-class sexual availability.

The use of chewing gum is interesting because it is conventionally coded as low cultural, ephemeral and cheap, and functions as a signifier of Americanized consumer culture. As the ultimate disposable commodity the chewed gum is connected to Pop Art, but retains a preoccupation with formal properties characteristic of Minimalism. The work alludes to the 'scars' left on women by a market economy in which they are traded as commodities, and can be contextualized through the 1970s feminist critique, particularly in the UK, of both patriarchy and capitalism. Here chewing gum represents the attitude of a disposable consumer culture taken to its logical conclusion, a malleable commodity that is literally used up and spat out. However, Wilke wears the used-up gum as a scar or as bodily adornment, lending it permanence and a range of possible, even contradictory, meanings. The planned obsolescence of gum as both material and sign has been stopped in its tracks, as if Wilke has pressed the pause button on her interaction with consumer culture.

In slowing that interaction down, Wilke makes the signifying possibilities of gum available to scrutiny. There is a manipulation of pace, which resonates with some contemporary work. In Chapter 7 I explore the tampering of pace in the work of Beecroft and Taylor-Johnson. Both of these artists share with Wilke a desire to change our temporal relation to highly commodified images, albeit in a post-VCR technological context not available to Wilke in the 1970s, which enabled viewers to partially control time by pausing, rewinding and fast-forwarding scenes.

The shapes stuck to Wilke's body are reminiscent of the carelessness involved in sticking unwanted gum to the nearest surface, but the symmetry with which they are placed references the purposeful arrangement of jewellery or African scarification wounds. In an artist's statement from 1977 Wilke spoke of the chewing-gum forms as marking the body not only as female, but also as Jewish: 'To also remember that as a Jew, during the war, I would have been branded and buried had I not been born in America. Starification-Scarification' (Wilke in Reckitt & Phelan, 2001, p. 107). The more specific reference to racial othering within *S.O.S.* speaks to Orientalist photography rather than the artist's Jewish identity. There is, nevertheless, a layering of identities at work on the surface of Wilke's body: woman, artist, Jew, American, feminist, flirt. In its physical attachment to the body, the gum is an explicit expression of this and functions as a malleable sign, both literally and culturally. However, the amassing of these signs has the effect of highlighting their habitual separation, the difficulty of being perceived as flirt *and* feminist, woman *and* artist. It is in the combinations of identities and visual signifiers that the work is at its most powerful. The notion of embodying that which is usually discarded in consumer culture, ending up as an abject irritant stuck to the sole of a shoe, has a historically specific resonance both in terms of the Holocaust and for a feminist politics charged with challenging women's devalued status as either exchange value or consumer.

The chewing-gum forms that scar/adorn Wilke's head and torso coexist with (if not puncture) the smooth repetition of an image. In one particularly arresting photograph her hair and mouth are covered and where we might expect to see long manicured nails we in fact find chewing-gum 'scars', which appear almost monstrous in their departure from the conventionally sexualized images that we have come to expect within the visual repertoire of the work. The chewing-gum nails do not function as a transgressive form in and of themselves, but in relation to the expectations provoked by the work's partial compliance with centrefold femininity. Where painted nails usually connote a smooth and sealed

exterior surface, here they suggest an internal, gruesome, vaginal space. The chewing-gum nails are somewhere in between the internal space and external surface of Wilke's body. They refuse to form a boundary to the body and confuse the borders that, as Mary Douglas has argued, are necessary to maintain order (Douglas, 1991). Lynda Nead (in part quoting from Laura Mulvey) connects the tradition of the female nude, as a form that shores up a sense of wholeness and containment, to the fear that the clarity of the categories of subject and object, inside and outside, may be breached: 'The cosmetically finished surface of the body must conceal the abject matter of the interior of the female body; and in psychoanalytic terms, this cosmetic surface "conceals the wound or void left in the male psyche when it perceives sexual difference"' (Nead, 1992, p. 66).

In its participatory forms *S.O.S.* engaged the senses of touch and smell as well as sight. The mouth became the facilitator of exchange as participants chewed the pieces of gum, which was then handled by Wilke and attached to her body. The subsequent loss of boundary between the bodies of audience members and artist, the sharing of saliva and touching something that has been in another's mouth all point to Wilke's knowing response to the idea of abjection (Kristeva, 1982). She traverses the social order by dismantling distinctions between inside and outside the body.

Saundra Goldman describes the introduction of this provocative vaginal imagery into Wilke's work as the visual device that led into her 'mature feminist works' (Goldman, 1998, p. 11). What constitutes 'mature' feminism is an interesting question. Here Goldman writes about Wilke's use of vaginal forms without this aspect of her work being over-determined by the 'problem' of essentialism cited by Barry and Flitterman. She does not perpetuate the progress narrative by which feminist art history tells its own story from naïve essentialism towards fragmentation and difference. Far from an essentializing feature of the work, the chewing-gum sculptures demonstrate Wilke's ability to exploit the malleability of such signs.

This chapter has argued that Wilke's *S.O.S.* project can be understood as an unfaithful repetition of femininity-as-image in a number of ways. The non-sequencing of photographic imagery, the double mime of racial otherness and the re-signification of chewing gum are mimetic strategies that manufacture a gap between imitation and identification. This has implications for the stories that feminist art history tells about which artworks are to be valued and why. The dominance of feminist art historical narratives premised on critical distance is in danger of

obscuring alternative stories, such as the critical potential of artworks that seduce rather than distance the viewer. This leaves us without a language to describe the traces of mimetic work in contemporary art that is ambiguous or uneven in its identification with feminism. Certainty and consistency are not always a prerequisite for feminist criticality. Wilke's affiliation with feminism fluctuated. She identified more with a post-Minimalist exploration of process and materials, even publicly warning against rigid judgements in a poster that proclaimed 'Marxism and Art: Beware of Fascist Feminism' (1977). Here she appeared alongside a provocative photograph from the *S.O.S.* series confronting the spectator with her shirt open, hands on hips, wearing a tie and decorated with chewing-gum sculptures. It is also a confrontation with feminist critical discourse, demanding that her combination of seduction and political ambiguity be taken seriously.

5
Critical Mimesis: Hannah Wilke's Double Address

In Chapter 4 I argued that unfaithful or partial repetition is an important strategy in Hannah Wilke's work of the mid-1970s. In particular, I focussed on a project Wilke developed in 1974–1975 called *Starification Object Series (S.O.S.)*. In this chapter I develop this idea of unfaithful repetition further by reading Wilke's interaction with femininity as a form of critical mimicry. This term is borrowed from the work of Belgian philosopher and psychoanalyst Luce Irigaray. The books for which this aspect of Irigaray's work is best known were written in the 1970s: *Speculum of the Other Woman* in 1974 and *This Sex Which is Not One* in 1977, after Wilke had been working on the *S.O.S.* project. However, they were not translated into English until 1985, so even *Speculum of the Other Woman* is unlikely to have influenced Wilke at this time. There is, nevertheless, an uncanny affinity between Irigaray's concept of mimicry, which is both philosophical and political, and Wilke's art practice. Despite the fact that 'theories' are often 'applied' to artworks, as if the latter is ultimately destined only to illustrate the former, I became aware of Irigaray's work through an ongoing fascination with Wilke's practice. I wanted to find a critical language with which to pursue the 'nearly but not quite' character of Wilke's enactments of femininity because I felt this was important for understanding the work of contemporary artists who use the female body as commodified material. There is a dialogue to be set in motion between Wilke and Irigaray, which extends to their approaches to feminism. Both have spoken about feminism with a degree of scepticism. In Wilke's case guarding against the ideological proscriptions of what she called fascist feminism and in Irigaray's case a desire to work outside the sociological understanding of feminism. What matters to Irigaray is that women discover who they are without trying to adapt to the existing social order. Only then will women locate female subjectivity and desire.

By reading Wilke's work through the critical reception of Irigaray, which has developed since the 1980s, I am using ideas that could not have influenced Wilke's practice in the mid-1970s. Nancy Princenthal has argued that the tendency to understand Wilke through more recent conceptual frameworks, specifically the post-structuralist construction of subjectivity in language, is ahistorical and does not do justice to the 'force of will' of Wilke's art (Princenthal, 2010, p. 13). One example of such a framework is the interaction of Irigaray's work with the post-structuralist philosophy of Jacques Derrida, which is discussed in this chapter. As a form of art history this approach is not linear or chronological and neither is it rooted in the cultural and philosophical concerns of the period in which Wilke's work was produced. However, rather than ahistorical I understand this approach as differently historical in its capacity to forge inter-generational links that are irreducible either to the moment of art production or to the time of our interpretation.

The notion of time in this chapter picks up on the last chapter's concept of repetition, but considers it in spatial terms. Critical mimicry depends on the simultaneous inhabiting of two different spaces: the space of repeating feminine norms and the space from which this can be knowingly observed. The split between repetition of the same and a critical part-repetition is also visual. It requires a kind of split subjectivity in which a woman looks at herself performing the repetition from another space. My aim is to explore how this operates in *S.O.S.* and what the implications are for contemporary practice. With this in mind I consider the collaboration between Angela Ellsworth and Tina Takemoto, which I introduce towards the end of the chapter.

(Un)fulfilled transactions: Woman as exchange value

In *S.O.S.* Wilke addresses the production of woman-as-commodity, maintaining a dual relationship to the objectification and commodification of her own body. On the one hand, she submits to the very gaze that many of her feminist contemporaries were trying to disable through strategies of deconstruction and distanciation. On the other hand, she is the author of the piece and is, therefore, aligned with other artists of the 1960s and 1970s who made themselves both subject and object of the gaze, moving in and out of sexualized femininity, notably Carolee Schneeman in works such as *More Than Meat Joy* (1964). The relationship of these artists to the idea of woman-as-commodity is multi-faceted and contingent on the historical and political circumstances of their reception.



Figure 5.1 Hannah Wilke, *S.O.S. Starification Object Series: An Adult Game of Mastication*, detail (1974–1975), mixed media installation, grid of 28 black-and-white gelatin silver prints, 5 × 7 inches each. Musée d'Art Modern, Centre Pompidou, Paris. Donation by Centre Pompidou Foundation and partial gift of Marsie, Emanuelle, Damon, and Andrew Scharlatt, Hannah Wilke Collection and Archive, Los Angeles. Copyright Marsie, Emanuelle, Damon, and Andrew Scharlatt/Licensed by VAGA, New York, DACS, London

Irigaray has argued that women function only as exchange value in a 'between-men' culture, 'an occasion for mediation, transaction, transition, transference, between man and his fellow man' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 193). Women are denied ownership of the exchange value they represent because this is an effect of relations between at least two men. Commodities do not exist in and of themselves, as if autonomous and self-determining; rather they exist only in relation to those subjects amongst whom they become the object of transaction, as 'objects that emblematize the materialization of relations among men' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 185). In this sense economic transactions are understood as homosexual, part of a between-men culture.

Wilke exaggerated the exchange value of her own image by presenting *S.O.S.* as a boxed game entitled *S.O.S. Starification Object Series: An Adult Game of Mastication*, 1974–1975 (see figure 5.1). Her playful approach to titling sets up an expectation of innuendo and knowingness that is borne out by the details of the work. The box set includes packets of chewing gum, encased pieces of moulded gum, twenty-eight photographs hung on the wall in the form of a grid, forty-eight numbered playing cards featuring stills of Wilke, one larger single image and further loose images of Wilke, six boxes of Chiclets (a brand of chewing gum coated in candy) and instructions for how to play the game. Players were to choose a flavour of gum and chew it. They would then turn over a card, which would select a pose, and give the gum to Wilke to sculpt and place on her body. When presented in the form of a boxed card game Wilke makes explicit the trading of her image, complete with chewing gum tabs that resemble the kind of currency often found in board games. However, Wilke disrupts our expectations because as an art object this game will never be played in the conventional sense. It is held in aspic, preserved and untouched rather than used and worn out. Now owned by the Centre Pompidou, Paris, the game is displayed in a glass case as a museum piece. Furthermore, Princenthal notes that the game's instructions included one rule that was never met: in order to participate in the game a player would 'rent' Wilke for $1,500 (Princenthal, 2010, p. 53). The productive failure of the work emerges through Wilke's use of irony and humour. It is in the promise of a transaction – a game that bears all the hallmarks of trading, using and exchanging Wilke's image – that will never be kept.

Irigaray reminds us that 'commodities can only enter into relationships under the watchful eyes of their "guardians"' adding that 'it is out of the question for them to go to "market" on their own, enjoy their own worth among themselves, speak to each other, desire each other, free from the control of seller-buyer-consumer subjects' (Irigaray, 1985a,

p. 196). Although *S.O.S: An Adult Game* does not invoke the reciprocity suggested here between commodities 'among themselves' it has been taken to market in a dual sense. The reference to pornography in the title (an adult game) refers to the trading of woman as image-ideal within a sexual economy and its existence as an artwork refers to the trading of such objects within the art market (not mutually exclusive categories). In short, there is more than one market at stake. While this does not directly address Irigaray's important question about the possibility of commodities refusing to go to market, it does multiply our understanding of the market(s) and Wilke's shifting position within them. Wilke converts the staging of the part-failure to achieve femininity into the acquisition of cultural capital enabled by entry into the artworld. By acquiring status as an artist she is recompensed for her existence as exchange value and for the labour intensity that characterizes femininity.

Mimicry as double address

Wilke adopts a mimetic strategy in which femininity-as-image, understood via Irigaray as an opportunity for the realization of transactions between men, is not repeated accurately. For Irigaray, mimicry requires that women deliberately stage the failure of complete repetition in order to suggest that they are something other than the meaning assigned to them by oppressive discourses. She argues that 'one must assume the feminine role deliberately. Which means already to convert a form of subordination into an affirmation, and thus to begin to thwart it' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 76). Performing the feminine role can only become strategically useful if women present themselves as highly conversant in the required behaviour. Like Elizabeth Manchester's *All My Dresses with All My Shoes* (2002), discussed in Chapter 2, Wilke's *S.O.S.* suggests the time spent practising femininity, as if femininity is something that only exists inasmuch as it is rehearsed. In re-presenting the behaviours they have learnt, both Wilke and Manchester demonstrate their consciousness of the expectation to conduct themselves in a particular way. They select this behaviour from a field of possible actions, rather than simply consenting to the ideologically preferred image regime. It is a tactic that illuminates the very structures of femininity-as-image that are supposed to keep them from discovering feminine subjectivity and language.

'To play with mimesis is thus, for a woman, to try to recover the place of her exploitation by discourse, without allowing herself to be simply reduced to it. It means to resubmit herself … to ideas about herself that are elaborated in/by a masculine logic, but so as to make "visible", by an

effect of playful repetition, what was supposed to remain invisible: the cover-up of a possible operation of the feminine in language' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 76).

The humour and play at work in mimicry needs to be derived from the very position that the strategy aims to undermine. Hence, where women are pitted against each other as commodities in the service of male desires, Wilke speaks from this position, but does so unfaithfully (or incompletely) in order to expose the masculine economy that naturalizes the commodification and standardization of women. This strategy depends on a demonstration of competence. Other artists have reconfigured feminine competence differently for the purpose of exposing its cultural (rather than natural) attachment to women. In Martha Rosler's contemporaneous work *Semiotics of the Kitchen* (1975) the artist performs as deliberately incompetent at feminine 'duties' from the start, never adopting the position she wishes to defamiliarize. Rosler stands behind a kitchen counter and goes through the alphabet miming the use of implements: A is for apron, B is for bowl and so on. Rosler stabs at the pan for ice pick and pretends to throw something out of the window for ladle. Indeed, part of the humour is in the lack of care, dexterity and domestic 'know-how' displayed by the artist as she wields kitchen implements as weapons against domestic servitude in a deadpan A–Z show and tell routine. Bobby Baker, on the other hand, has more recently performed kitchen pieces that involve her own kind of domestic competence, albeit one that signals the absurdity of conventional domesticity. Baker's performance piece entitled *Cook Dems*, which was commissioned in 1990 by Third Eye Centre, Glasgow, involves a demonstration of unusual bread products such as 'Baked Antlers worn to improve your status, Breast Pizza personalised with your own heraldic devices – strap it on and feel secure' and 'Bread Ball Skirt that is wonderful to dance in' (Baker, online, 2006). While Rosler is deliberately incompetent at performing domestic femininity and Baker is deliciously inappropriate in her competence, Wilke adopts a different strategy, putting her sexual competence to effective mimetic use. Crucially, mimesis requires a dual position in relation to femininity: 'it also means to "unveil" the fact that, if women are such good mimics, it is because they are not simply resorbed in this function. *They also remain elsewhere:* another case of the persistence of "matter", but also of "sexual pleasure"' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 76, original emphasis). What Wilke's critical mimicry makes visible is an alternative space not accounted for in a between-men culture.

Mimicry thus depends upon a series of skills, the acquisition of which implies familiarity not only with the conventions of a particular form

of femininity, but with the exact gestures required to embody it. Wilke can only interrupt the poses of the striptease to the extent that the viewer is convinced of the familiarity of the poses in the first place. Skills have to be practised and femininity experienced as something that must be strived for, despite remaining continually out of reach. However, competence at these skills enables more than submission to a masculinized sexual economy if the performance of femininity enables women to look at what they are performing, to be conscious of the performance, rather than to be subsumed by it. Thus mimicry suggests a double address: both proximity to the image-ideal and a simultaneous 'elsewhere' from which this proximity can be observed.

The other side of patriarchy

Irigaray's call to retrieve the feminine position or to take on a feminine role has been interpreted as essentializing, for example by Monique Plaza, who in 1978 claimed that 'to found a field of study on this belief in the inevitability of natural sex differences can only compound patriarchal logic and not subvert it' (Plaza quoted in Burke et al., 1994, p. 51). Wilke's work was also chastized as essentialist by, for example, Barry and Flitterman, who favoured scripto-visual work that could be seen to be deconstructive (see Chapter 4 for a more detailed explanation of Barry and Flitterman's position). Margaret Whitford (1994) has argued that the critique of female specificity united critics from a range of disciplinary backgrounds, despite, as Naomi Schor has noted, the incompatibility of various positions grouped together under the umbrella term of essentialism. Furthermore, Schor argues that the position from which Irigaray was attacked for expounding an ahistorical and universalist biological causality was itself lacking an acknowledgement of its own historical contingency. The adequacy of the debate between essentialism and anti-essentialism is called into question when, as Schor describes, 'by the end of the eighties the very anti-essentialism that had attacked essentialism for its universalism had assumed the status of a universal value' (Schor, 1994, p. 7).

The reception of Irigaray's earlier translated work is an example of a narrative of progress in which an understanding of feminist politics as anti-essentialist is drawn, like a magnet, to critique ideas about female specificity, as if these ideas always stop at the point of biological interiority. Schor reminds us that some of the earliest essays that engaged with Irigaray did not connect her with essentialism, but that the dominance of the anti-essentialist critique steered the reception of

Irigaray's work away from alternative interpretations. For Whitford, the essentialism of Irigaray's work in *This Sex Which Is Not One* functions differently, as a 'moment of becoming' rather than a goal (1994, p. 12). The inhabiting of a specifically feminine role is necessary as a tactic, a means to a strategic end rather than an end in itself. In any case, to inhabit a feminine *role* is not the same as suggesting a biologically or psychically determinant universalism premised on sexual difference. The former suggests an active detachment from femininity because a 'role' is something that must be 'played'. Furthermore, the idea of feminine language is not the same as assuming a feminine role, although both concepts are employed by Irigaray to discuss mimicry. Irigaray's writing on mimicry does not appear monolithic in its approach to femininity and cannot be contained by straightforward divisions between essentialism and anti-essentialism. The critique of Wilke's work on the grounds of its perceived essentialism shares this understanding of the biological as an end in itself, for example in the emphasis on the chewing gum as vaginal. It is as if the ambiguity of the shapes formed by the gum is over-determined by the need to critique any notion of biological causality, which must be denied in post-structuralist inflected feminist art criticism. As I have argued in Chapter 4 the gum is culturally loaded with references to American popular culture and Pop Art. As a product of chewing, the gum sculptures are both the result of a bodily process and of cultural encoding.

Alternative readings of critical mimesis understand it as a deconstructive concept in dialogue with Derrida's critique of metaphysics. This is a helpful analytical framework with which to make sense of the strategic element of Wilke's *S.O.S.* project (Burke, Schor and Whitford, 1994).[1] If there is no language available for women to articulate their own desires, they have to work from *within* the given symbolic order as a first stage towards an alternative mode of articulation, which is an argument that Amelia Jones has made of Wilke's work (1998). Irigaray's call for women to deliberately inhabit a feminine role can, in this sense, be understood as a strategy of re-inscribing binary oppositions. Derrida's critique of metaphysics involves recognizing structures of thought as couplets, such as male/female, text/supplement, self/other or inside/outside. Working from within the binary structure, which assumes the priority of one term and sees the other term only in relation to the first, Derrida's tactic is first to reverse the violent hierarchy of the terms. By arguing that neither term is wholly manifest without the other – for example, without an 'other' there is no 'self' to privilege in the first place – deconstruction suggests the possibility of reinterpreting the very organizational structures

that give rise to binary oppositions. They cannot be eclipsed because they are necessary for us to make sense of the world. Hierarchies will be re-established, but in different conceptual formations giving rise to different structures of thought.

This reinterpretation of the conceptual groundwork is distinguished from the reversal of unequally positioned terms, which, on its own, would do nothing to change the premises upon which uneven power relations are based. Here Derrida speaks of the 'irruptive emergence of a new "concept", a concept which no longer allows itself to be understood in terms of the previous regime' (Derrida cited in Spivak, 'Translator's Preface', 1976, p. lxxvii). Just as Derrida works from within the logocentric binary order to reverse the hierarchy of terms, as a necessary stage towards disrupting the logic upon which such notions of hierarchy and opposition are based, Irigaray acknowledges that 'there is no simple, manageable way to leap to the outside of phallogocentrism, nor any possible way to situate oneself there, that would result from the simple fact of being a woman' (Irigaray, 1985a, p. 76). Both Derrida and Irigaray acknowledge the impossibility of stepping outside of that which they seek to change. For Irigaray, deconstructing binary polarities means occupying the devalued feminine term excessively and consciously, rather than tacitly, in order that the conceptual framework that conventionally supports the notion of woman as derivative, or as supplementary, is itself displaced. What emerges is the potential for a different kind of 'space', on the other side of patriarchy, in which the possibility of finding a language for female desire is not foreclosed or entrapped by what is currently available. Burke describes the purpose of Irigaray's deconstructive strategy in similarly spatial terms, understanding it as 'preoedipal or postpatriarchal, or, as the place of a desire. It is a site where women's relations to each other might acquire appropriate expression' (Burke, 1994, p. 45). Words such as 'place', 'elsewhere' and 'site' signal a connection between the repetition involved in mimicry and a space inaccessible to patriarchy, even if this is as-yet only imagined.

Read through this narrative positioning of Irigaray's writing on mimicry, Wilke's *S.O.S.* speaks from *within* a phallocentric image regime, but not only *to* it. It also speaks to other women for whom the practice and temporal rhythm of femininity as project is familiar at the level of experience. This sense of 'elsewhere' is what emerges in Irigaray's work as the *place* of women's relations to each other. When considered alongside Wilke's practice of unfaithful repetition a spatialization of time occurs, whereby the part-repetition opens up a space not already colonized by patriarchal law. This might offer a between-women moment of

knowingness and delight in the danger they pose by operating on the margins of patriarchy.

Whitford's argument that the critique of Irigaray on grounds of essentialism is premised on a mistaken belief that essentialism constitutes the final stage rather than a part of an eventually strategic process, can also be applied to Barry and Flitterman's (1987) dismissal of the feminist potency of Wilke's work. Where they read Wilke's inclusion of vaginal forms as politically reductive, Irigaray's concept of mimicry can engage in a different kind of dialogue with the *S.O.S.* project, in which playing out a range of femininities is understood as a stage rather than the entire journey. Indeed, Wilke reincarnated the project in a number of forms, never really settling at a clear destination. In the photographs that form part of the series, femininity-as-image appears in many different guises as something that is achieved, failed, wanted, refused or resigned to. It is, however, never simply consented to as if it is a natural state of being. Indeed, just as Schor argues that Irigaray's desire for feminine language (*parler-femme*) is less about female specificity and more about dismantling the assumption of a universal (male) subject – 'to speak woman is, above all, not to "speak universal"' (Schor, 1994, p. 64) – Wilke uses irony and parody to point to the artifice of the construction of femininity-as-image, not to uphold it. Her relevance to contemporary women's practice that employs the visual and linguistic rhetorics of objectification and woman-as-commodity is precisely in her use of this language to say something else.

Duplicity and artifice

Wilke uses the language of photography to excessively perform the objectification of women, including the genres of glamour, fashion and Orientalist fantasy (see Chapter 4). Other artists have explored this through the history of painting and sculpture. Ellsworth and Takemoto's collaborations explore a number of themes such as illness, racial identity, sexuality, friendship and empathy.[2] Their *Her/She Senses* series of performances include appropriations of paintings and sculptures by Vermeer and Bernini. *Her/She Senses Eroto Electric* (2003) is a spectacularly unfaithful repetition of Bernini's *Saint Teresa in Ecstasy* (1645–1652). It is both a performance and installation featuring Ellsworth dressed as a disco diva and Takemoto in geisha costume. There is also a soundtrack in which the words of a conventional optimistic chart song about finding love are spoken slowly over a pop beat. Ellsworth describes it as 'a tableau vivant of ecstatic and electrifying proportions' in which the

artists 'hump and grind amidst chopsticks, light bulbs, and other objects of crass seduction' (Ellsworth, online, 2006). They use the erotic charge of the Bernini sculpture, but transpose this into a dazzling performance about inter-racial identification and lesbian desire.

Takemoto discusses her own work alongside Cindy Sherman's *History Portraits* and Yasumasa Morimura's mimicry of old masters, which make visible the tendency of European art history to naturalize gender and racial norms. Here Takemoto employs the notion of 'specular correspondence' as a critical mechanism through which Sherman and Morimura reproduce themselves by holding up a mirror to European masterpieces. Takemoto describes specular correspondence as 'a visual response to a work based on mirroring, doubling and distorting by producing a looking-glass into the past and creating a dialogue with the present' (Takemoto, 2004, p. 48). This sets up an exchange between the past and the present and becomes the occasion for unfaithful repetition. She uses the example of Cindy Sherman's version of a 15th-century Madonna and Child, in which the artist dresses up as the Madonna, but removes the anticipated reverie by wearing an overly artificial prosthetic breast and holding a plastic baby. The absurdity of the breast in Sherman's version highlights its exaggeration in medieval and Renaissance depictions of the Madonna. Invoking the idea that the mirror that Sherman holds up to the gendered conventions of representation is cracked and therefore distorts what it sees, Takemoto argues that Sherman problematizes the representation of femininity. The mirror that Sherman holds up to European art history reflects both too little and too much; the reflections are simultaneously 'inadequate to the logic of mastery and excessive to the logic of the same' (Takemoto, 2004, p. 48). The specular correspondence of Sherman's work is, for Takemoto, a critical strategy that enables a space to open up between the original work, or artistic genre, and its reproduction. She argues this through Irigaray's claim that 'a disruptive excess is possible on the feminine side' (Irigaray in Takemoto, 2004, p. 54).

In *Her/She Senses Eroto Electric* Ellsworth and Takemoto perform culturally different types of femininity excessively to expose the gap between 'woman' as a fixed and universal sign and the diversity of women artists who play with it in historically and culturally specific contexts. As a strategy it chimes with film theorist Mary Ann Doane's work on masquerade. Doane reads the excessive display of femininity in film not as a placatory compensation for the appropriation of masculinized subjectivity, as in Rivière's account, but as a strategy for exposing the artificiality of the image and the staged character of representation. In

so doing Doane argues that the masquerade 'holds [femininity] at a distance' (Doane, 1992, p. 235). In this sense distance is manufactured not by attempting to step outside patriarchal structures of the look (as favoured by Mulvey's interest in a feminist counter-cinema), but by exaggerating the accoutrements of femininity such that their constructed character is made available for manipulation. This is not the space of critical distance so much as the simulation of a gap articulated through excessive display.

Doane works with the idea that female spectatorship is characterized by a nearness or 'over-identification' with the image, which is premised on psychoanalytic understandings of sexual difference in which only boys are able to displace their initial object of desire (their mother). Girls are positioned differently in relation to structures of looking, as Doane explains: 'For the female spectator there is a certain overpresence of the image – she *is* the image. Given the closeness of this relationship, the female spectator's desire can be described only in terms of a kind of narcissism – the female look demands a becoming' (Doane, 1992, p. 231).

The female spectator is unable to experience the distance necessary for voyeurism and is therefore unable to disengage from the image.[3] The position offered to women in relation to the image is one of claustrophobic proximity and hence women are understood as unable to critically engage with the very cultural forms that proliferate their image – what Doane describes as 'the eviction of the female spectator from a discourse purportedly about her' (Doane, 1992, p. 230). It is not surprising, therefore, that the discursive construction of feminist art has tended to include those works that demonstrate distance from patriarchal structures of representation and has, at times, been hesitant to include works such as Wilke's *S.O.S.* that allow viewers to identify with visual pleasures of the gaze. Takemoto's reading of Cindy Sherman's *History Portraits* uses the notion of 'specular correspondence' to articulate the distance forged between the portrait and its unfaithful repetition in denial of the overbearing proximity of woman to her own image. This is a knowing, conscious and deliberate tactic, akin to Doane's reading of the strategic nature of masquerade in cinema. Nevertheless, proponents of critical mimesis, myself included, need to acknowledge the tendency to invoke authorial intent as a distinguishing factor that stands between unfaithful repetition and perpetuation of women-as-commodity. As Carole-Anne Tyler observes, theorists of mimicry often premise their argument about the production of such 'differences' on a notion of encoding and decoding: 'They appeal to a notion of authorial intention when they want to read parody, irony,

or "difference" into what might be a mere repetition of the same, an instance of imitation or even "plagiarism". After having thus produced this difference, they find it "in the text itself", just where the author "intended" it to be' (Tyler, 2003, p. 24).

The idea of authorial intent has been heavily challenged most famously by Roland Barthes in his essay 'Death of the Author' (1977, originally published in 1967) and Michel Foucault in 'What Is An Author?' (1977, originally delivered as a lecture in 1969). This work has been highly influential to cultural criticism and enabled an understanding of the historical and cultural contingency of meaning, its dependence on changing contexts and conditions of reception. To ground a critical strategy in authorial intent is, therefore, problematic. The critical mimesis of feminine norms cannot be anchored in the artist's intentions or secured by an enduring meaning attachment to the artwork irrespective of its contexts of consumption. It is not necessarily repeatable or sustainable. The space of potential for female desire only exists to the extent that viewers are convinced of Wilke's ambiguous, doubled position. It is a risky business, which is as uncertain as it is effective.

The use of artifice in such works is tied to a history of femininity as duplicitous and fake. It is an idea that permeates everyday Western practices of femininity in phrases such as 'making up', 'putting your face on' or references to 'war paint'. The implication is that being a woman involves pretending to be something you are not. This is what Efrat Tseëlon describes as the 'duplicity paradox' in which the woman is constructed, both theologically and psychoanalytically, as fake and artificial, only to then be chastised for her lack of essence or authenticity (Tseëlon, 1995, p. 34). In theological discourse woman's crime is to try to improve on God's work. The applying of make up or the dying of hair is cast as a false impression, a disguise or illusion with which to entrap and destroy men. There is a surface/depth model at work here in which the notion of false appearance implies something that exists underneath it, something against which the artifice of appearance can be measured. For Irigaray what exists beneath the masquerade of femininity is the woman: 'beneath all those/her appearances, beneath all those/her borrowed finery, the female other still sub-sists' (Irigaray, 1991, p. 118). In this scenario the woman plays out the feminine role in order to expose and denaturalize misogyny, but not to reject any kind of female specificity. In Rivière's account of masquerade femininity has no essence in and of itself, but consists of the displacement of anticipated male anxiety. What emerges is the idea that woman's essence is non-essence. This is argued either in terms of her 'nothing to see', her

duplicitous and sacrilegious nature, or femininity as dissimulation. Tseëlon links the psychoanalytic positions on masquerade as follows: 'whether from Rivière's or from Lacan's position, masquerade reveals the claim for authentic femininity to be like the structure of "bad faith": in both cases I constitute myself as "a thing" in order not to be "that thing"' (Tseëlon, 1995, p. 38). The strategy of unfaithful repetition that I am arguing for depends on the articulation of bad faith. In a sense Wilke cannot avoid this position. After all, what would be a faithful repetition of femininity if, according to Rivière, this is already a disguise that hides masculinity? Seen through the lens of masquerade, Wilke repeats a relation to non-essence. If, as a woman, Wilke somehow embodies artifice, she does not *become* unfaithful in her (sometimes failed) repetition of gendered visual codes, as if this is the action of a subject. She already occupies this state. Read through Rivière's masquerade, her femininity is inessential, only existing as an unfaithful, even adulterous, copy of masculinity. If, as a woman, Wilke already embodies artifice, she then further demonstrates it as a part of the material world of image making. Artifice is both integral to her being and a cultural construct that is external to her embodied self. By further performing a series of poses that represent artifice, Wilke's work doubles dissimulation. Artifice thus emerges not only as an embodied state, but also as part of a visual language constructed by the artist.

For Takemoto and Ellsworth the simulated gap described by Doane becomes a space in which identification with racial and sexual norms is held at a distance. This is achieved using an exaggerated repertoire of seductive imagery that simulates the eroticism of Bernini's image, but re-locates this in relation to contemporary forms of desire. The artist's transformation of *Saint Teresa* stages a dynamic between visibility and invisibility as it seeps through increasingly porous boundaries between art and popular culture. The excessive visibility of Ellsworth as a disco version of Teresa and Takemoto in geisha costume is derived from popular culture, but here articulated in relation to Bernini's sculpture. As Takemoto explains, 'as makeshift madonnas, drag-queen hookers, sadistic angels and mystical divas repopulate and revitalize the uninhabitable regions of art history, we begin to explore the erotics and abjection of specular correspondence (Takemoto, 2004, p. 56).

The failure to accurately reproduce Bernini's sculpture is productive in its realization of a differently repeated sexual and racial spectacle. Where Wilke works from within the heterosexual structures of visual pleasure Ellsworth and Takemoto transpose transcendental ecstasy into inter-racial lesbian desire. To return to Irigaray, this work begins

to articulate a between-women language of desire, which is accessed by excessively inhabiting types of femininity more often considered available for transaction between men. Lesbianism challenges the phallogocentric approach of Freud in which all economic transactions are between men. Lesbian women are a threat to Freud's system because they represent a different economy of desire and exchange, one that cannot be contained within patriarchal law.[4]

Critical mimesis can be traced through a number of works by women of different generations operating in different cultural and political contexts. As a meaningful strategy mimesis is not independent of these contexts but formed in relation to them, in which case it makes little sense to look for the same kind of mimesis in the work of Wilke, Sherman and Ellsworth and Takemoto. Nevertheless, the simultaneous inhabiting of a 'here' and an 'elsewhere' adds a spatial dimension to repetition, which is shared by these artists. In critical mimicry we can imagine a relation to femininity that dare not usually be conceived of in political terms. It is a matter of holding on to the 'feminine' in all its various forms while exposing 'femininity' for the construct that it is.

6

Smooth Surfaces and Flattened Fantasies: Thoughts on Criticality in Sam Taylor-Johnson's *Soliloquy III*

In the last two chapters I have focussed on the work of Hannah Wilke because I think that an understanding of her use of unfaithful repetition and critical mimicry is important if we are to make sense of the various ways in which contemporary female artists work with bodies, photographic surfaces and notions of pleasure. This chapter focusses on the work of Sam Taylor-Johnson, specifically one of a set of works completed between 1998 and 2001 called the *Soliloquy* series. Although working in different time periods and political contexts the two artists share a propensity to reconfigure the pleasures of popular culture from within its own language. In addition, both artists emphasize artifice and the screen culture through which images of women (and men in Taylor-Johnson's case) are produced. In the mid-1970s Wilke made an incursion into popular culture, which was viewed with suspicion by some for whom the seductions of pop could hold no genuine critical purpose. By the time Taylor-Johnson became successful, as one of the young British artists of the 1990s, pop was ubiquitous in the contemporary art scene. For her pop is a given part of a cultural landscape in which the distinctions between 'high' and 'low' cultural forms have been called into question.[1] In this chapter I explore what kinds of feminist criticality are offered from within its terrain. I argue that Taylor-Johnson's work, and *Soliloquy III* (1998) in particular, brings into being an elongated present tense rich with possibilities for rethinking what it means to respond critically to contemporaneous cultural conditions. Taylor-Johnson's work often features bourgeois characters in lavishly ornate surroundings, but where we should find pleasure we encounter something akin to this, but different.

The primary form of time considered through my reading of Taylor-Johnson's work is the stretched out or prolonged present. Her practice

often deals with time; for example in the speeded up decay of a bowl of fruit in her short film *Still Life* (2001) and the many references to the history of painting peppered throughout her oeuvre. In what follows I set out the historical positioning of *Soliloquy III*, specifically in relation to feminist notions of rupture, before arguing for the critical significance of the smooth surface on which the suspended present appears.

Affective emptiness

Soliloquy III consists of a main panel beneath which is a panoramic image (see figure 6.1). The panel restages Velázquez's *Rokeby Venus* (1647–1651) using model Suzie Bick lying in a contemporary interior. She is without the cupid who holds the mirror in Velázquez's painting and fashionable blinds typically found in many high street stores have replaced the heavy drapery of the original. The compositional structure of the whole work refers to Renaissance religious art in which predella panels were used on altarpieces of the Virgin and of saints to represent stories of moral guidance. The artist has explained that her aim was to use this structure to depict 'the different formal sense between above and below, between the sublime and the physical, immaterial and material' (Taylor-Johnson in Millar, 2002, unpaginated). However, in Taylor-Johnson's version the panel features a modern-day Venus, lying on a bed and observing herself in the mirror, and the predella envisions a scene of sexual fantasy. The relationship between the panel and predella, as it travels through religious and secular traditions of art history, suggests changing approaches to the self. In transposing consumer culture for religious imagery the transcendental self becomes differently immaterial – not divine, but constructed in the flow of signifiers that constitutes the photographic image. The relationship between the screen and the self, understood as female but not autobiographical in *Soliloquy III*, raises a question about how one interacts with the other within a secular understanding of the image. Does the artwork produce the self as a subject who claims an identity as a coherent individual, or does it produce, rather, the fully panopticized self of a consumer culture regulated by the omnipotence of the camera that reaches into the private thoughts of the Venus and visualizes them in the predella below?

By recasting the relationship between the main panel and predella in relation to contemporary consumer culture, *Soliloquy III* can be understood as an altarpiece to consumption. The conspicuous consumption on show in the *Soliloquy* series has a relationship to class that plays out unexpectedly. Many of the actors are imaged occupying environments



Figure 6.1 Sam Taylor-Johnson (British, b. 1967), *Soliloquy III* (1998), C-Print in two parts, 81.38 × 101.19 inches. Copyright the artist and White Cube, London

in which they do not appear to belong. The inhabitants of loft apartments and opulent houses appear to be temporary visitors, which creates an atmosphere less concerned with ownership than a reflexive mode of existence. As Ewa Lajer-Burcharth puts it, the work is more about 'being' than it is about 'having' (Lajer-Burcharth, 1999, p. 140). The interior design depicted in *Soliloquy III* is that of reasonably affluent, but widely available, middle-class taste.[2] Here the acquisition of particular cultural capital means enacting a mode of behaviour, a way of being in the space, rather than solely the accumulation of material wealth. Martin Hentschel has argued this point specifically in terms of the entwined relationship between photography and film in Taylor-Johnson's *Five Revolutionary Seconds* series (1995–2000). Staged in the sumptuous surroundings of a country house or the stylized interior of a loft conversion, these photographs are 360° panoramas shot using

a camera that takes five seconds to pan the room – hence the title of the work functions as a play on the word 'revolutionary'. Hentschel's comments are directed at *Five Revolutionary Seconds*, but can equally speak to the curious presence of the characters in the *Soliloquy* series: 'The photographic vision dwells on the figures and configurations, using the evidence of their states of mind in an attempt to solve the mystery of their presence; the cinematic vision, as it passes through the unfolded spaces, meets with utter randomness. These people seem to have nothing whatever in common, except for their accidental, monadic presence in this luxurious interior' (Hentschel, 2000, p. 8).

The presence of the characters in the predella of *Soliloquy III* may remain a mystery, but I would add to Hentschel's observations an understanding of class as a contributory factor in the work. The characters that inhabit both the *Soliloquy* and *Five Revolutionary Seconds* series do not display the labour necessary to acquire such resplendent surroundings. These are images of what the American economist and sociologist Thorstein Veblen called conspicuous waste, a display of affluence and distance from the need to work ([1899] 2009). In the wider narrative that these works suggest the spacious apartments and stately homes might be inherited or borrowed, but not worked for. If the inhabitants do not lack anything economically, their apathy born of a distance from need, they nevertheless appear emotionally impoverished, as if none of it really matters. There is an emptiness that no amount of architectural splendour can fill; an affective, rather than material emptiness, which leaves the various characters detached and isolated.

Historical dialogues

The angle from which we view Taylor-Johnson's Venus is slightly, but importantly, different from Velázquez's painting.[3] In Taylor-Johnson's version the viewer is positioned lower down, on a line of sight continuous with the model's body. As a result the chin of the reflected face is obscured by the model's hip. Velázquez, on the other hand, offers the viewer a neatly positioned reflection in which the face of the Venus fills the mirror. It is as if we see the reflection that she sees, which is an impossible sleight of hand given the difference between her angle of vision and ours. Taylor-Johnson's positioning of the viewer has the potential to immerse us further into the image; our point of view has been changed from one in which we look down slightly in Velázquez's painting to a point of view that is less voyeuristic and totalizing. Our relation to the photograph should, therefore, feel more immersive and

participatory, but this is combined with the positioning of the viewer further away from the figure of Venus. It is as if the viewer is lying on a bed next to the one we can see, watching the model contemplate her own image whilst ignoring our presence. This viewpoint is one from which we can see less of the model's reflection in the mirror than in the *Rokeby Venus*, yet despite only filling the bottom section of the mirror, Suzie Bick's reflected image appears sharper and more discernible than the reflected face in the Velázquez painting.

Soliloquy III enters into a conversation with both the tradition of the female nude and its deconstruction by feminist artists and art historians. The work is in dialogue with Sylvia Sleigh's *Philip Golub Reclining* (1971) in which the artist borrowed the composition of the *Rokeby Venus*, but replaced the reclining woman with the male art critic, Philip Golub. In this version the mirror is much bigger so that, despite displacing the tradition of the female nude such that we see the artist in an upright position in the background and Golub as the reclining nude in the foreground, the only figure that appears outside the mirror's reflection is Golub. Noting the male model's active presence in which he returns our gaze, Roszika Parker and Griselda Pollock commented in 1981 on the incomplete reversal of power relations in Sleigh's painting, 'Despite the metres of sensual flesh, he is a portrait, recognizable and singular. He is not a male odalisque. A man may be placed in a feminine position but will not become feminine' (Parker & Pollock, 1981, p. 124).

Parker and Pollock read this in contrast to a uni-directional gaze in Velázquez's painting. The mirror in the *Rokeby Venus* reflects an indistinct face that lacks specificity and, as the authors argue, does not demand to be treated as an individual. The generic nature of this female nude contrasts sharply with the specific and recognizable portrait of a particular male body in Sleigh's painting. Their argument was made in the context of a critique of sexual power inscribed in representational tropes such as the female nude as it is used, for example, in advertising, and the limits of reversing stereotypes. Pollock discusses the failure of the reversal of sexual stereotypes in representation by citing an essay by Linda Nochlin in which a 19th-century soft porn image of a bare-breasted woman holding a tray of apples is contrasted with a photo of a naked man holding a tray of bananas. Whereas the idea of woman as sexual commodity (as saleable as the apples she is offering) is culturally embedded this is not the case for men, so the reversal of the image does not work. Pollock describes the 'basic asymmetry inscribed into the language of visual representation which such reversals serve to expose' (Pollock in Parker & Pollock, 1987, p. 137). What is at stake is

a potential critique of the gendered distinction between male artistic activity and female passivity, alongside the need to claim an identity as a female subject.

However, despite being located within this trajectory of patriarchal and feminist responses to the notion of ideal femininity, Taylor-Johnson's photographic piece has an ambiguous relationship to the feminist critical discourses through which the tradition of the female nude has been questioned. The temporal reach of the work sets up a tension between femininity, feminism and dialogue between women artists of different generations. Reaching back to a moment of feminist deconstruction, whilst simultaneously invoking the idealized femininity such critiques aimed to defamiliarize, *Soliloquy III* refuses to sit still.

The predella does not distinguish between active masculinity and passive femininity; all of the bodies in the predella section are posed as spectacle and all are equally unmotivated. The men strike poses and do not demonstrate action any more than the female characters. There is no sense of developmental progression of a narrative, instead time is merely something to pass. The predella does not comply with Mulvey's distinction between objectifying close-ups of women over which the camera pauses and male protagonists who control events (Mulvey, [1975] 1989, p. 19). This idea is explored further in the next chapter through a reading of Taylor-Johnson's filmed portrait of David Beckham. For now it is worth noting that while it can be argued that the artist's portrayal of Suzie Bick as a present-day Venus perpetuates the problematic association of femininity with both inauthenticity and spectacle, the male characters featured in the predella do not offset this with authenticity and action. These actors – both male and female – do poses *as* poses, without alluding to a prior reality or an authentic depth. In this way *Soliloquy III* annihilates what Steven Cohan has called the 'impression of dimensionality: an outside in relation to an inside, surface to depth, performance to authenticity' (Cohan, 1992, p. 398). The work is non-oppositional in this sense and denies the gendered binaries of activity/passivity and authenticity/performance. This is reinforced by the spatial encounter between the main panel and the predella, which disrupts conventional subject/object relations. The compositional structure of the predella prevents the panel from standing alone. The desire to visually 'possess' the Venus is interrupted by the spatially different relation that the spectator has with the predella. Here the change in scale and depth of field, through which the spectator encounters the multiple bodies on display, denies the total vision expected from the compositional arrangement of the main panel.

In *Soliloquy III* the model's facial reflection is clear and specific but, when combined with the viewer's line of sight, the non-return of the gaze can be read as an active decision. The model's status as one to be looked at is entirely anticipated by the Venus herself. In contrast to *Philip Golub Reclining* the model does not return our look, but the angle of spectatorship nonetheless suggests the figure's consciousness of our presence. If we are positioned next to her in the field of vision she must be able to see our reflection in the mirror. This sets up a viewing position that cannot escape the model's knowingness, so the spectator does not look with impunity. The return of the viewer's gaze is not the only way of signifying an acknowledgement of the viewer, nor the only way to claim individuality in the field of vision. The clarity of Suzie Bick's reflected face posits a particular female body looking back not only at herself, as if in a moment of self-absorbed narcissism that invites our look, but at the conventions of the female nude that she adopts. What the viewer sees is a woman demonstrating the female nude as a representational trope. Individuality becomes less a coherent and integral certainty to be claimed than a dispersed series of desires through which to travel. What distinguishes Taylor-Johnson's piece is, therefore, an approach to subjectivity that is not firmly grounded in Renaissance perspective, in which the viewer is located at the apex of a cone of vision. In order to look at the model I have to position myself in the image space with her, which prevents me from standing outside the image as a self-contained spectator. At the same time, however, I am given no indication that my presence impacts upon the fantasy world imagined in the predella below. Despite my presence, the actors remain isolated.

An impenetrable surface

The changing of the spectator's line of sight in the main panel draws us to the predella, almost as disinterested participants, in which we find an orgiastic scene set in a sparsely furnished interior (in keeping with other scenes featured in *Five Revolutionary Seconds*). The relationship between the large image and predella is related to the meaning of the title *Soliloquy*. Taylor-Johnson has explained that 'by calling them *Soliloquy* I introduce the idea of the actor giving an aside to an audience – he's speaking a thought out loud' (quoted by Michael O'Pray in Hentschel, 2000, p. 112). Where the self-absorption of Velázquez's model suggests narcissism and, as Parker and Pollock argue, legitimates the viewer's objectification of her (1981, p. 124), in Taylor-Johnson's version the model's thoughts are lent the substance of active sexual desire. In *Soliloquy III*

the very self-absorption that is supposed to allay the threat of female sexuality invokes a fantasy life in which the model becomes a desiring subject rather than only an object desired by others. Furthermore, she is depicted imagining herself as a voyeur within her own fantasy, appearing somewhat detached, seated in red at the centre of the predella strip as if watching the scene on the blank television screen positioned next to her.

Within the visual field of the work there is no distinction to be drawn between the experience of being present in this fantasy scene and the screen culture through which it is disseminated. However, if the scene is a visualization of the fantasies of the Venus above, these are strangely distant and sterile, even if they are sexually explicit. There is nothing carnal or fleshy about the scene. Furthermore, although we are given access to this particular female nude as a model who complies with the art historical conventions required of life posing, whilst simultaneously breaking out of this decorum in her fantasy life, these private desires appear as yet another kind of mediated image. While her fantasies are imagined using a different visual repertoire, they do not release her from the production of the self in and through the screen.

It is as if the raw edges of sexual fantasy have been smoothed, or seen through a screen beyond that of the image itself. The fantasies appear to her as already imaged, already a product of the screen, which sets up a relationship between the experiential and the visual quite different from that explored in Sleigh's painting, which is more to do with claiming subjectivity in the field of vision. There are also two different kinds of screen: the veil effect of the pixilation of the main image contrasts with the televisual clarity of the panel below, as if rendered in high definition. The privacy that the work promises moves the spectator not to an anticipated intimate depth, but to another series of image regimes derived from a combination of fashion imagery, Sunday supplement lifestyle editorial photography and adult TV channels. Indeed the boredom with which the actors engage in their various sexual encounters belies a familiarity born of the accessibility of porn. Far from intensifying the sexualization of Western cultures the result here is a desexualized ordinariness. By attempting to read the model's inner thoughts the spectator moves only from one surface to another. In its traversing of surfaces, *Soliloquy III* refuses to distinguish between a deviant femininity of sexual excess and the patriarchal ideal of the Venus.[4] The distinction is subdued by the screen culture to which the work refers and within which it is both produced and consumed. It is as if the sexual fantasies have been flattened by a sheet of glass. The result is a muting of affect and the production of sexuality that is smooth rather than visceral.

The impact of the screen on understandings of femininity adds a historically specific resonance to this work. In 1914 Velázquez's *Rokeby Venus* was damaged by Mary Richardson, who attacked it with an axe in protest at the government's treatment of Emmeline Pankhurst. The valorization of a particular kind of femininity and the tradition of the female nude that supported it had become a target for direct action. Lynda Nead observes that the reporting of this act created a division between a deviant, uncontrollable and violent femininity (Richardson) and the patriarchal ideal represented by this particular female nude (Nead, 1992, p. 37). In the broader context of anti-suffrage representations feminist activism was aligned with sexual pathology. Deviance was articulated through images of the 'hysteric' and uncontrollable lapses from decorum (Tickner, 1987; Betterton, 1996). The representation of this event in terms of conflicting femininities was possible because Richardson had broken the seal of the female nude, both literally and conceptually.[5] In smashing the plate glass that was supposed to protect the *Rokeby Venus* from an embodied, physical relation with others, and slashing the painting beneath the glass surface, the integrity of the form was splintered. Whereas in this instance the screen was not continuous with the artwork (it had to be broken in order to access the canvas/image beneath), in *Soliloquy III* the screen *is* the work. The bodies are of the same order as the surface, their production contingent upon technologically specific fields of vision. However, in taking an axe to the *Rokeby Venus*, Richardson was understood to have committed a crime against a woman's body and patriarchal femininity, not just a canvas. It is a crime that has not faded over the last century. During 2006–2007 the *Rokeby Venus* was on show in London as part of the Velázquez exhibition at the National Gallery. In reviewing the exhibition for *The Times Online*, Waldemar Januszczak perpetuates the characterization of Mary Richardson as out of control, describing her as 'demented' and 'jealous' of the attention male visitors paid to the painting. In an article entitled 'Still sexy after all these years' Januszczak describes how 'Mary "Slasher" Richardson went about her with a meat cleaver. Richardson hacked and hacked at Venus's delicious back; if you look carefully, you can still see the scars' (Januszczak, *Times Online*, 8 October 2006). Unencumbered by feminist challenges to the idea of the suffragettes as hysterical, Januszczak's comments make clear the inability of patriarchal culture to 'forgive' an attack on idealized femininity, even 'after all these years'.[6]

In her discussion of this event Nead invokes a distinction between surface and depth, canvas and flesh. Richardson broke the unity of the female form, each tear further fragmenting it into parts. Indeed, the cuts

in the canvas centre on the female nude's back and shoulder rather than her reflection in the mirror. It is the model's body that is under attack as opposed to her facial reflection, which, albeit indistinct, is the area of the painting that moves away from the generic towards the expression of an individualized body.

Looking closely at the *Rokeby Venus* it is less the 'scars' of attack that are visible as the filigree of fracture lines where the painterly surface has splintered. Although at a distance the female nude appears smooth and slightly softened (like Taylor-Johnson's photographic surface in *Soliloquy III*), as you move closer to view the painterly surface in detail, it distends. This effect is reproduced differently (and in a different technological and mediated context) by the pixilation of Taylor-Johnson's version. In particular, there is a difference between the gaps between pixels, which are separated from one another but only perceivable as such close-up, and the fracturing of a painted surface that was once consistent. Paint touches paint, as well as canvas; there is no individual unit, equivalent to the pixel, until the surface fractures. It is as if the glass frame holds together a fragile surface that will otherwise break apart, not as a result of frenzied attack, but of a painterly process through which the idea of an unthreatening and fully contained female form has been established. The very process of creating this ideal femininity contains within its technique its own undoing.

The distinction between embodied depth and pictorial surface is not rehearsed in *Soliloquy III*. The surface appears impenetrable in its evenness and, despite the specific feminist history to which the work is connected, does not present the viewer with a punctured femininity. The object of pleasure is not ruptured, where this can be understood as a metaphor for critical opposition to the spectacle of the female nude, but neither is it left intact. Far from rupturing the surface, it is as if Taylor-Johnson has polished it to an almost reflective state, which begs a question about the extent to which we can see ourselves in this vision of indulgent boredom. In a catalogue essay for the artist's 2002 exhibition at London's Hayward Gallery, Michael Bracewell describes the complexity of the surface in Taylor-Johnson's films and photographs: 'The films maintain the extraordinary lustre of their surface texture – lit to a degree of near hyper-reality, in either cold blues or warm amber – in a way that conveys intimacy and distance, simultaneously' (Bracewell, 2002, unpaginated). Ultimately, Bracewell reads works such as *Five Revolutionary Seconds* as a representation of the captivity, isolation and 'unfreedom' of post-1980s consumer materialism, which he describes as 'a kind of alienation

in aspic'. In identifying the luminosity of the photographic surface, Bracewell describes the characters as 'almost "too there", too vivid in their heightened emotional presence' (2002, unpaginated). At the same time, however, the characters are not tied to their locations; they are temporary residents, provisionally occupying the mise-en-scène. What seems 'too there' has no permanence.

Implications for criticality

The history of contested femininities that emerges from the damaging of the *Rokeby Venus* – the idea of the militant feminist as sexually untamed who is unleashed to reek havoc on the contained and unthreatening form of the female nude – is not reproduced in Taylor-Johnson's work. Contrary to expectations, she does not rehearse the polarization of respectable femininity and uncontrollable female sexuality suggested by the relation between composition and pictorial content. There is, however, an unsettling approach to pleasure, which fails to deliver on the embodied fantasies that the predella promises. These remain distant, stylized and untouchable. The Venus, as she appears in the panel, and as an observer of her own imagination in the predella below, occupies femininity as an image, deliberately and without compromise. Her sexual fantasies are not raw. They have been 'cleaned up', as if they have been supersaturated in post-production. The intensity of the colours has been dialled up, which has the effect of emphasizing the imaged nature of the scene.

In this respect Taylor-Johnson's practice is connected to Wilke's earlier adoption of femininity as a series of poses derived from already known photographic genres, such as the centrefold pin-up. In Chapters 4 and 5 I argued that Wilke's works of the mid-1970s – what she called her 'performalist self-portraits' – are strategic invocations of femininity that operate as mimetic critique. Here I want to posit a connection between Wilke and Taylor-Johnson and argue for the importance of Wilke's practice in understanding what contemporary artists who draw attention to femininity-as-image are doing. This is, in my view, particularly important given the absence of any substantive discussion of the critical potential of contemporary artworks that operate within (often unfaithfully) the commodified pleasures of femininity.[7] As in Wilke's provocative practice of the mid-1970s, Taylor-Johnson generates her art from within the pleasure systems of a range of popular cultural forms in order to produce something else; something not in opposition to pleasure but contiguous with it. It knowingly works within a specific

image repertoire as opposed to puncturing the idea that femininity is produced as a relation to the image. In this sense her work maintains the ambiguity of a practice that slides between knowingness of femininity-as-image and capitulation to a patriarchal understanding of femininity as unthreatening whole. Here I posit a relationship of chronological importance between the two artists: without Wilke's earlier practice I could not read Taylor-Johnson's treatment of stylized femininity as critically productive. In so doing I risk the criticism that my own argument relies on precedence and thus falls into one of the structures of history that this book aims to challenge. However, where precedence suggests rank and order, which are ideas often used to exclude women from art history, the connection I posit is less hierarchical. Wilke's work stretched the boundaries of what feminist art historians considered properly critical. In particular, the 'dangers' of artworks that teeter on the edge of what Lucy Lippard, in 1976, called the 'subtle abyss that separates men's use of women for sexual titillation from women's use of women to expose that insult' proved insurmountable for some feminist critics (Lippard, 1995, p. 102). The historical and cultural context for Taylor-Johnson's work differs from that in which Wilke's 'performalist self-portraits' were received. In particular, the alliance of feminist activism and art was not a dominant feature of the British art scene in the late 1990s. Nevertheless, the relation to pleasure in the work of the contemporary artists included in this book also tests the limits of inclusion and prompts a new debate about the forms of criticality invoked by Taylor-Johnson, Emin, Beecroft and others. In Taylor-Johnson's wider body of work there is little sense of a message being communicated or a desire to change material realities. *Soliloquy III* is not strategic in the way that I am arguing Wilke's *Starification Object Series* is and it is susceptible to Lippard's critique. There is, however, an interesting orientation towards a feminine critical sensibility that is smooth not visceral; one that slides across surfaces rather than mining depths, yet remains curious and ambiguous in its historical affinities.

The feminist criticality through which Richardson's attack on the *Rokeby Venus* is understood is about rupturing the surface of femininity and breaking apart the ideological apparatuses of pleasure. In particular, feminist art history written during the 1980s often employed the notion of rupture. Parker and Pollock, for example, argued that some artworks 'are easily retrieved and co-opted by a male culture because they do not rupture radically meanings and connotations of woman in art as body, as sexual, as nature, as object for male possession' (Parker & Pollock, 1981, p. 130). They had in mind Judy Chicago's 'central core' paintings.

Here the notion of rupture is a product of a surface/depth relation. The surface must be transgressed in order to reveal the ideological workings of the image regime. The rupture of feminist intervention is understood as the displacement of values and beliefs that are naturalized in patriarchal culture. The fear (often justified) is of repetition without the more strategic notion of intervention, where the latter is closely allied with rupture. The activity of exposing previously hidden ideological motives is politically necessary, but also problematic in its presumption of a critic who has the requisite knowledge to do this work on behalf of others, hence instigating another hierarchy in the very process of breaking others down. In addition, the idea of looking for a meaning beneath the surface suggests a sense of origin; despite appearances to the contrary, it suggests that this is what the image *really* means. A diverse array of critical models has emerged since Parker and Pollock expressed their anxiety about cooption into a male imaginary, but the notion of rupture persists as a given. As a result some artworks fall outside this remit despite holding interest for feminist criticality. There is no space within the concept of rupture for Taylor-Johnson's smooth surfaces and flattened fantasies. The evenness of her surface texture, alongside the separation of pixels that appear always-already reproduced (copies without an original) rather than available to touch, renders the work un-amenable to such a model. Instead we are invited to pause over the photographic surface where we find a strange suspension of narrative. In the final part of this chapter I would like to consider the critical potential of the surface in this work and suggest a different framework with which to think through its implications.

Privatized desires in the historical present

There is a temporal contradiction at the heart of *Soliloquy III*, which is common to a number of other artworks in this series and in the artist's wider body of work. It is replete with historical reference yet holds its viewer in a suspended present. The surface of *Soliloquy III* is in effect a spatialization of time in which the present moment of contemplation, narcissism and fantasy is elongated across the photographic surface. It is an invitation to consider the present as itself historical, as having a particular atmosphere and relation to both the past and the future. Here I am suggesting an affinity between Taylor-Johnson's practice and Lauren Berlant's writing on the affective politics of the present (2008; 2011). I do not want to *apply* Berlant's writing to the artworks, not least because this would miss the open-ended generosity of Berlant's

approach. Hers is not a *theory* of affect so much as a radical reconfiguration of the conceptual landscape with which to think the contemporary moment as historical. Indeed, a theory of affect is a contradiction in terms. Rather than a theory we might think of this work as offering a different orientation, which does not separate thinking and feeling. Berlant's work combines this approach with an emphasis on the present. She shares with Taylor-Johnson a desire to pay attention to the present and to imagine what kinds of experience can be articulated when what she calls the 'ongoingness' of life is slowed down and brought into visibility.

The idea of an ongoing life is ordinary rather than exceptional. A number of commentators have noted the emotional drama of Taylor-Johnson's films and photographs in works such as *Pent Up* (1996), an installation consisting of five video projections each showing an individual talking incessantly about their despair at one of the others. Works such as this involve heightened emotional states such as desperation, anxiety and shame. However, there are other works, such as *Soliloquy III* and the *Five Revolutionary Seconds* series, which are about the ordinariness of boredom, idleness and the spectacular turned mundane. There is a sense that life goes on without any drama or expectation of an improved future state. At times the characters seem to be waiting for something, but at other times they just languish in the present without even the futurity implicated in waiting (they do not anticipate anything). In these works the aspiration to a version of the good life characterized by access to bourgeois but widely available taste in interior decor turns out to be unfulfilling. It is as if the models who feature in these works are stuck in an image of the good life they have aspired to, unmotivated to change any material reality. Bracewell puts this eloquently when he describes the events depicted in *Five Revolutionary Seconds* as 'all but broken down, turning narrative into a frieze-like tableaux of oblique episodes. These people are captive in time' (2002, unpaginated). This situation is not exceptional or dramatic. It does not rupture the usual state of affairs so much as create what Berlant calls a crisis in the ordinariness of life. This idea of the ordinary suggests a temporality that resonates with Taylor-Johnson's work. The present here is to be lived, it is ongoing, but it is not teleological and does not suggest movement towards a future state.

So the present tense of *Soliloquy III* is not historical in the sense that something dramatic or unexpected is happening – on the contrary, the only action is fantasy – but the isolated figures that populate the Venus' imaginary life tell us something about our present moment.

There is another sense in which the stretched out present of this work is historical. As a photograph *Soliloquy III* has an immediate pastness about it because it is a present tense that has already taken place (this photographic pastness is discussed further in Chapter 7 in relation to Taylor-Johnson's film *David*). The present tense of the artwork is, therefore, doubly historical. It is a present-past, which is at the same time thick with an atmosphere that is historically specific. This begs a question about what kind of atmosphere hangs in the air of *Soliloquy III* and in what way (if at all) does this comment on the conditions of living in the present moment.

In common with the photographic panoramas of the *Five Revolutionary Seconds* series, *Soliloquy III* feels strangely devoid of intimacy. This extends to the spectator who is offered a confusing position as the artist plays with the balance between inclusion and exclusion. In one sense it is difficult to gain distance from the female nude in Taylor-Johnson's work because the viewer is positioned as if on the same horizontal plane as her body. However, having set up this sense of proximity, the models that populate the predella appear detached. There is a sense of invitation (even an open door), which will not develop into interaction. It is possible to imagine being in the loft apartment shown in the predella, yet feeling as if nobody has noticed your presence because while these bodies appear so visible to us we do not, despite multiple aids to visibility such as the possibility of reflection in the window or mirror, appear to be visible to them. The depth of field changes between the panel and predella, which encourages movement between panning and zooming. The spectator's eye acts as a camera that pans the scene of the predella and zooms in on the close-up of the Venus. There is, however, no way to break out of voyeurism into a relation that is embodied and inter-subjective, which is problematic for any feminist reading premised on the psycho-sexual dynamics of the gaze. The orchestration of space renders the spectator conscious of his or her embodiment, but does not allow us to be spatially, or emotionally, immersed in the pleasures on show (if not on offer). No matter where I am positioned my presence is not acknowledged.

Originally invented by the Royal Air Force (RAF) to take aerial photographs, the camera used in both the *Soliloquy* and *Five Revolutionary Seconds* series circles the room at eye level in an exposure that takes several seconds. The combination of an all-seeing pivotal camera and the arrangement of bodies in a space lit brightly by windows that stretch the circumference of the room promises an extreme visibility that somehow fails to take place. The encircling surveillance of the camera, the results

of which are unfolded to create a horizontal strip, does not deliver total vision because despite appearing explicit the bodies show us nothing intimate, no narrative of closeness just a series of acts. It is possible to read them as 'docile bodies', entirely regulated by an internalized gaze, but their failure to acknowledge the presence of an instrumentalized spectator/camera suggests a kind of failed Panopticism (Foucault, [1977] 1991).[8] There is a refusal to acknowledge the power relation that the spectator expects, which results in an experience for the viewer that is closer to Peggy Phelan's articulation of the 'failure of self-seeing' (Phelan, 1993, p. 15). Drawing on Lacan's notion of the mirror stage, Phelan argues that 'the looker is always also regarded by the image seen and through this regard discovers and continually reaffirms that s/he is the one who looks' (Phelan, 1993, p. 15). It is the inability to become a fully observable being that motivates the desire to see the other, hence 'all seeing is hooded with loss – the loss of self-seeing' (Phelan, 1993, p. 16). The power invested in seeing is dependent upon an understanding of the other as one who feels looked at. However, the models that populate the predella of *Soliloquy III* do not offer this kind of reassurance; they do not appear to feel looked at and, therefore, do not confer coherence on the spectator. In side-stepping this acknowledgement *Soliloquy III* has a disconcerting effect. It is as if the masculinized spectator has been invited to the party, only to be ignored in the field of vision.

The invitation/exclusion dynamic of the work operates as what Berlant calls 'cruel optimism'. Berlant argues that people sustain problematic attachments to fantasies of the 'good life' (for example, upward mobility, social equality or intimacy in relationships) despite the inability of liberal-capitalist societies to deliver on these promises. Thus, the better life remains unfulfilled and out of reach as we keep the attachments that harm us in close proximity. Furthermore, a relation of cruel optimism occurs when the very thing we desire functions as an obstacle to our fulfilment of an aspiration; a 'binding to fantasies that block the satisfactions they offer' (Berlant, 2011, p. 51). For the spectator of Taylor-Johnson's vision whose desire is to be a part of the post-1980s consumerist dream there is disappointment because this desire only entrenches her position outside the world that she witnesses. It is as if our faces are pressed up against a window through which we can see the events unfold. On closer inspection, however, there is no connectivity that we could hope to link up to. The characters are atomized, individual units, sometimes in couples and sometimes alone. What makes the scene sterile is the absence of any collective emotion. The lack of intimacy within the fantasy scene imagined by the Venus is a

neo-liberal nightmare stretched out across a shiny surface. This is shared with *Five Revolutionary Seconds XI* (1997) in which a series of models and friends of the artist are photographed in one room in a five-second shoot. Although occupying the same space they appear disconnected and seemingly unchanged by the activities or mood of the others. I cannot help but wonder why they are there and why they remain so uninterested in each other. There is, in short, no community, only privatized desires. What we find in the stretched out present is the cruel optimism of numbness where we might hope to find excitement. The characters are dispersed and their present is not shared in any meaningful way. In a scene of apparent desire (for objects, intimacy and a privileged way of life) there is a lack of adrenalin and a sense of resignation that this is what life has to offer. This atmosphere is forged in relation to the materiality of the image. In contrast to the enhanced luminosity of the colours and photographic texture, which is often used in commercial photography to generate desire for commodities, the appetite for intimacy has been dialled down. Where the surface of the image is 'too there' the models respond by being distant, not there at all in any visceral sense.

To return, finally, to the question of criticality, Taylor-Johnson does not rupture the lacquered surface of her photographic vision. She thickens the surface in a way that draws attention to the atmosphere of the historical present. *Soliloquy III* does not have a critical message; it does not advocate anything. It is, nevertheless, tuned into an affective repertoire of hope and disappointment in which we are presented with a disarming and maybe familiar image of anaesthetized pleasures.

7

Near-Stillness in the Art Films of Sam Taylor-Johnson and Vanessa Beecroft

Feminist art practice has a rich heritage of radical filmmaking, which has contributed to an understanding of its politics as subversive and oppositional. Examples include Laura Mulvey and Peter Wollen's groundbreaking *Riddles of the Sphinx* (1977) and Chantel Ackerman's *Jeanne Dielman, 23, quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (1975), both of which explore sexuality, motherhood and feminism. Mulvey and Wollen's film is informed by psychoanalysis and addresses the position of women within patriarchy. A range of narrative codes and avant-garde techniques are used to shift the focus from woman as image to woman as a subject of enquiry. These include Mulvey reading to the camera, fragmentation (visual and in dialogue) and the use of multiple voices to disrupt the narrative framework of conventional film. Ackerman's film is about a widowed housewife and mother who carries out monotonous chores and makes ends meet by working as a prostitute in the afternoons. The film is three hours and twenty-one minutes long and uses a fixed camera to emphasize the duration of mundane tasks such as peeling a potato or looking for a missing button. It uses rhythm, duration and stasis to set up a dialogue between the drama of Jeanne's sexwork and the ongoingness of life's domestic routines. Crucial as these strategies are, the grounds upon which they were founded have shifted in relation to the changing relationship of art films to popular culture. If the radicalism of second-wave art films was to be found in the extent to which they sharpened the spectator's agency, demystifying the illusions of mainstream cinema and raising awareness of film as an ideological construction, contemporary artist-filmmakers operate in a changed cultural landscape. Opposition, reversal and subversion are not enough now that popular culture has appropriated these tactics.

In this final chapter of the book I suggest that women artists have found new ways to respond to the complexities of this situation and indicate a different relation from what counts as critical practice. This is explored through an analysis of two films by commercially successful artists: Vanessa Beecroft's *VB29* (1997) and Sam Taylor-Johnson's *David* (2004). Beecroft's film features a young woman who presents herself to the spectator, pausing over semi-choreographed poses before getting up and repeating the movements. Taylor-Johnson's film consists of a sixty-seven-minute close-up of British footballer David Beckham sleeping. What connects these two artworks is that they operate in between the static photographic image and the movement of film, born as this is out of a series of stills. Both refer to stillness within the continuum of movement and in this sense are connected to a history of avant-garde film that includes Ackerman's elongated approach to time. Here I focus on a number of temporal forms enabled by *VB29* and *David* – endurance, duration, stillness, repetition and restlessness – to examine what they can offer, if anything, a feminist sensibility. In order to analyse the multiple temporalities of the two films I refer to a number of different areas of literature. My discussion of Beecroft's *VB29* leads me to recent developments within photographic theory (Stezaka, 2006; Mulvey, 2003; Campany, 2006) as well as Judith Butler's work on repetitious gestures as formative of femininity (Butler, 1990). My reading of Taylor-Johnson's *David* is informed by literature on masculinities and the representation of sport (Rowe, 1999; Whannel, 2002).

The two films share with earlier feminist experimental films a desire to meddle with the gendered expectations of narrative time. This was a concern within feminist performance art as well as film. A notable example is Faith Wilding's metronomic *Waiting*, performed at Womanhouse in 1972, in which the artist recounted a long list of events that women wait for in their lives such as 'waiting to be a pretty girl … waiting for my first date … waiting for my baby'. Wilding's monologue suggests that women spend their lives waiting to exist while maintaining the lives of partners and children. It is as if womanhood *is* the condition of waiting. Photography has also been used to examine the concept of waiting as part of what it means to be a woman, for example in Susan Hiller's *10 Months* (1977–1979), which consists of photographs of the artist's pregnant body arranged into ten lunar months of twenty-eight days and accompanied by journal entries written during the same period. The films by Beecroft and Taylor-Johnson also articulate gender as a product of time, but not in an explicitly feminist context. In Beecroft's film the spectator encounters a strangely

asexual performance of youthful femininity and in Taylor-Johnson's case a feminized performance of masculinity. These films were made in a different historical context and do not share the politicization of the personal that was such an important framework for second-wave feminist art. Indeed Taylor-Johnson has been criticized for her perceived complicity with consumer culture (Stallabrass, 1999). It is as if her use of spectacular visual imagery forecloses the possibility of critiquing the inequitable social relations that lie beneath the surface of such seductive visual pleasures. My intention here is to ask if new forms of criticality emerge from the temporal ambiguity of Beecroft and Taylor-Johnson's films through which we might be able to imagine a different orientation to feminist cultural practice. I want to ask if we need an alternative conceptual vocabulary to describe art that agitates the field of vision without embodying the historically legitimated patterns of feminist 'critical' practice. This is not intended as feminist art, but it is made with a consciousness of objectification, visual pleasure, voyeurism, desire and fantasy. It does not aim to disrupt the narrative framing of femininity within film. The temporal manipulation used is now familiar to audiences of popular culture as well as art films and cannot, therefore, function as radical in the way it once did. It is, however, working with the impact of the screen on spectatorship and the alignment of time with the production of femininity (including feminized masculinity). My proposition is that close analysis of these characteristics can suggest forms of transformation that cannot be articulated in terms of opposition, subversion or ideological awakening.

Temporal ambiguity

Beecroft is well known for her controversial performance works in which endurance is a significant factor. Groups of young female models stand in pre-determined arrangements for long periods of time, often three to four hours, eventually sitting down to take the weight off their spike-heeled feet. In Chapter 2 I discussed a performance by Beecroft called *VB35* and argued that femininity only exists as a utopian image marked by failure to achieve a future state. This is exemplified by Beecroft's performance and film works, which refuse to sustain the stillness of the photograph that characterizes femininity-as-image. For this reason the works that involve a degree of movement are more provocative than Beecroft's photographs. There is a marked difference between the static images of Beecroft's work that appear in magazines and the ambiguous temporality of her performances and films. For Bourriaud these are

'relational' works, which increase the viewer/participant's awareness of the social contract that they find themselves in (Bourriaud, 2002, p. 39). Jan Avgikos notes that Beecroft's performances have been described as 'non-events' because it looks like nothing happens, but that they are, in another sense, extremely eventful in their subtle reconfigurations of the original composition. As Avgikos notes, 'Inevitably, the "picture" begins to twitch and fidget, to sag, droop and collapse. The perfect, and perfectly problematic, picture quite literally falls apart' (Avgikos, 1999, p. 109). The stillness of the pose starts to disintegrate, but only to collapse into another image.

Performed and recorded in 1997 at Le Nouveau Musée, Lyon, *VB29* features a young woman wearing a tasselled, silver and blue g-string bikini and matching spike-heeled ankle boots, her long, straight hair swept back into a ponytail (see figure 7.1). The woman moves slowly and deliberately, pausing over semi-choreographed poses before getting up and repeating the movements. What emerges is a cyclical performance of familiar gendered constructs described by Polly Staple as 'a cross between a New York princess and a stripper called Bambi' (Staple, 2000, p. 12). The pattern of *VB29* involves the temporary adoption of a pose, which then dissolves into the continuum of movement. A rhythm emerges between moments of mobility and moments during which a pose is held, which serves to remind the viewer that filmic movement consists of a sequence of still images, rendering any argument that opposes film and photography problematic. The woman choreographs her body between near-stillness and slow movement and in this sense the film plays with audience expectations of the kind of temporality usually adopted by the cultural forms to which the artwork makes reference. The temporal ambiguity of Beecroft's work can be understood as a series of unfulfilled expectations, citations of temporal knowledge drawn from a range of cultural forms. Here we are not experiencing the momentum of the catwalk show or the limited time span of the peep show. Despite alluding to the durational language of popular film the work involves no narrative progress; the repetitive slowness and endurance of the piece is unlike the developmental drive of mainstream cinema. However, neither do we experience the stasis of the photographic pin-up. Instead, the slowly fidgeting image exists between stasis and movement and between different types of temporality drawn from familiar cultural forms.

My own engagement with *VB29* was initially as a video exhibit at the Lisson Gallery, London in 2000. Projected on to a large screen, the ambiguous nature of the work teetered on the edge of what Lippard

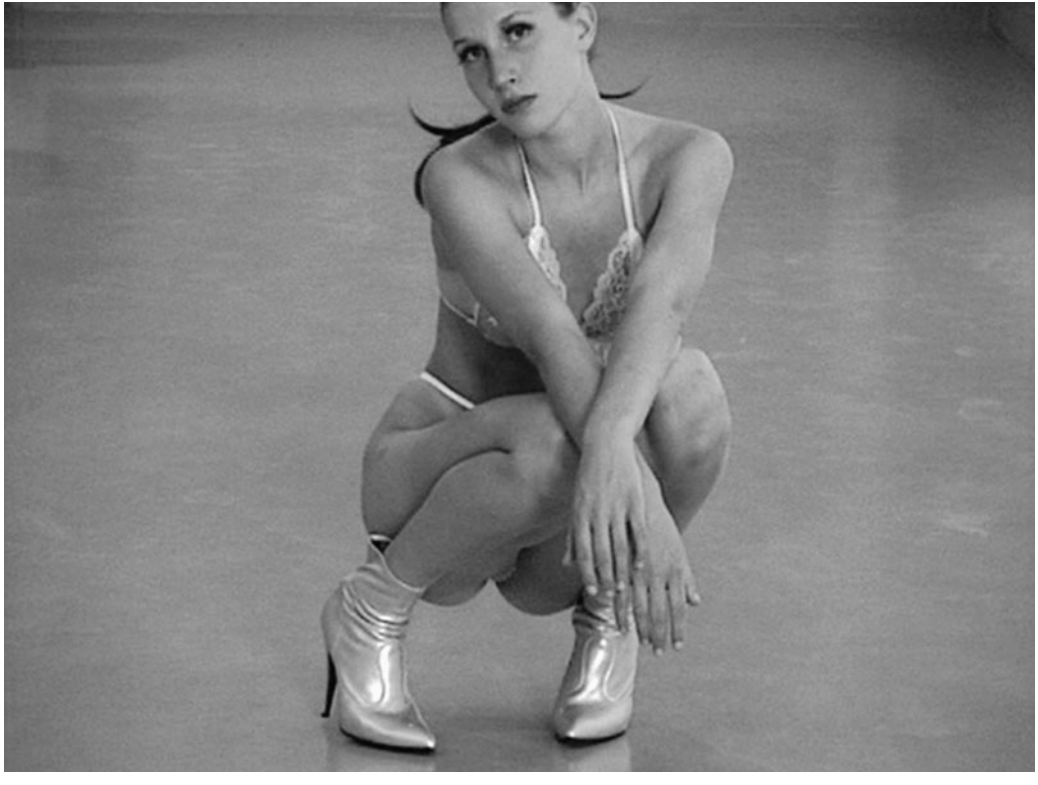


Figure 7.1 Vanessa Beecroft, *vb29* performance, FRAC, Le Nouveau Musée, Lyon, France (1997). vb29.004.vb, photographed by: Vanessa Beecroft.© 2012 Vanessa Beecroft

has called the 'subtle abyss' that separates feminist use of the fetishized female body from its collapse into conventional gendered power relations (Lippard, 1995, p. 102). However, the temporality of the pose in Beecroft's film is prolonged in contrast to the fast-editing and ephemeral imagery we anticipate from the work's references to the fashion industry. The durational slowness of the film works against the possibility of instant gratification, even if it does not cancel it out. It is churlish to ignore the problematic nature of this work, which clearly objectifies the unnamed woman and puts distance between the artist and model. This contrasts with the dual position of artist and model, subject and object, taken up by many women artists as a challenge to the gendered separation of these roles. Indeed Beecroft's work has been challenged on the grounds of its objectification of women and the exhausting nature of the work undertaken by the models involved (Steinmetz et al., 2006; Fox, 2010).[1] However, when experienced as a durational filmic performance, rather than photographic image, there are other factors to consider. The refusal of the film's temporality to fully align itself with our expectations of any one set of representational tropes not only focuses our attention on the deliberate imitation of a particular type of gender, but also draws attention to what Butler has called 'the imitative structure of gender itself' (1990, p. 137). This is an anti-essentialist, Foucauldian notion of identity as something that is discursively constructed; an effect, rather than cause, of discursive practices that produce what Butler terms 'the appearance of substance' (1990, p. 141). This illusion of an inner core that exists prior to the gestures that 'express' gender is, for Butler, a 'truth effect' that serves the purpose of maintaining the regulation of sexuality around the assumption of heterosexual primacy.

If gender is a performative practice that has no essence, femininity cannot be an identity category that has any existence beyond (or before) the gestures and acts through which it is constituted. Furthermore, these acts are repetitious. It is the continually perpetuated anticipation of approximating femininity as a substantive identity that produces the sense of an essence. The model in *VB29* naturalizes femininity only to the extent that her repetitious movements convince the viewer of the identity that she purports to 'express'. However, the loss experienced between self-image and screen image (Stacey, 1994), which may well be that of inevitable failure or impossibility for the female viewer, coexists in *VB29* with Beecroft's *staging* of a power relation that is intended to secure the spectator's privileged position. *VB29* exaggerates the single-point perspective that guarantees the viewer's position of seeing/

knowing. The model walks towards the camera/us before crouching to slowly move through her selection of poses and, as she approaches, the spotlights and wall-mounted pictures enhance the severity of the perspective. Every attempt has been made to dramatize the connection between seeing and knowing that Antin's *Carving*, discussed in Chapter 2, aims to reveal as a form of oppression. *VB29* stages the extreme instrumentalization of the camera/eye and compliance with Renaissance perspectival subject formation in which the viewing subject occupies a privileged, disembodied position in relation to the object of his or her gaze. The effect of Beecroft's film is to heighten the spatial and visual arrangement that Norman Bryson refers to as the 'gaze', a valorized alignment of the viewer's look with that of the 'founding perception' of the artist (Bryson, 1983, p. 93). By exaggerating the matrix of visibility, the body and architectural space the power relation is itself brought into view.

Beecroft's model is already sustaining a series of poses as the viewer enters the room in which the work is displayed. Although the mechanism for a male gaze is undoubtedly in place, the model is not 'captured' or petrified by the viewer's gaze because this has already been temporally separated from that of the camera. The viewer is confronted by the work as he or she walks into the room, whereas the camera is a continuous presence within the visual dynamic of the film. Whether we choose to examine her or not Beecroft's model carries on delivering femininity as a series of highly mediated near-stills. If femininity consists of the future-oriented anticipation of the gaze that provokes an aspiration to stasis (femininity-as-image) – and exists, therefore, only inasmuch as it defers to the coherence of the viewing subject – this is pre-empted by the work, which presents a model who is always-already an image of near-stillness. In slowing the anticipated pace of the imagery and repeating the gestures that constitute what Butler calls 'an originating activity incessantly taking place' attention is drawn to the production of femininity as a copy without an original (2004, p. 26). The gestures performed in *VB29* are deliberate and voluntaristic, rather than the unconscious repetitions that Butler cites as constitutive of gender identity as a 'regulatory fiction'. The slowness of the gestures and the refusal to remain still in any one pose brings into focus the processes through which femininity-as-image is naturalized as an 'appearance of a substance'. This is not achieved by deconstructive tactics that presuppose a position outside the power relations that constitute femininity as a gendered relation to the static image. In Beecroft's film femininity-as-image is imitated, rather than rehearsed,

by drawing attention to its failure to achieve the stasis of the photographic moment.

Between stasis and movement

In *VB29* stillness is not something to overcome in the pursuit of movement. Beecroft's filmed performance enacts what John Stezaka has described, in his work on the film still, as 'the desire for stillness as an expanded moment, rather than as an interruptive one' (Stezaka, 2006, p. 125). This idea of the expanded moment is a useful description of *VB29*. The model's poses imply arrested motion, a pause in which femininity can be produced in relation to the stilling of movement. However, here we do not encounter arrested motion so much as near-stillness for its own sake. Beecroft's film articulates the enduring existence of femininity-as-image within this expanded moment of near-stilling, a kind of relentless and excessive production of femininity, which does not dissolve into goal-orientated (masculinized) movement. The moments of near-stillness are contained within slow movement, which enables a slippage quite different from the one that Stezaka describes between filmic movement and the *tableaux vivant* of stills used for film promotion in the late 1970s, in which actors reconvened after shooting the film to pose for a second-take to adorn the film poster.[2] Where the latter suggests a temporal difference between 'acting' and 'posing', Beecroft's model sustains no such division of labour.[3] The spectacle of femininity-as-image is simply held. Furthermore, where Stezaka observes a tendency in film promotion shots to over-compensate for stillness by exaggerating gestures and facial expressions in an attempt to connote movement, Beecroft's filmed performance involves no such dramatization. The model's facial expression is understated, even deadpan, as if she does not feel the weight of the viewer's stare. There is no attempt to signify action or narrative development in the way that Stezaka observes of film promotion shots. Instead, in her refusal to settle into a pose that can be grasped as a static image, Beecroft's model circumvents the binary that opposes stillness to movement, photography to film.[4]

The lack of expression on the face of the model intensifies what Craig Owens has described as the still photograph's 'mortification of the flesh', the anticipation of photographic stillness inherent in the pose (Owens, 1992, p. 210). Combined with the prescribed nature of the model's movements, *VB29* has something in common with the automatons of zombie movies in which characters inhabit a state in between life and

death, not quite fully mobile but not quite still either. The models that populate Beecroft's work of the mid- to late 1990s invoke what David Campany, writing about the contemporaneous photographs of Jeff Wall, has called 'blank mimicry' (Campany, 2006, p. 103), an estranging experience in which the robotic adherence to normative gestures does something other than simply repeat them. Similarly, Campany argues that the limited repertoire of facial expression in the work of Cindy Sherman speaks to a 'mesmerising blankness, an immobility as still and automatic as the image itself' (Campany, 2006, p. 108). *VB29* connects to this observation in that the model's facial expressions remain unmotivated by the objectification of her body, an affectless state that speaks to the ubiquity of the performance.

The association of femininity with the stalling of time echoes Mulvey's observation in 'Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema' that the camera pauses over women in mainstream film in contrast to the portrayal of active, masculinized movement as the embodiment of narrative time ([1975] 1989). Mulvey's often-quoted argument hinges on the gendered polarization of active/passive, hence women are almost 'outside' time, they represent the passive stilling of time as pure spectacle. Beecroft's film, however, occupies an ambiguous position in relation to this distinction because the femininity displayed is constituted in between stasis and movement, rather than being a product of the stilling of masculinized movement. Furthermore, movement has been dissociated from a conventionally masculinized understanding of action, commodified time spent in the production of something. Beecroft's work speaks of the impossibility of stillness as her model pauses temporarily to hold a pose, but never becomes a static image. This also points to a tension in Mulvey's original argument in that the close-up of the female protagonist was only ever an approximation of stillness cast in relation to the empowering developmental action of the male star. The spectacle of Tippi Hedren as the female star in Hitchcock's *Marnie* (1964), for example, who at one point is watched by the spectator via Sean Connery's voyeuristic gaze as she displays fear of lightening, is a relative, not absolute, stillness.

In her recent work on the relationship between celluloid and digital technologies Mulvey discusses stillness as a concept historically contingent on a technological dialectic of 'old' and 'new', specifically 'how technological change has given a new kind of visibility to stillness as a property of celluloid' (Mulvey, 2003, p. 113). Mulvey argues that new kinds of spectatorship take place when a film is encountered in its digital form, specifically in relation to the viewer's ability to exert more

control over the pace of a film and the order of events. Reflecting on her earlier work on the spectacle of the female star in Hollywood cinema, Mulvey situates her present concerns with spectacle as 'moments of narrative halt, a state of near stillness, that figure the halt and the stillness inherent in the structure of celluloid itself' (Mulvey, 2003, p. 114). She notes the significance of the video cassette recorder in enabling viewers to control the temporal experience of film, for example through repetition of favourite sections, slowing down the pace or halting the sequence of images until what remains is a still. Mulvey argues that the representation of time is given new visibility in a post-VCR age. Here the improved quality of Digital Video Disk technology not only increases the level of control, but sharpens the paused image to a quality more commonly attached to the photograph. The possibility of controlling the filmic image has become widespread since the mid-1970s, which prompts Mulvey to identify a space where the aesthetic dynamics of celluloid and photography meet. It is here that Beecroft's filmed performance is located, somewhere between movement and stasis, while simultaneously reconfiguring the gendered meanings attached to these terms. Movement is not prioritized as the defining feature of film. Furthermore, the work alludes to the way in which viewers can now revisit the stillness inherent in the filmic apparatus by using a number of electronic and digital viewing technologies. *VB29* is not of the order of developmental filmic continuity, but resonates with the repetition and temporary stilling that derives from film, but was more fully exploited by the VCR. Sam Taylor-Johnson also explores the idea of a partial or temporary stilling of movement in her video portrait of David Beckham. In the remainder of the chapter I turn to this film and consider how the temporal ambiguities of both works suggest alternative approaches to criticality.

Criticality and cultural change

Taylor-Johnson sustains an enduring fascination with cinema and its mediation of the human figure. Michael O'Pray picks up on Taylor-Johnson's multiple approaches to time drawn from different types of cinema arguing that 'the vibrant tension in her work is partly the result of this merging of Warhol's minimalist performance-based aesthetic with an ironically delivered, full-blown emotionalism, plucked from key scenes of the work of Cassavetes, Ferrara and Coppola' (1996, unpaginated). There are also references to the strategies of German Marxist avant-garde playwright, poet and theatre director Bertolt

Brecht, in particular the desire to make visible the constructed nature of the filmic or photographic event. This is often achieved by manipulating time, specifically changing the pace of events. In a ten-minute film called *Brontosaurus* (1995), for example, the artist filmed a naked man dancing to techno music and then slowed down the footage and replaced the dance music with Samuel Barber's classical *Adagio for Strings*. Alternatively, *Still Life* (2001) is a three-minute forty-four-second film depicting the accelerated decaying of a bowl of fruit. In *Still Life*, as in *David*, the stylistic conventions of painting (still life and reclining nude respectively) are manipulated using the technological possibilities of film. For Brecht the purpose of raising the spectator's awareness of the constructed nature of the image was to remind them that what they are watching is a representation of reality, not reality itself. It was to heighten their critical faculties by making what happens on stage unfamiliar and strange, opening up a gap between appearance and reality. As a playwright Brecht achieved this by, for example, using songs to punctuate action or directing actors to address the audience, thus destroying the illusion of reality. His intention was to politicize the audience such that they would not accept the reality of their own lives as inevitable or beyond change. The artist is installed as the agent of transformation, tasked with revealing the gap between appearance and reality to the otherwise complicit spectator by opposing the lie of the spectacle. He or she acts by intervening in the machine of the spectacle, thus, as Jacques Rancière notes, 'action is presented as the only answer to the evil of the image and the guilt of the spectator' (2009, p. 87). However, for Rancière it is ultimately the sovereign voice of the 'critical' practitioner that emerges as the real content of critique i.e. the one who proposes the call to action. It is this voice that is counterposed to the falsity of the image, rather than action or opposition. In asking 'why can't you see what I can see?' the sovereign voice of the critical practitioner instantiates its own existence as more critically aware than the spectator.

Brecht's ideas about theatre have been influential in film theory and practice and can be detected in the work of directors such as Jean-Luc Godard and Lars Von Trier. However, despite some audio-visual similarities, Taylor-Johnson's films have been produced in a different cultural context and do not operate in the same way. The kind of temporal play at work in *Still Life* or *Brontosaurus* has long since been co-opted by popular culture via the work of directors such as Quentin Tarantino. We are no longer surprised to see time slowed down, sped up or otherwise manipulated or to have the mechanisms of visual media exposed; for example, via DVD extras such as a director's voice-over.

Taylor-Johnson does not, in my view, use these devices to expose the gap between appearance and reality, which would secure the criticality of her work in Brechtian terms. She does not attempt to transform the viewer into a state of activity, nor install herself as the conveyor of a message. Indeed, Rancière argues that: 'we no longer live in the days when playwrights wanted to explain to their audience the truth of social relations and ways of struggling against capitalist domination' (2009, p. 11). The screen does not function with the same ideological force, given the spectator's loss of innocence in front of the mediated image. The need to interrupt the spectator's passivity in order that he or she actively engages with the image is challenged by theoretical arguments about the activity involved in consumption. Nevertheless, her films have the potential to provoke an intensity of feeling, which Rancière notes is a more common aspiration for contemporary artists (2009, p. 14). Here I want to explore how the temporal play of *David* produces something that cannot be described in terms of transformation, consciousness and defamiliarization, but nevertheless re-orientates our relationship to the objectification of Beckham's image.

Practices of looking

Commissioned in 2004 by the National Portrait Gallery, *David* is a sixty-seven-minute film of British footballing star and celebrity David Beckham sleeping (see figure 7.2). Part of the gallery's permanent collection, the work is a kind of filmed canvas, shot with only the artist and sitter present and lit with one lamp in a darkened room. Here Taylor-Johnson operates simultaneously as filmmaker, artist, collaborator, witness, companion and voyeur, challenging the idea that art emanates from a singular position. Produced on digital video the film is shown on a plasma screen and positioned at eye level in a small room. It was shot after a training session while Beckham was playing for Real Madrid and performs its subject as calm, vulnerable, soft, even serene in contrast to the tough, strong, heroic performance we expect of a footballer. The depiction of vulnerable masculinity is a theme that the artist has explored in other works, notably her *Crying Men* series of photographs for which she asked male actors to cry in front of the lens (2002–2004).

In *David*, the spectatorial expectations of sport, as they are reconfigured in a highly mediatized cultural climate, meet those of the filmic close-up. In contrast to the sports action shot, the photograph that captures a moment of triumph or technical skill, *David* offers an image of calm surrender to the camera's (and spectator's) gaze. Beckham

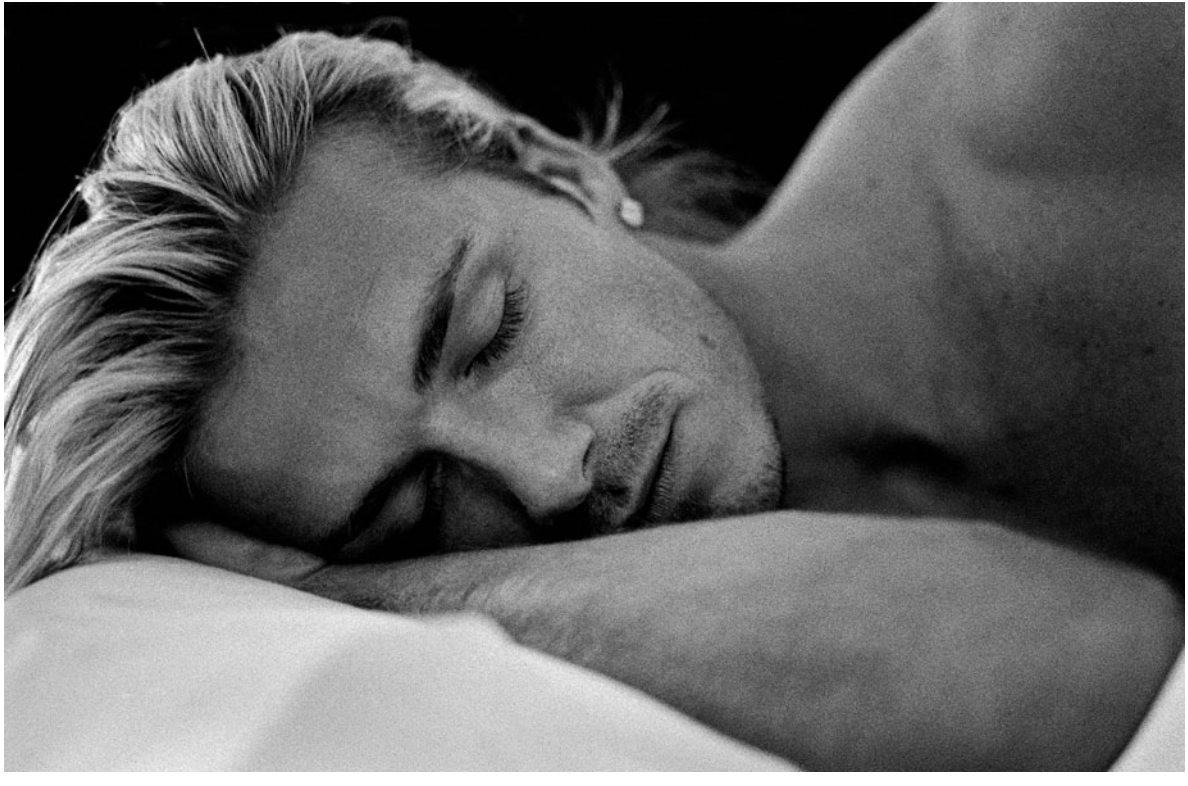


Figure 7.2 Sam Taylor-Johnson (British, b. 1967), *David* (2004), C-Print, 15.75 × 23.63 inches. Copyright the artist and White Cube, London

allows himself to be feminized in the sense that he is willing to occupy a position more often ascribed to women but increasingly experienced and critically examined by men (see, for example, Nixon, 1996; Whannel, 2002). He is lying down, uncovered and visually available. We are presented with the upper half of Beckham's body as landscape to be traversed by our gaze, the queer subtext of the film only heightened by its reference to Warhol's 1963 film *Sleep*, which features over five-and-a-half hours of footage of Warhol's then partner John Giorno sleeping. Taylor-Johnson provides no compensation in the form of motivated action more commonly associated with visually seductive representations of male sports stars; for example, sprinters crossing the finishing line or footballers scoring goals. *David* denies the straight male viewer the possibility of admiring sporting technique, leaving him with nothing but an image of Beckham's body. A gallery audience used to contemplating nudes may not find this challenging, but it does raise the issue of what motivates different practices of looking. Beckham has, after all, been the subject of a wide range of looks from the invested football fan to the celebrity follower to the spectator in a gallery. Just as Beckham traverses multiple cultural institutions (as international footballer, celebrity and artist's collaborator/model) the various practices of looking involved also cross boundaries.

There is a difference between the 'sports gaze', which Rose and Friedman argue is predicated on 'identification, nearness, and participation' (Rose and Friedman, 1997, p. 4) and the libidinal gaze of Taylor-Johnson's film, which is premised on fragmenting and objectifying Beckham's body. If the viewing of sport on television or at live events is characterized by a highly affective commitment and identification with an individual or team (exemplified by shouting at the TV, sitting on the edge of your seat, feeling a sense of anticipation, joy or disappointment) *David* encourages the spectator to engage in a comparatively cool and detached experience. In place of the group activity of sports fandom, which involves strong loyalties, historically enduring rivalries and often group spectatorship, this film is a more individual experience in which the identification encouraged is with Beckham as image rather than with his affiliation to a team or country. However, the representation of sportsmen and women across various media forms is increasingly concerned with the creation of stars, often via the narrativization of their lives on and off the field of play. Thus the sports gaze and libidinal gaze overlap.

This is at least partly as a result of the forms of spectatorship enabled by contemporary viewing technologies. Helicopter shots, close-ups,

multi-angle analysis and slow motion all encourage what David Rowe identifies as a dramaturgical approach in which spectators are inclined to feel that they 'get to know' the sportsmen and women as personalities (Rowe, 1999, p. 155). The different visual apparatuses used have temporal implications, which in turn inform our viewing of *David*. We are used, for example, to the slowing down of sporting action for the purposes of post-event analysis and the production of sporting history through repetition of treasured memories, often in relation to the construction of nationhood such as the England's World Cup win in 1966. Gary Whannel unpacks this in detail identifying five different ways of understanding time in relation to media sport: time as a significant moment (for example, England's winning goal in the aforementioned World Cup); time as the period of performance (for example, Roger Bannister's 'four-minute mile'); time as shared memory; time as a scarce commodity (for example, injury time, extra time, time that is limited); and time understood as a 'golden era' (Whannel, 2002, pp. 52–53). I would add to this list a sense of futurity, which is often coupled with disappointment and high expectations; for example, an as-yet unrealized era of renewed success. If and when success does arrive it is often grounded simultaneously in the present tense (his/her time is now) and in relation to the past tense (the wait is over). All of this adds to the drama of sport as numerous fora such as television, radio, advertising, newspapers and social media mediate it. The increasingly melodramatic representation of sports stars within popular culture already crosses genres. Rowe argues that televised sport draws on the physicality of 'action' drama as well as the emotional currency of 'human' drama (Rowe, 1999, p. 154). This is extended in *David* by the references to avant-garde film such as the lack of narrative and fixed camera. It sits between the temporal manipulations of popular culture, exemplified by sports coverage, and an avant-garde tradition of cinema that challenged the illusions of narrative time.

The notion of the individual footballer as a unit of analysis upon which the camera fixes/fixates has been explored previously, notably in Hellmuth Costard's *Football As Never Before* (1970) in which eight cameras follow Manchester United winger George Best's real-time movements in a league match against Coventry. Two years after Taylor-Johnson produced her film, Douglas Gordon and Philippe Parreno directed *Zidane: A 21st Century Portrait* (2006), in which the camera follows the French star for the duration of a match between Real Madrid and Villarreal (Beckham also features as one of Zidane's team mates). Whereas Costard's film of George Best was unusual in its focus on Best's

movements alone, by 2004 we were all too familiar with Beckham as image/text. The drive to get closer to the game as it is played in Costard's film is transformed into the desire for intimacy and proximity to one of its stars in Taylor-Johnson's portrait. Both Gordon and Parreno's film of Zidane and Costard's film of Best examine their subject in the context of the action on the field, thus going some way towards compensating for the libidinal gaze. In each case there is a climax: Best scores a goal and Zidane is sent off. This is, however, absent in Taylor-Johnson's film of Beckham, which offers no teleological momentum towards narrative fulfilment. His near-still presence upsets the logic of an earlier moment of feminist film theory in which masculine activity and movement was distinguished from feminine passivity and pause. Within the internal logic of the film Beckham is reanimated back into small movements but not action. Like Warhol's *Sleep* there is no story within the film itself, but it is part of the wider dramatization of Beckham as a commodity and national celebrity/ambassador.

It is tempting to read this trajectory of films by Costard, Taylor-Johnson, and Gordon/Parreno as a gradual shift from the sports gaze to the libidinal gaze in the context of increased commodification of technical skill. Not surprisingly, the film of Zidane is a more polished production than Costard's much earlier representation of Best. Nevertheless, there is a segment in *Football As Never Before* that resembles Warhol's *Screen Tests*, short filmic portraits of friends, celebrities and regulars at the Factory studio made between 1964–1966. During the half-time interval we follow Best down a corridor and into a room where he turns to face the camera. For over two minutes Best holds the camera's gaze in a thinly veiled homoerotic interlude of pure spectacle. However, whereas now both popular culture and cultural criticism understand masculinity as plural and contested, in the early 1970s the British working-class football culture did not allow heterosexual hegemonic masculinity to be destabilized. Nevertheless, Best was represented, albeit for an audience of avant-garde cinema, as spectacle to be devoured. The films by Taylor-Johnson and Gordon/Parreno are not, therefore, the end point of a straightforward, linear developmental trajectory that turns athletes into celebrities as if this is somehow inevitable and unstoppable, but part of a history of representations of footballers that has often combined appreciation of their technical skill with the visual pleasure of their bodies. Cigarette cards featuring sports stars first appeared in the late 19th century and were aimed predominantly at men because they were the main consumers of cigarettes. The cards focused attention on faces and names, thus increasing familiarity

with individuals (Whannel, 2002, p. 32). The hyper-commodification of sports stars is a recent development, fuelled by sponsorship deals and a multi-platform mode of consumption, but needs to be considered within the context of a longer history of familiarization.

Intimate near-stillness

The tendency to identify with a sports star as a familiar personality is extended by the intimacy of *David*, in particular its capacity to position the spectator as if lying next to the subject, examining his face as you might a lover who sleeps. The aspiration to intimacy is problematic for a feminist critical trajectory of radical practice that takes its cues from a Marxist/Brechtian tradition of defamiliarization and critical distance. It appears too close, too invested, too interested for the artist-filmmaker to establish a sovereign critical voice. The screen acts as a highly reflective surface and far from establishing a gap between reality and appearance overlays the spectator's image on to Beckham's. The screen enables a kind of intimacy that the spectator is unlikely to experience in any tangible sense. Watching the film gave me a sense of catching someone whose image is so carefully manufactured in an unguarded moment. The film appears to give the spectator a licence to study the subject's face and torso as a painterly text, filling the screen with his image and turning him into a fetish object. It uses the language of feminist film theory – objectification, fetishism, voyeurism – to examine masculine vulnerability.

On first sight the stillness of the screen image permits an enduring gaze and in this sense *David* differs from Cornelia Parker's disconcerting installation *The Maybe*, a collaboration with actress Tilda Swinton, who lay, apparently asleep, inside a vitrine within the Serpentine Gallery, London, in 1995. The screen adds a level of permission to look that was denied by Parker's live event. However, *David* is not completely still and despite its mediation by the screen the small movements have the capacity to temper the spectator's voyeurism, generating an anxiety that its subject might stir or even wake and return our gaze. Where one cannot help but notice that in Costard's film Best does not move a great deal, spending most of his time standing around waiting for the ball to come to him rather than running to get it, Beckham is surprisingly agile in his sleep, turning his head and rearranging his arms as he sinks further into the pillow. The moments of intimate near-stillness within the film draw attention to its materiality, the photographic registration of the film strip, as well as the materiality of Beckham as a text.

Furthermore, the absence of narrative drive, lack of sound and possessive focus on the subject to the exclusion of anything else emphasizes Beckham's performance of affective labour as opposed to physical or financial labour.

There is a restlessness about the film, which, like Beecroft's *VB29*, situates it between the stillness of the photographic moment and the movement of film. The spectator's investment in the temporalities of VHS and DVD, in particular the ability to change the pace of movement, organize viewing according to DVD chapters, or turn the continuity of film into a still, is fed back into the production of *David*. In short, where Warhol's *Sleep* (and *Screen Tests*) anticipates the spectator's desire to still the movement of film, the technology for which was made widely available 20 years later in the 1980s, *David* was produced in the context of a post-VHS form of spectatorship in which there is no desire to repress stillness in the pursuit of an illusion of realism. In my reading Taylor-Johnson does not remind the spectator of the stillness within the moving image out of a need to illuminate something otherwise hidden; she does not hope to activate the otherwise passive spectator by demonstrating the constructed nature of film. Instead she highlights the combination of pleasure and reflection that accompanies our viewing. *David* exists between what Mulvey calls the pensive spectator, who reflects on the visibility of time (a thought process enhanced by post-VHS forms of spectatorship) and the possessive spectator, who is fetishistically absorbed by the image of the body (Mulvey, 2006). As Mulvey acknowledges these categories overlap such that the pensive spectator is never completely detached from fetishism and, I would add, criticism is never completely detached from pleasure.

In *David* a series of temporalities drawn from different media forms fold into one another. The film reaches back to a classical painterly tradition of sleeping nudes, but also refers to the individual frame of film, which in Warhol's case was imagined within the continual present-tense flow of television. *David* simultaneously employs the temporality of the repeat and of the pause, which temporarily halts continuity. Different periods of historical time overlap with the temporalities of historically specific technologies. Time is not fixed in the past despite reference to the photographic frozen moment, but neither does it reside entirely in the 'now', a perpetual present set loose from the past. The 'now' of continuity, movement, duration and the moment of our viewing folds into the 'then' of stillness, pastness and death so often associated with the photographic moment of registration. The film's near-still quality sets up an indexical relation to the past by reminding the

spectator of the photographic footprint of an event that once occurred, but only for stillness to melt into slight movement. Beckham is not embalmed as in a photographic still and neither does the screen offer the certainty of a waxwork. The apparently inanimate still is occasionally reanimated before settling again, not brought back to life so much as stirred from the certainty of death, a temporary revival rather than a resurrection. The transition from inanimate to animate is not complete, but fluctuating and partial. Cinema's uncertain relationship to life and death, animate and inanimate, is rendered even more ambiguous when this relation represents sleep, itself redolent of fantasies and dreams, qualities of cinematic spectatorship as well as of sleep. The interaction between the time of photography and that of film is overlaid on to the undulating time of dreams and sleep; for example, the feeling that you have been asleep for hours when only five minutes have passed, or the confused time of dreams in which events drawn from different eras of your life appear contemporaneous. In short, time does not stay in its place. Neither the 'now' of continual filmic movement nor the 'then' of photographic stillness remain intact as stable categories. In Taylor-Johnson's film we are somehow held in the expanded moment even though we know that sleep is durational. Here it is not so much stillness as a relation to the past that is brought into visibility, but the unsettling of the stillness/movement binary. *David* occupies the space in between for which we have no developed conceptual language.

This creates a visual disturbance without the artist positioning herself as the one who knows or as the agent of transformation. Despite the apparent (but as I hope to have argued, not actual) idleness of the two films under discussion in this chapter the real lack of action is perceived to reside with the spectator. The idea that spectators are in need of transformation by 'critical' filmmakers instils a hierarchical division between maker and spectator, which is destabilized by a networked digital culture in which the boundary between producers and consumers is increasingly permeable (Jenkins, 2006). Spectators do not need to be transformed into actors because they are already actors. In relation to *VB29* and *David*, spectators are potentially engaged in the transference of different practices of looking, the navigation of different temporal modes and movement between a range of cultural forms. It is the structural distinction between viewing and acting that is problematic in Brechtian-informed approaches to critical practice. In contrast Rancière argues that, 'emancipation begins when we challenge the opposition between viewing and acting', which is itself part of the structure of domination that needs to be undone (2009, p. 13).

The unsettling nature of Taylor-Johnson's *David* and Beecroft's *VB29* does not depend upon the taking up of a position that can be defended. It does not equip the spectator with the means to see through the image to the social reality beyond and there is no call to action. There is no attempt to shock the viewer out of their desire, curiosity or boredom. Certainly, these films do not do the same kind of political work as Ackerman's *Jeanne Dielman, 23, quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* or Mulvey and Wollen's *Riddles of the Sphinx*. However, in the dissociation of movement from action, which is enabled by the films' semi-stillness, temporal relations can be reconfigured within the world of appearances, along with their attachments to gendered expectations. These films are examples of a disquieting aesthetic, which is informed by identification, intimacy and temporal agitation, and thus offer a different orientation towards criticality.

Notes

Introduction

1. Kristeva argues that this third generation challenges the 'dichotomy man/woman as an opposition between two rival entities', which it understands as 'belonging to metaphysics' (1981, p. 33).
2. Saundra Goldman reads Wilke's robed figure, with which the sequence begins, as Mary Magdalen (1998, p. 22).
3. Meskimmon's discussion of global cartographies is a contribution to the catalogue that accompanies 'WACK!'. A spatialized conceptualization of feminist art history enables a geopolitical discussion in which the dominance of American and English artists as definitive of feminist art practice is repositioned, thus encouraging new affinities between works made in different geographical, cultural and political contexts.

1 Fantasies of Adventure, Escape and Return: Tracey Emin's *Why I Never Became a Dancer*

1. See Lauren Berlant's work on sex and citizenship (Berlant, 2002) as well as her analysis of the 'crisis within the ordinary' (Berlant, 2008, pp. 4–9). Kathleen Stewart also explores the affective quality of everyday life as a way to make sense of the ordinary as a political site (Stewart, 2007).
2. For further information see Felski, 2000; Giles, 2004, as well as Johnson and Lloyd, 2004.
3. For an insider's view of Womanhouse see Faith Wilding's account of the project's development and critical reception (Wilding, online). See also an essay by Paula Harper who originally suggested the project (Harper, 1985, pp. 762–781) and Miriam Schapiro's account of the event (Schapiro, 1972, pp. 268–270).

2 Traces of Feminist Art: Temporal Complexity in the Work of Eleanor Antin and Elizabeth Manchester

1. The connections and tensions between artworks produced and received within different spatio-temporal contexts is also a central concern in Amelia Jones' writing on Judy Chicago (1996). Jones offers a critical context for Chicago's landmark installation *The Dinner Party* (1979), and her curatorship of the exhibition to which her writing refers places Chicago's piece alongside other feminist works, which enables consideration of the history of the reception of *The Dinner Party*.
2. My aim is not to offer a periodizing account, nor to offer a matrilineage of the sort encouraged by Mira Schor in an article written for *Art Journal* in 1991, although it should be noted that the catalogue produced for the group

show entitled 'Apparition: the Action of Appearing', in which Manchester's piece was exhibited at the Arnolfini, Bristol, in 2002, makes no mention of the Antin piece also shown at the Arnolfini just a year earlier. Instead curator Roger Malbert establishes Elizabeth Manchester's patrilineage by relating her interest in self-portraiture and costume to Rembrandt.

3. See Foucault (1991) in which the notion of self-regulating 'docile bodies' is proposed using Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon. See Kember (1995) for a useful application of Panopticism in relation to medical imaging technologies.
4. Much has been written about Beecroft outside the art press, including appearances in *Vogue* magazine and reviews in broadsheet newspapers that pay attention not only to the treatment of femininity in Beecroft's work, but to her own relationship with femininity. For example, a review of a performance event at Berlin's New National Gallery, *VB55*, contextualizes Beecroft's work in terms of her 'long struggle with bulimia' and 'obsessive relationship with food since her early teens' (Harding, 2005, p. 5).
5. Eleanor Antin had already explored a number of stereotypes prior to Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* series. In Antin's performance works of the early 1970s she took on the female personae of a ballerina, black movie star, a nurse, as well as a male character in the form of a king.

3 Sexuality, Loss and Maternal Desire in the Work of Carolee Schneemann and Tracey Emin

1. Carolee Schneemann's *Interior Scroll* has been frequently cited in anthologies of feminist and body art, including Norma Broude and Mary Garrard's *The Power of Feminist Art* (1994) and, more recently, Helena Rekitt and Peggy Phelan's *Art and Feminism* (2001).
2. For a detailed historical account of the position of women artists as object and subject, model and artist, see Meskimmon, 1996, pp. 15–63.
3. These are ideas which, as Betterton has argued in relation to early 20th-century works by Paula Modersohn-Becker and Käthe Kollwitz, have traditionally been kept apart (Betterton, 1996, p. 20).
4. Schneemann made a line drawing of *Interior Scroll*, which depicts a figure with one leg on a stool pulling a strip of paper from her vagina. The style of drawing bears an uncanny resemblance to Emin's monoprints and can be found on the artist's website – see http://www.caroleeschneemann.com/interiorscroll2.html.
5. There is a distinction to be made between media forms and what Auslander terms mediatization, used in Frederic Jameson's sense of a 'mediatic system' (Jameson, 1991). Emin's *I've Got It All* suitably demonstrates Jameson's definition of 'the process whereby the traditional fine arts … come to consciousness of themselves as various media within a mediatic system' (Jameson, 1991, p. 162).

4 Feminist Narratives and Unfaithful Repetition: Hannah Wilke's *Starification Object Series*

1. The temporality of this process was explored by the participants of Judy Chicago and Miriam Schapiro's 'Womanhouse' project (1972). A piece

entitled *Léah's Room* consisted of a young woman repeatedly making herself up, wiping off the cosmetics, then making herself up again.
2. Parker and Pollock's edited collection *Framing Feminism* (1987) is particularly interesting in terms of feminist critical historiography because it both preserves feminist documents that may otherwise not have survived in the public domain and positions its archive material in relation to a critical account of the artworks and ideas of the period (1970–1985). Parker and Pollock's approach is both archival and critical.
3. For Fuss, these questions arise from her discussion of Frantz Fanon's work on the French colonialists' desire to unveil Algerian women. The relationship between impersonation and identification is mapped on to the colonialist requirement that Algerian women be Europeanized (Fuss, 1995, pp. 149–165).
4. Lewis argues that in perpetuating the idea of a silenced woman, the harem stereotype misunderstands the ways in which Ottoman women manipulated cultural codes (Lewis, 2004, p. 7).

5 Critical Mimesis: Hannah Wilke's Double Address

1. Whitford notes that the association of Irigaray's work with essentialism obscured from view interpretations informed by Derrida's critique of metaphysics. However, Carolyn Burke was interpreting Irigaray in relation to Derrida's work as far back as 1981 (Whitford, 1994, p. 16).
2. Ellsworth and Takemoto have explored the notion of empathy in other works, particularly after 1993 when Ellsworth was diagnosed with lymphoma. In a project called *Imag(in)ed Malady*, which is part of the Her/She Senses series, the artists investigate their differing emotional responses to cancer using documentary and staged photographs, which they call 'visual rhymes' (Takemoto, online). Their reflective approach to their own relationship as long-distance friends and artistic collaborators, coupled with the subject matter of this work and medium used, resonates with Wilke's earlier photographs of her mother who endured a long struggle against cancer between 1978 and 1982. In *Portrait of the Artist with her Mother, Selma Butter* (1978–1981) Wilke presents the viewer with a photographic diptych in which her mother's post-mastectomy body is in stark contrast with Wilke's youthful, healthy body. This work and others in which the artist photographed her mother are particularly poignant when considered in the context of Wilke's own battle with lymphoma from which she died in 1993.
3. Doane notes the pervasiveness of these ideas, which are premised on the Freudian distinction between seeing and knowing. This is understood as simultaneous for girls – there is no time lapse between seeing the penis and understanding that they do not have it. For boys, on the other hand, the look is followed by the threat of castration – what Doane describes as 'the perception of an absence rather than a presence … the woman's "nothing to see"' (Doane, 1991, p. 45). The temporality implied by this second stage forges a distance between looking and knowing that operates as a blueprint for fetishism. The boy is able to revisit the image and avoid the overpresence that Doane refers to in relation to girls.
4. For more detail on Irigaray's dialogue with Freud in relation to lesbianism and mainstream film see Christine Holmlund, 1989.

6 Smooth Surfaces and Flattened Fantasies: Thoughts on Criticality in Sam Taylor-Johnson's *Soliloquy III*

1. This point has been made in relation to Taylor-Johnson's work by Bruce Ferguson who describes the 'full collapse of distinctions between disciplines – high and low culture; academia and entertainment; empirical and conceptual research' as a context for her work (Ferguson, 1998, p. 11). Although I think this contextual framework is important, Ferguson overstates the reach of the argument. While the premises upon which differences between 'high' and 'low' culture have often been based may have changed, it does not necessarily follow that the distinctions have fully collapsed.
2. The *Rokeby Venus* was appropriated by British store Habitat to promote a range of interior design products for the December 2006 Christmas period. Postcards were available to pick up in store promoting Habitat's 'Vive la Différence' range. The notion of 'making up' was emphasized not only in relation to the interior (quilt and bed linen), which was the product being advertised, but also the Venus herself, whose make-up case could be seen on the left-hand side of the bed in Habitat's version of the image. The transformation of an interior space runs alongside the transformation of oneself and the addition of the make-up case indicates that both involve a degree of work.
3. Hentschel describes Suzie Bick's pose in *Soliloquy III* as precisely the same as that adopted by the female nude in Velázquez's the *Rokeby Venus* (Hentschel, 2000, p. 14). However, I argue that there are important differences between the works in terms of the angle of vision and the resulting dynamic between invitation and exclusion in the respective works.
4. Here my reading differs from the artist's own interpretation of this work, which posits a distinction between the ideal beauty of the Venus and the sexual deviancy of her fantasy. 'You have the beautiful *Rokeby Venus* lying on the bed and then underneath are her filthy, sordid thoughts of an orgy going on. So it's taking that beautiful painting which seems to be about beauty and purity and showing an underside of narcissism, decadence and sexual desire' (Taylor-Johnson in conversation with O'Pray in Hentschel, 2000, p. 114).
5. The notion of breaking the seal of the female nude has been explored through feminist challenges to the significance of wholeness in patriarchal understandings of the female body. See, for example, Mary Douglas ([1966] 1991) on the transgression of boundaries and the threat of transitional states, and Julia Kristeva (1982) on abjection and the in-between.
6. The depth of feeling about crimes against femininity has been highlighted in recent years by the controversy surrounding Marcus Harvey's portrait of Myra Hindley, *Myra* (1995), which gained widespread attention when it was exhibited at the *Sensation* show at London's Royal Academy in 1997. The unimaginable horror of Hindley's crimes was understood not only as a series of crimes against her child victims, but also as crimes against femininity, which prompted questions about how a woman could have ignored her maternal instinct to protect.
7. There are exceptions such as Amelia Jones' brilliant chapter on Pipilotti Rist (2006, pp. 207–238), but feminist art history has been wary of putting artists who work within the vocabulary of pop culture at the heart of its enquiry.

8. The arrangement of bodies, space and light in the *Soliloquy* series is reminiscent of Foucault's interpretation of Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon, an 18th-century prison design. Foucault argued that the Panopticon's mechanism of surveillance made it an extremely efficient 'laboratory of power' (Foucault, 1991, p. 204). Prisoners arranged in a peripheric ring become totally visible to the centrally positioned guard who, whilst able to see all, remains unseen himself and, therefore, surplus to requirements. In the context of an increase in disciplinary mechanisms during the 17th and 18th centuries, in which the notion of surveillance takes over from more overt and physical forms of social control, the anticipation of the gaze results in the self-regulation of bodies. Although Taylor-Johnson's *Soliloquy III* does not isolate its characters (unlike the Panoptic regime they can see each other), it is useful to think about the work in terms of Foucault's reading of the power produced by Panoptic (in) visibility.

7 Near-Stillness in the Art Films of Sam Taylor-Johnson and Vanessa Beecroft

1. The material conditions of production for Beecroft's performance *VB46*, Los Angeles 2001, are critiqued by Julia Steinmetz, Heather Cassils and Clover Leary in a scathing attack published in *Signs* (Spring 2006). Cassils and Leary successfully auditioned as models for this performance and use their first-hand experience to challenge what they understand to be the dominant reading of Beecroft's work, which is that the performances are 'living paintings' in which viewers are confronted in the flesh by women more often seen as images (Hickey, 2000). The authors emphasize the indignity involved in having their bodies spray painted for the performance and being given instructions about how to behave throughout. Cassils had intended to sabotage the performance by inserting an egg inside her vagina and letting it fall and crack on to the gallery floor, but decided against this in the end preferring to let the inclusion of their queer bodies enact a more nuanced critique.
2. There is a history to the imposition of stillness, which is tied to the history of cinematic consumption. Stezaka notes that many promotion stills, shot after the movie for the purposes of advertising film posters, flooded second-hand book shops in the late 1970s as a result of the widespread closure of single-screen cinemas. Alongside this change in film distribution was the need to dispense with publicity material owned by cinemas that had closed down (Stezaka, 2006, p. 113).
3. David Campany has also observed the complexities of the relationship between acting as a time-based activity and posing as something related to stillness, with reference to devices such as the *tableau vivant* and the cinematic close-up (Campany, 2006, pp. 97–112).
4. Here there is an interesting difference between *VB29*, in which stillness cannot be grasped, and *VB35*, which attempts stillness until it is painful both physically for the models who are dressed in spike heels and, in some cases, aesthetically for those who watch.

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